APHOTIC REVELATION





In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.

GENESIS 1:1 (AV) · IN UNCONTRACTED ENGLISH BRAILLE

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APHOTIC REVELATION

Haptic Scripture, Katechontic Custody, and the Anarchival Covenant in The Book of Eli



A HEXAEMERAL READING

@ertertwert

NOV 5, 2026

Aphotic Revelation: Haptic Scripture, Katechontic Custody, and the Anarchival Covenant in The Book of Eli

Nov 5, 2026 · @ertertwert

Set in EB Garamond, with Cormorant Garamond and Cinzel for display. The braille throughout (on the frontispiece, the part openers, and beneath every folio) is uncontracted English braille, drawn as dots rather than set in a braille font.

Abstract

THIS thesis argues that *The Book of Eli* (dir. Albert and Allen Hughes; screenplay by Gary Whitta; Alcon Entertainment and Silver Pictures for Warner Bros., 2010) constitutes the most rigorous popular-cinematic articulation of what I term **aphotic revelation**: a mode of disclosure that, after an apocalypse conceived as a terminal event of light, can no longer proceed through the ocular economy that has governed Western concepts of truth from Plato's sun to the nuclear flash (*theōria*, illumination, *apokalypsis* as unveiling-to-sight), and must instead be routed through the haptic, the acoustic, and the mnemonic. Reading the film *figurally*, against the typological matrices of Eli of Shiloh, Elijah and Elisha, Ezra the scribe, and Paul of Tarsus, and *constellationally*, against Bunyan, Miller, Bradbury, McCarthy, Eco, Dostoevsky, Hobbes, Spinoza, Benjamin, Derrida, Levinas, Agamben and Virilio, I contend that the film stages a sixfold passage of the Word (*phonē*, haptic *grammē*, *mnēmē*, *typos*, *archeion*, *hodos*) through which scripture survives its own instrumentalization only by being withheld from sovereignty (**katechontic custody**), incorporated into a mortal body (the Pauline "fleshy tables of the heart"), and released, not into a new theocracy, but into a plural, non-sovereign archive and onto an open road.

Against the Hobbesian-Rousseauian logic of scriptural sovereignty embodied by Carnegie, whose hydraulic despotism recognizes in the Bible the only technology of domination capable of scaling beyond the reach of a well, the film opposes neither the secular iconoclasm of its backstory (the post-war burning of Bibles) nor confessional triumphalism, but an **anarchival covenant**: a custodianship of the *arkhē* as commencement ("In the beginning") that renounces the *arkhē* as commandment.

Six subsidiary claims are developed. First, the climactic illegibility of the Braille codex to the sighted tyrant constitutes an **inverse Molyneux scene** that vindicates Berkeley's heterogeneity of the visible and the tangible while inverting the Black Atlantic trope of the Talking Book. Second, the narrative is architected by **Malachi 4** (the day that burns as an oven, the Sun of righteousness, the Elijah who turns the hearts of the fathers to the children), and its protagonist is a **post-eschatological Elijah**, arriving after the day he was sent to precede. Third, the dictation at Alcatraz is the latest variant of a transcultural **mytheme of scriptural restitution** (Ezra in 4 Ezra 14, Fu Sheng after the Qin burning, Matsya's recovery of the Vedas, the Avestan recompilation, the post-Yamama codification of the Qur'an). Fourth,

Claudia's refusal to read is the film's decisive political act: a Bartlebyan potentiality-not-to that collapses scriptural sovereignty at the level of the reader. Fifth, the final shelving of the printed Bible between the Tanakh and the Qur'an enacts Lessing's ring parable as a museological gesture, suspended between Agamben's museification and profanation. Sixth, the Elijah-Elisha transfer of the mantle to Solara institutionally separates letter (archive) from spirit (road) in a configuration that disarms the Pauline "letter that killeth."

The thesis is organized as a hexaemeron, six "days" and a Sabbath on the model of Basil's and Bonaventure's commentaries on the creation week, because the film's own climax is a cosmogonic recitation: a dying man dictating "In the beginning" to a scribe on an island at the western edge of a burned world. It concludes with an "eighth day," the patristic name for the beginning of another world, which I propose as the proper name of the post-apocalyptic condition: neither the end nor the return, but the commencement that follows completion.

Contents



PROLEGOMENA

Tohu wa-Bohu 1

The Uncreated World and the Question of the Book

0.1 The Object and Its Conditions · 0.2 The Historical Moment: The Apocalyptic Cluster of 2009–2010 · 0.3 Composite Authorship as a Theological Problem · 0.4 Lineage: The Archival Post-Apocalypse · 0.5 Method: Hand, Figure, Constellation · 0.6 Architecture: An Itinerary in Six Days



DAY ONE

Fiat Flamma 11

The Flash, the Ruin of the Visible, and the Necessity of Aphotic Revelation

1.1 Anti-Creation: The Light That Precedes No Sun · 1.2 Nuclear Optics: The Bomb as Light-Weapon · 1.3 Overexposure: The Film Image as Burn · 1.4 The Sun Inverted: Ocularcentrism After Its Apotheosis · 1.5 The Genealogy of the Blind Seer · 1.6 The Inverse Molyneux Scene · 1.7 Aphotic Revelation Defined



DAY TWO

The Firmament Dividing the Waters 21

Hydraulic Sovereignty and the Scriptural Supplement

2.1 Hydraulic Sovereignty · 2.2 The Scalability Thesis · 2.3 The Name of the Warlord · 2.4 "It Has Happened Before": A Genealogy of Instrumental Scripture · 2.5 The Iconoclasts: The Other Answer to Carnegie · 2.6 Claudia's Refusal · 2.7 The Captured Ark and the Wounded King



DAY THREE

Let the Dry Land Appear 35

Road, Frontier, Pilgrimage, and the Seed of the Word

3.1 Westward the Course of Empire · 3.2 The Stranger Who Comes to Town · 3.3 The Pilgrim's Regress: Bunyan After the Flash · 3.4 Dust Bowl and Open Road · 3.5 Ely and Eli: The Apophatic and the Cataphatic Prophet · 3.6 The Psalter Triptych: Psalm 22, Psalm 23, Psalm 24 · 3.7 The Seed Is the Word



DAY FOUR

Lights for Signs and Seasons 45

Malachian Architecture and the Post-Eschatological Katechon

4.1 The Time of the End · 4.2 Malachian Architecture · 4.3 The Post-Eschatological Elijah · 4.4 The Katechon: He Who Withholds · 4.5 Signs: Providence and Hesitation · 4.6 Solara: The Sun of Righteousness



DAY FIVE

Let the Waters Swarm and the Fowl Fly 53

Voice, Vocation, and the Media A Priori of Blindness

5.1 Vocation: The Voice in the Rubble · 5.2 Conviction and Responsibility: The Saint with a Sword · 5.3 Hearing as Obedience: The Acoustic Covenant · 5.4 Secondary Orality and the Phonographic Relic · 5.5 Night Writing: The Military Origin of Aphotic Script · 5.6 The Fifth Day's Creatures: Cat, Raven, Pelican, Albatross



DAY SIX

Let Us Make Man 63

Cannibal and Eucharistic Tables, the Face, and the Fleshy Tables of the Heart

6.1 The Image After the Image · 6.2 Three Tables and a Scroll · 6.3 The Priest Who Passed By · 6.4 The Black Custodian and the Talking Book · 6.5 Mothers, Daughters, and the Decisive Margin · 6.6 Disability Beyond the Blind Seer · 6.7 The Fleshy Tables of the Heart



DAY SEVEN

Sabbath of the Book 75

Dictation, Press, Shelf, and Mantle

7.1 The Island · 7.2 Dictation and the Mytheme of Restitution · 7.3 The Press: *Typos* and *Figura* · 7.4 The Shelf: Rings and Books · 7.5 The Mantle and the Letter · 7.6 Franciscan Coda: The Canticle of the Creatures



THE EIGHTH DAY

Octava Dies 89

Toward an Anarchival Covenant

8.1 The Week and Its Remainder · 8.2 The Sixfold Passage of the Word · 8.3 The Anarchival Covenant · 8.4 Through a Glass, Darkly · 8.5 Into Life

Works Cited 97

Keywords 101

For we walk by faith, not by sight.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:7 (AV)

• • •

And the word of the LORD *was precious in those days; there was no open vision. And it came to pass at that time, when Eli was laid down in his place, and his eyes began to wax dim, that he could not see; and ere the lamp of God went out in the temple of the* LORD*, where the ark of God was, and Samuel was laid down to sleep; that the* LORD *called Samuel.*

1 SAMUEL 3:1–4 (AV)

• • •

Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path.

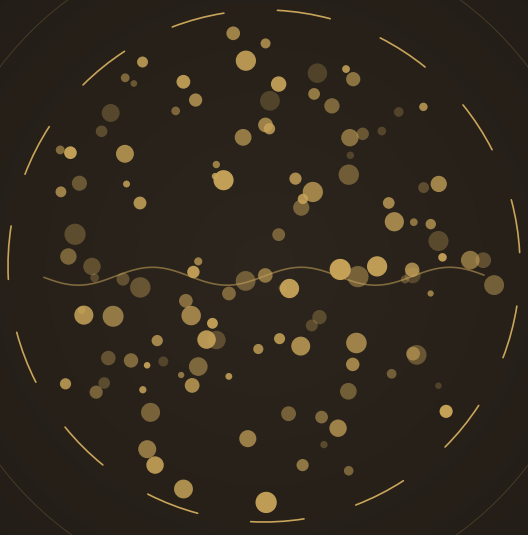
PSALM 119:105 (AV)

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A note on citation. Scripture is cited from the Authorized (King James) Version of 1611, the version the film names, and other public-domain texts are quoted in their classic English translations. Copyrighted modern works, including the film's own dialogue, are paraphrased or quoted only in brief phrases. Classical and early-modern works are cited by their standard internal divisions; modern works by author and date of first publication, with translations indicated in the Works Cited.

PROLEGOMENA

תֹהוּ וָבֹהוּ



Tohu wa-Bohu

The Uncreated World and the Question of the Book

I beheld the earth, and, lo, it was without form,
and void; and the heavens, and they had no light.

JEREMIAH 4:23 (AV)

0.1

The Object and Its Conditions

The object of this study is a film whose narrative premise can be stated in a sentence and whose implications cannot be exhausted in a volume. Thirty years after a war remembered by its survivors as "the flash," a solitary man walks westward across the burned interior of North America carrying what he believes to be the last extant copy of the Bible, guided by a voice he heard in the ruins and protected, he claims, by the same agency that summoned him. In a scavenger town he encounters Carnegie, a literate warlord who has monopolized the settlement's water and who has spent years dispatching illiterate gangs to recover precisely this book, which he regards not as a text but as an instrument of rule. The walker refuses Carnegie's offer of patronage, is pursued, is shot, surrenders the codex to save the life of Solara, the young woman who has followed him, and nonetheless completes his journey to Alcatraz, where a community of archivists is rebuilding a library of the destroyed world. There he dictates the entire scripture from memory before dying. Carnegie, meanwhile, unlocks the captured codex and discovers that it is written in Braille; the walker has been blind throughout. The only person in Carnegie's domain capable of reading it, his blind consort Claudia, declines to do so, and his town disintegrates around his festering wound. On the island the dictated text is set in type, printed, and shelved between a Tanakh and a Qur'an; Solara, now wearing the dead man's gear and carrying his blade, sets out alone onto the mainland road.

The film was directed by the twin brothers Albert and Allen Hughes, their first feature since *From Hell* (2001), from an original screenplay by Gary Whitta, a London-born former video-game journalist and editor whose later credits would include the story for *Rogue One* (2016). It stars Denzel Washington as Eli, Gary Oldman as Carnegie, Mila Kunis as Solara, Jennifer Beals as Claudia, and Ray Stevenson as Carnegie's lieutenant Redridge, with Tom Waits as the trader known only as the Engineer, Michael Gambon and Frances de la Tour as the homesteaders George and Martha, and Malcolm McDowell as Lombardi, the curator of the Alcatraz archive. Don Burgess's digital cinematography, shot largely in the deserts of New Mexico, renders the world in a bleached, desaturated register that I will read in Day One as the photographic trace of overexposure; Atticus Ross's score works in long, low drones against which the film's few diegetic songs, above all Al Green's 1972 recording of "How Can You Mend a Broken Heart" on Eli's battered iPod, sound like messages from a vanished civilization. The film was released in the United States in January 2010 by Warner Bros. to commercial success and divided criticism: devotional audiences embraced it as a rare mainstream affirmation of scripture, while much secular criticism dismissed it as a violent action vehicle with a Bible for a MacGuffin. This thesis contends that both receptions mistake the film's object. The Book of Eli is not a film *about* the Bible in the sense of either advocacy or exploitation. It is a film about what scripture is, materially, politically, and phenomenologically, when the conditions that made it legible have been destroyed.

0.2

The Historical Moment: The Apocalyptic Cluster of 2009–2010

The film belongs to an extraordinary cluster of North American apocalyptic and post-apocalyptic releases bracketing the turn of 2010: John Hillcoat's adaptation of Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* (November 2009), Roland Emmerich's *2012* (November 2009), Shane Acker's *9* (September 2009), Ruben Fleischer's *Zombieland* (October 2009), McG's *Terminator Salvation* (May 2009), and, within weeks of *Eli* itself, the angelic-apocalyptic *Legion* and the vampiric *Daybreakers* (both January 2010). The cluster is legible against three overlapping crises. The first is economic: the financial collapse of 2008 had made the sudden disappearance of a civilization's infrastructure of value an experienced rather than merely imagined possibility, and scarcity-economies of the kind the film depicts (water, batteries, moist towelettes, boots stripped from corpses) acquired an uncanny proximity. The second is geopolitical: the attacks of 11 September 2001, in which nineteen hijackers acting for al-Qaeda, a movement that claimed a religious warrant for mass murder, killed nearly three thousand people, and the US-led invasion of Iraq in March 2003, justified in large part by claims that Iraq possessed weapons of mass destruction, claims the Iraq Survey Group's final report of 2004 found to be unfounded, had together installed, as a structuring presupposition of public discourse, the proposition that religious conviction and weapons of mass destruction might converge in civilizational catastrophe. The third, inseparable from the second, is intellectual: the so-called New Atheism of Sam Harris's *The End of Faith* (2004), Richard Dawkins's *The God Delusion* (2006), Daniel Dennett's *Breaking the Spell* (2006), and Christopher Hitchens's *God Is Not Great* (2007) had made the thesis that faith is a civilizational hazard a bestselling commonplace. Harris's argument in particular, that the conjunction of unfalsifiable belief with nuclear capability constitutes an existential threat, reads in retrospect as the screenplay of the film's prehistory. Whitta's backstory imagines precisely that the war was blamed on religion and that the survivors, acting on the diagnosis, burned every Bible they could find.

The film's intervention in this moment is therefore more precise than its reception allowed. It neither refutes the New Atheist diagnosis nor endorses it. It grants, through Carnegie, the most cynical version of the thesis that religion is an instrument of domination, and it grants, through the backstory, the consequence that a civilization persuaded of that thesis will attempt to extirpate the instrument; and then it asks what remains when both the instrument and its extirpation have run their course. The answer it proposes, I shall argue, is neither a return to confessional authority nor a secular victory, but a third thing for which neither the religious nor the secular discourse of 2010 possessed a name.

The moment's intellectual horizon also held a secular alternative to the New Atheism. A month after the September attacks, Jürgen Habermas used his acceptance speech for the Peace Prize of the German Book Trade, *Glauben und Wissen* (October 2001), to describe Western democracies as post-secular societies, in which religious communities persist and public

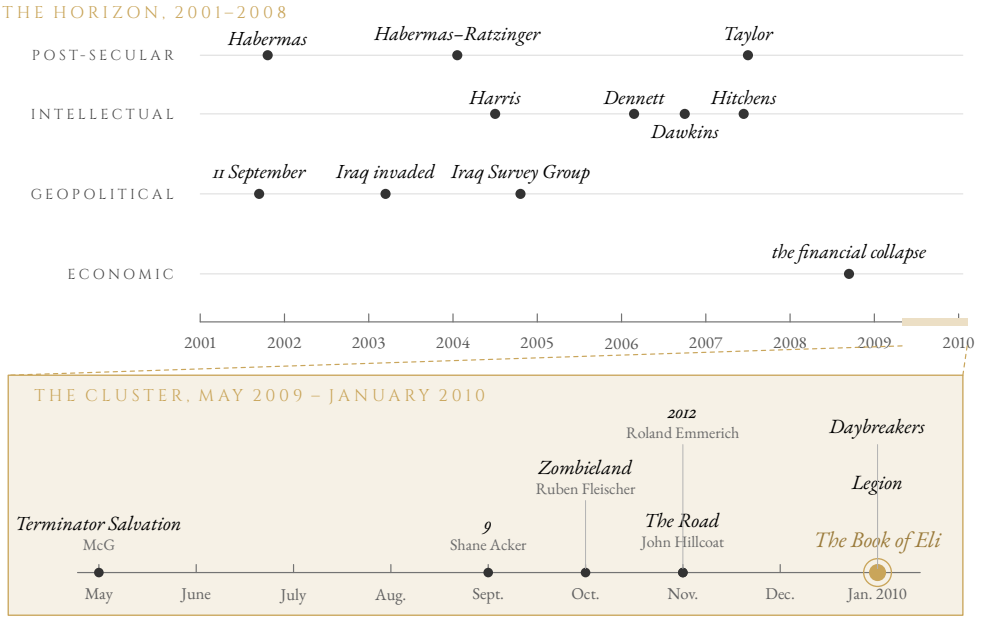


FIGURE 1

The apocalyptic cluster

The North American releases among which the film appeared, set beneath the horizon against which Prolegomena 0.2 reads them: an economic, a geopolitical and an intellectual crisis, and the post-secular alternative of the same years.

reason must be willing to learn from them, provided their contributions are translated into a language accessible to every citizen. In January 2004 he debated the foundations of the liberal state with Joseph Ratzinger at the Catholic Academy of Bavaria in Munich, an exchange published as *Dialektik der Säkularisierung* (2005); their common point of departure was the jurist Ernst-Wolfgang Böckenförde's dictum of 1967, that the liberal, secularized state lives on presuppositions it cannot itself guarantee. Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age* (2007) completed the period's rethinking of secularization as a transformation of the conditions of belief rather than its disappearance. Carnegie is the Böckenförde dilemma realized as tyranny: a power that knows it cannot generate its own legitimacy and sets out to seize a scripture to supply it. The film's resolution answers Habermas as well as Carnegie. It neither translates scripture into secular reasons nor enlists it as the state's presupposition; it makes the untranslated text available, openly, beside the scriptures of others, for readers to take up or refuse.

0.3

Composite Authorship as a Theological Problem

Any reading of a studio film must reckon with the dispersal of its authorship across writer, directors, performers, producers, and revisers, and *The Book of Eli* presents the problem in a form that its own subject matter thematizes. The screenplay credited to Whitta was rewritten, after the Hughes brothers were attached in 2007, by Anthony Peckham, whose work is not credited on screen; the present study does not apportion the released text between drafts, and treats the released film as a composite authorial text in the sense opened by Roland Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) and Michel Foucault's "What Is an Author?" (1969): the name "Whitta" or "the Hughes brothers" will designate a function of classification and attribution rather than an originating consciousness whose intentions govern meaning. Where the screenwriter's or directors' biographies bear on the film's grammar, they are adduced as conditions, not as keys.

The bracketing is not merely a methodological convenience. It replicates, at the level of criticism, the problem the film poses at the level of plot. The book Eli carries is itself the paradigmatic composite text of the Western tradition. Julius Wellhausen's *Prolegomena zur Geschichte Israels* (1883), whose title this chapter borrows, gave canonical form to the documentary hypothesis according to which the Pentateuch was woven from distinct literary strata; the version Eli carries, the Authorized Version of 1611, was produced by some four dozen translators organized in six companies, and draws much of its New Testament wording from the translations of William Tyndale, who was executed for producing them. The film's insistence that Eli's book is specifically "the King James" thus loads its MacGuffin with the most charged question in the history of scriptural authorship: the relation between *authorship* and *authority*, between the many hands that compose a text and the single sovereign that authorizes it. Carnegie's project, I will argue in Day Two, is the attempt to make a composite text speak with a single, sovereign voice. The film's resolution is the restoration of the text's composite, plural, and dispersed condition.

One biographical condition does bear directly on the film's grammar. Whitta came to screenwriting from a career in the criticism of video games, and the film's narrative architecture is legible as a ludic structure translated into cinematic form. The voice that guides Eli functions as a waypoint marker; his days are organized by an inventory economy of scarce consumables (batteries, wet wipes, water); his encounters are designed as discrete set-pieces of escalating difficulty (the hijackers beneath the overpass, the brawl in the bar, the siege of the homestead); and the plot culminates in the delivery of a quest item to an archivist at a fortified terminus. The resemblance to Bethesda's *Fallout 3* (2008), in which the player traverses a nuclear wasteland, trades salvage, and may retrieve the Declaration of Independence from the ruined National Archives for a curator in a scavenger settlement, is not a matter of influence but of a shared grammar. What the film does with that grammar is decisive: it allows the quest item to be *lost* without the quest failing. The object is captured

by the antagonist two-thirds of the way through, and the delivery succeeds anyway, because the item has already been transferred into the courier's body. The film thus stages, within a ludic structure, a critique of the ludic fetish of the object, and in so doing it rehearses one of the oldest arguments in the theology of scripture: that the Word is not identical with the book.

0.4

Lineage: The Archival Post-Apocalypse

The film descends from a specific subtradition within post-apocalyptic narrative which I propose to call the *archival post-apocalypse*, distinguished from the *survivalist* post-apocalypse (whose question is whether bodies endure) by its governing question: whether a civilization's memory endures, and in whose custody. Its founding modern text is Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959), in which, after a nuclear "Flame Deluge" and a subsequent "Simplification" during which mobs burn books and murder the literate, a monastic order preserves the "Memorabilia" of the lost world, including documents its monks can no longer understand. Miller's inversion is exact: in *Canticle* the survivors blame *knowledge* for the catastrophe and burn the books of science, which the Church preserves; in *Eli* the survivors blame *religion* and burn the Bibles, which a blind layman preserves. Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451* (1953) supplies the second founding gesture: the community of "Book People" who, in a society whose firemen burn books, each memorize a single work and so become, bodily, its only remaining copy. Bradbury's Montag ends the novel holding Ecclesiastes and part of Revelation in his memory; Eli has become the whole canon.

Around these two poles cluster the comparative texts this thesis will mobilize: Russell Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980), whose post-nuclear England has degraded both language and scripture into fragmentary myth; Mick Jackson and Barry Hines's *Threads* (1984), whose final act depicts the collapse of literacy within a single post-nuclear generation with documentary severity; George Miller's *Mad Max: Beyond Thunderdome* (1985), whose feral children preserve the memory of the old world as an oral "Tell"; David Brin's *The Postman* (1985) and Kevin Costner's adaptation (1997), in which a wanderer's fiction of a restored institution becomes the instrument of its restoration; Kevin Reynolds's *Waterworld* (1995), in which a map to the last land is inscribed on a child's back and hunted by a warlord; Umberto Eco's *The Name of the Rose* (1980), whose blind librarian murders to withhold a book; Alfonso Cuarón's *Children of Men* (2006), whose protagonist dies of an abdominal wound after delivering his charge to a refuge at sea; and above all Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* (2006), released in Hillcoat's adaptation two months before *Eli*, in which a father and son "carry the fire" through an ash-covered America and encounter a nearly blind old man who gives his name as Ely. The convergence of an Ely who denies God and an Eli who carries His book in the same season of American cinema is, I will argue in Day Three, one of the most consequential accidents in the recent history of the form.

The archival post-apocalypse is older than nuclear modernity. The Standard Babylonian *Epic of Gilgamesh* opens by instructing its reader to locate a tablet-box of cedar, release its bronze clasp, and read the story of a king who brought back tidings from before the Flood: the first epic is a self-archiving text, locked in a box, delivered across a catastrophe. Eli's codex is likewise a locked book, which Carnegie's men must force open; and, like Gilgamesh, Eli is the traveller who returns from the far side of the deluge with what the world before it knew.

0.5

Method: Hand, Figure, Constellation

Three methodological commitments govern what follows. The first is *figural*. Erich Auerbach's "Figura" (1938) recovered from patristic exegesis the principle by which an event or person signifies both itself and another that it prefigures or fulfils, without either term losing its historical reality. The film invites figural reading with unusual insistence: its protagonist bears the name of a blind priest of Shiloh who died when the Ark of the Covenant was captured (1 Samuel 4:18), and the same name, differently spelled in Hebrew, that Jesus cries from the cross (Matthew 27:46); his journey, his vocation, his succession, and his final words are, as I will show, drawn from a narrow and identifiable set of scriptural types. Figural reading is not allegory; it does not dissolve the film's literal action into a code, but reads the literal action as itself the bearer of a typological charge.

Auerbach's other major contribution supplies the thesis's methodological emblem. *Mimesis* (1946) opens with the scene in *Odyssey* 19 in which the old nurse Eurycleia, washing the feet of a disguised stranger, recognizes Odysseus by touching the scar on his thigh. Western literary criticism's founding essay on representation thus begins with an act of haptic recognition: a hand reading a body in the dark of disguise. Auerbach contrasts the Homeric style, which illuminates everything in a uniform foreground, with the biblical style, which is "fraught with background," withholding, and which makes an imperious claim upon its reader: the biblical narrative does not seek our favour but our subjection, and whoever will not submit is a rebel. Carnegie, I will argue, is the one character in the film who has read Auerbach's insight correctly and drawn the wrong conclusion from it. Eli is the one who has read the scar.

The second commitment is *constellational*. Walter Benjamin's "Epistemo-Critical Prologue" to *The Origin of German Tragic Drama* (1928) proposes that ideas are to objects as constellations are to stars: the idea is not abstracted from phenomena but configured among them. The comparative apparatus of this thesis is constellational in that sense. It does not claim that Whitta read Berkeley or Spinoza or 4 Ezra. It distinguishes three registers of relation: *attested* lineage (what the film names or quotes, beginning with the King James Version itself); *generic-genealogical* lineage (the inheritances of the Western, the samurai film, the archival post-apocalypse, and the video game); and *constellational* affinity (configurations the critic constructs in which the film's elements become legible as an idea). The originality

of the thesis lies predominantly in the third register, and it is there that its claims must be judged by their explanatory yield rather than by documentary proof.

The third commitment is *dialectical in the hermeneutic sense*. Paul Ricoeur's *Freud and Philosophy* (1965) distinguished a hermeneutics of suspicion, practised by Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud, which unmasks meaning as disguised interest, from a hermeneutics of restoration, which receives meaning as address; and his *Symbolism of Evil* (1960) proposed that beyond critique lies a "second naïveté," a post-critical capacity to be addressed by symbols one no longer naïvely believes. The film distributes these hermeneutics across its antagonists with schematic clarity. Carnegie is a master of suspicion: he knows religion is a technology of power and wishes to use it as one. Eli is, until the last act, a naïve custodian who guards the text without having fully understood it. The film's resolution, Eli's confession that he had been so absorbed in protecting the book that he neglected to live by what it taught, is a passage to second naïveté. A final caution governs the whole. Because this thesis privileges the haptic against the optical, it must heed Jacques Derrida's critique, in *On Touching—Jean-Luc Nancy* (2000), of "haptocentrism": the tendency to invest touch with the immediacy and presence that the tradition denied to vision. Braille is writing, not presence; it is subject to the same spacing, delay, and iterability as any other script. The aphotic is not the immediate. It is another regime of mediation, and the thesis treats it as such.

A fourth commitment, haptic, is the condition of the thesis's central concept. Film theory has developed a vocabulary for the cinema's appeal to touch. Laura U. Marks's *The Skin of the Film* (2000) describes a haptic visuality in which the eye moves over the surface of an image as a hand moves over a texture, invited by grain, blur, and the image's refusal to yield a clear figure; Vivian Sobchack's "What My Fingers Knew" (in *Carnal Thoughts*, 2004) argues that the spectator's body makes sense of a film before consciousness has identified what it shows; Jennifer M. Barker's *The Tactile Eye* (2009) extends the account to the film's own body, its skin, musculature, and viscera. A haptic hermeneutics reads a film for what it gives to the hand and the ear rather than for what it presents to the gaze, and *The Book of Eli* invites such reading twice: before its twist, through an overexposed image that withholds the figure and offers the surface (Day One); after it, by obliging the spectator to reconstruct as touch and sound what had been watched as sight. The caution against haptocentrism stated above governs this commitment as it governs the others.

0.6

Architecture: An Itinerary in Six Days

The thesis takes the form of a hexaemeron, a commentary on the six days of creation and the Sabbath, a genre that runs from Basil of Caesarea's homilies and Ambrose's *Hexameron* through Augustine's *De Genesi ad litteram* to Bonaventure's *Collationes in Hexaemeron* (1273). The choice is not ornamental. The film's climax is a cosmogonic recitation: Eli's dictation begins with Genesis 1:1, so that the end of the world terminates in the words that

begin it. Mircea Eliade argued in *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) that archaic societies regenerated time by reciting the cosmogony, re-enacting the creation so as to found the world anew; the film's last act is such a recitation, performed by a dying man in a former prison at the edge of a burned continent. Bonaventure's *Itinerarium mentis in Deum* (1259), composed on Mount La Verna where Francis of Assisi received the stigmata, structures the mind's journey to God in six stages modelled on the six days and the six wings of the seraph, culminating in a seventh, Sabbatical rest; the present thesis is, in that sense, an *itinerarium libri post flammam*, the journey of a book after the flame, and its terminus in San Francisco, the city of Bonaventure's master, will prove more than coincidental.

The film's world is the *tohu wa-bohu* of Genesis 1:2, the formless void over which darkness lies, but by way of Jeremiah 4:23–26, the Bible's own vision of un-creation, in which the prophet beholds the earth returned to formlessness, the mountains trembling, the birds fled, the fruitful place a wilderness, and the cities broken down. Jeremiah's un-created world has no light. The film's has too much. That difference is the subject of Day One.

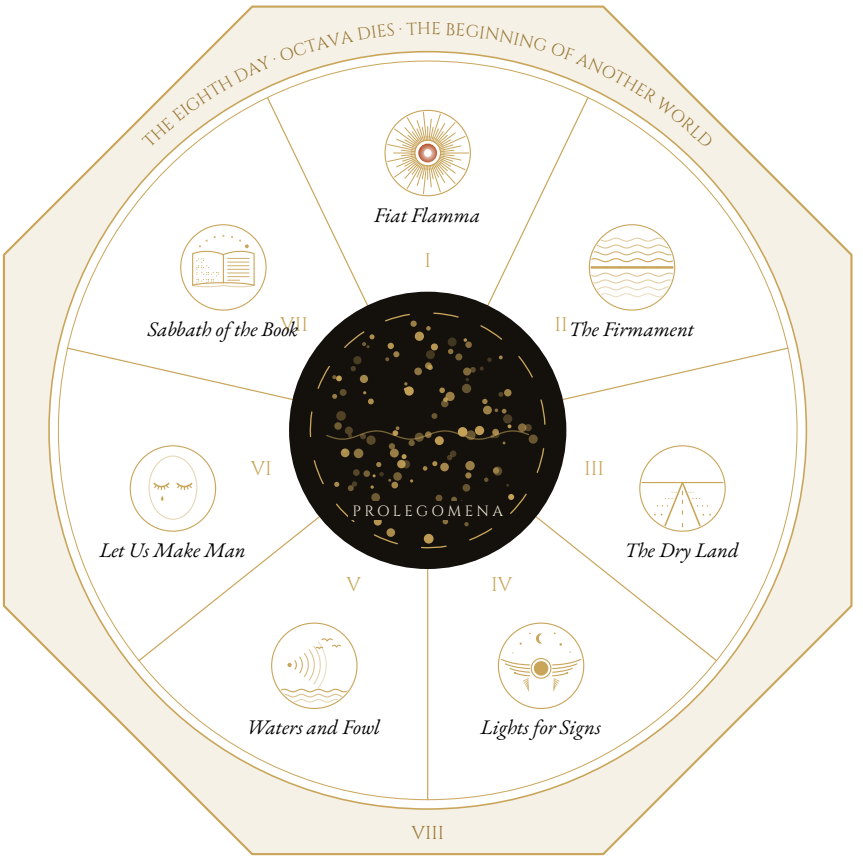
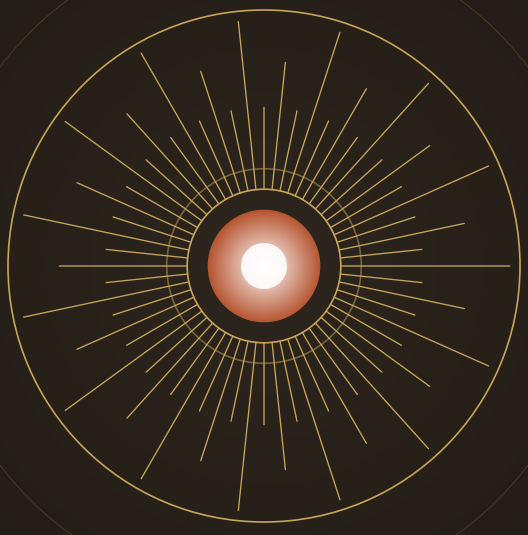


FIGURE 2

The hexaemeral architecture

The thesis as a hexaemeron: the uncreated world of the Prolegomena at the centre, the six days and the Sabbath around it, and the eighth day enclosing the week, "the beginning of another world."

DAY ONE



Fiat Flamma

The Flash, the Ruin of the Visible, and the Necessity of Aphotic Revelation

And God said, Let there be light: and there was light.

GENESIS 1:3 (AV)

1.1

Anti-Creation: The Light That Precedes No Sun

The first creature of the biblical cosmogony is light, and it precedes the luminaries: the sun, moon, and stars are not made until the fourth day (Genesis 1:14–19). Patristic commentators from Basil to Augustine laboured over this sequence, and Origen in *De principiis* (IV.3.1) cited it as proof that Genesis could not be read with crude literalism, since there could be no evening and morning without a sun. The puzzle acquires a terrible literalness in the film's cosmology. The catastrophe that founds its world is remembered not as a war of armies but as a single photic event, "the flash," a light without a sun, or rather a light that counterfeits the sun, which in the survivors' oral account tore open the sky and brought the heavens' fire down upon the earth. If Genesis 1:3 is the *fiat lux* by which the world was called out of darkness, the flash is a *fiat flamma*, a creation-word inverted into its negation: light pronounced not as the condition of the visible but as the instrument of its abolition.

The Bible itself distinguishes these two fires with precision. At Horeb, the theophany to the prophet whose name Eli's abbreviates is marked by the systematic exclusion of the destructive elements: a great wind rent the mountains, "but the LORD was not in the wind"; an earthquake, "but the LORD was not in the earthquake"; "and after the earthquake a fire; but the LORD was not in the fire: and after the fire a still small voice" (1 Kings 19:11–12). The Hebrew phrase rendered by the Authorized Version as "still small voice," *qôl dĕmāmāh daqqāh*, is more strictly a "sound of thin silence," a voice at the threshold of audibility. The film reproduces this sequence as its theological premise. The fire of the flash is not God; God, if He is anywhere in the film, is in the voice Eli heard in the ruins. Against the other biblical fire, the bush that "burned with fire, and … was not consumed" (Exodus 3:2), the nuclear fire is the fire that consumes everything and reveals nothing. The burning bush is a revelation that does not destroy its medium; the flash is a destruction that leaves no medium for revelation. The entire problem of the film is how revelation is possible after the second kind of fire.

1.2

Nuclear Optics: The Bomb as Light-Weapon

The film's conception of the apocalypse as a photic event is not a poetic licence but an accurate transcription of the way nuclear weapons entered human experience. The first detonation, at Alamogordo in July 1945, was witnessed principally as light; Robert Jungk's history of the Manhattan Project took its title, *Brighter than a Thousand Suns* (1956), from the verse of the *Bhagavad Gītā* (11.12) that J. Robert Oppenheimer associated with the test, in which the radiance of a thousand suns bursting at once into the sky is likened to the splendour of the divine form revealed to Arjuna. The theophanic analogy is exact and

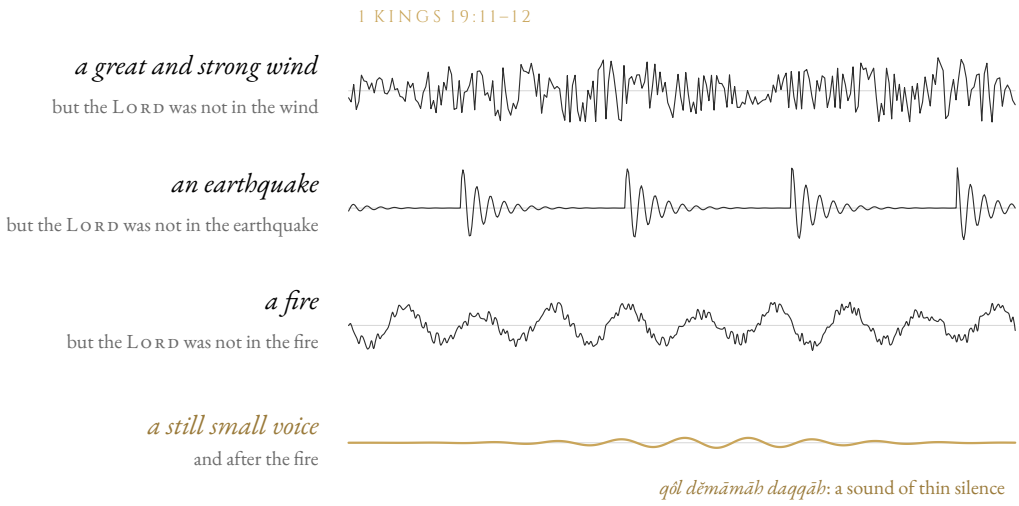


FIGURE 3

Not in the wind, nor the earthquake, nor the fire

Horeb in the Authorized Version: three destructive elements in which the LORD is not, and after them a voice at the threshold of audibility, more strictly "a sound of thin silence." The fire of the flash belongs to the third row; the voice Eli heard in the ruins, to the fourth.

appalling: the bomb was experienced as a counterfeit epiphany, a revelation of the godhead's terrible aspect manufactured in a desert in New Mexico, the state in which, six decades later, *The Book of Eli* would largely be photographed.

Paul Virilio's *War and Cinema: The Logistics of Perception* (1984) argued that modern war is waged as much through the management of perception as through the application of force, and that the atomic flash over Hiroshima was the culmination of this logistics: a weapon of light whose first effect was to blind and whose most enduring images were photographic. Akira Mizuta Lippit's *Atomic Light (Shadow Optics)* (2005) extended the argument into a theory of what he calls the "avisual": the bomb's light, like the X-ray with which it shares a genealogy, reveals by destroying, and its signature images are the human shadows burned onto stone steps and walls in Hiroshima, photographs taken with the city itself as the photographic plate. These images must be named for what they record. The United States dropped atomic bombs on Hiroshima on 6 August 1945 and on Nagasaki three days later, and by the end of that year the two weapons had killed well over a hundred thousand people, most of them civilians. The best known of the shadows, on the stone steps of the Hiroshima branch of the Sumitomo Bank, is the mark left where a person sitting there was killed, the granite around the body bleached by the flash. A reading that treats such traces as photographs must remember that each records a person killed in the exposure. The nuclear flash is the apotheosis of the Western equation of knowledge with

illumination, the moment at which illumination becomes total and therefore annihilating. Günther Anders, in *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (1956), named the corresponding moral condition *Apokalypseblindheit*, "apocalypse-blindness": the incapacity of a humanity whose productive power has outstripped its imaginative capacity (the "Promethean gap") to perceive the catastrophe it is able to produce. The film's wager can be stated as an inversion of Anders's diagnosis. Before the end, humanity was blind to the apocalypse; after it, only the blind can see what the apocalypse means.

The survivors' universal habit of wearing dark glasses, which the film presents without explanation as a costume convention of the wasteland, is the mark of this condition. Every face in the film is shielded against a sun that has become hostile; vision persists only as a damaged and defended faculty. The eye, in Western philosophy the noblest organ, is in this world the most endangered, and its protection is the universal sign of membership in the post-apocalyptic community. Eli's own dark glasses, which the audience reads as conformity to this convention, conceal the opposite: not a wounded eye guarding its remaining sight, but an eye that has nothing left to guard.

1.3

Overexposure: The Film Image as Burn

Don Burgess's cinematography for the film, captured digitally and graded toward a bleached, drained, nearly monochrome palette of bone, ash, and tarnished bronze, has usually been described as a stylistic choice in the tradition of post-apocalyptic desaturation. I propose a stronger reading. The film's image is *overexposed* in the technical sense: it presents a world in which too much light has struck the photosensitive surface, washing out colour, flattening tone, and consuming detail at the bright end of the scale. In the photographic economy, overexposure is irreversible information loss; the burned highlight records nothing. The film thus inscribes the flash into its own photochemical (or photo-electronic) substrate. The catastrophe is not only represented in the backstory; it persists as the condition of the image itself, as though the camera were still recording in the afterglow of the event. Compared with the saturated ochres of George Miller's *Mad Max* films, the ash-grey of Hillcoat's *The Road*, or the documentary grain of *Threads*, the palette of *Eli* is distinguished by its luminous sickness: it is not dark but too bright, a world bleached rather than blackened.

This matters because cinema is, constitutively, an art of light. Its inventors bore, by an etymological accident that the history of the medium never ceased to exploit, the name Lumière. Every film is light thrown upon darkness, and every spectator's pleasure in it is, as Christian Metz argued in *The Imaginary Signifier* (1977), grounded in a primary identification with the camera's look: the spectator identifies first not with a character but with the act of seeing that the apparatus performs. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) showed how classical narrative cinema organizes that look along gendered lines, aligning the spectator with a male protagonist who looks and a female figure

who is looked at. *The Book of Eli* disables both structures at once, and it does so retroactively. Its central twist, the revelation that the protagonist has been blind throughout, forces the spectator to reread two hours of images in which they had identified their seeing with his. Every shot from Eli's apparent point of view, every glance he seemed to cast, is retrospectively disclosed as a fiction of the apparatus. The spectator discovers that they have been lent a gaze the protagonist never possessed. The twist is thus an act of cinematic self-blinding: a film made of light confesses that its hero lived outside the regime of light altogether.

The Mulveyan consequence is equally precise. The sequence in which Carnegie sends Solara to Eli's room as a sexual offering, the scene most explicitly organized in the film's grammar as an invitation to the male gaze, is the scene in which that gaze is most completely absent. Eli does not refuse to look at Solara. He cannot look. What the spectator took for a chaste averting of the eyes was the condition of a man for whom the visual offer had no purchase. The refusal that follows is therefore not the triumph of a disciplined gaze over desire but the redirection of an encounter that never passed through vision into another register entirely: he feeds her, and he teaches her to pray. The film's ethical turn begins at the point where the cinematic look is shown to have been empty.

1.4

The Sun Inverted: Ocularcentrism After Its Apotheosis

The Western philosophical tradition has, from its beginnings, thought knowledge on the model of sight. Aristotle opens the *Metaphysics* (A.1, 980a) by observing that all men by nature desire to know, and that the sign of this is the delight we take in our senses, above all in sight, which most makes us know and brings to light many differences between things. *Theōria* is a seeing; *eidos*, the form, is what is seen; the Enlightenment, *les Lumières*, *die Aufklärung*, names its own project as a clearing of light. Hans Jonas's "The Nobility of Sight" (1954) gave this privilege its phenomenological justification: vision alone presents a simultaneous manifold at a distance, without causal entanglement between perceiver and perceived, and thus supplies the model for objectivity, for theory, and for the idea of an eternal present. Martin Heidegger's "The Age of the World Picture" (1938) diagnosed the modern culmination of this privilege as the conversion of the world itself into a *Bild*, a picture set before a representing subject; and Martin Jay's *Downcast Eyes* (1993) traced the twentieth-century French revolt against this regime, from Bergson and Bataille through Sartre's look, Lacan's gaze, Foucault's panopticon, Debord's spectacle, and Levinas's ethics, to Derrida.

The founding image of this tradition is Plato's sun. In *Republic* VI (507b–509b) the sun is the offspring of the Good, giving to visible things their visibility as the Good gives to intelligible things their intelligibility; in Book VII the prisoner released from the cave is dazzled by the light and must accustom himself to it by degrees until he can behold the sun itself. Plato's allegory contains, however, a detail that the film activates. When the liberated

prisoner returns to the cave, his eyes, accustomed to the light, are "full of darkness," and the prisoners mock him for having ruined his sight by the ascent; were he to try to release them and lead them up, Socrates says, they would kill him if they could (517a). The philosopher who has seen the sun returns to the world of shadows as a blind man and a candidate for murder. The film literalizes this structure while reversing its valuation. Its sun is not the Good but the destroyer; the flash is the sun brought down into the cave, and those who looked upon it were not enlightened but burned. Eli, the returned man with darkened eyes whom the powerful of the cave try to kill, possesses truth not because he has seen the sun but because he no longer needs to. The tradition from Plato to Jonas made the sun the source of truth; the nuclear age made it the source of annihilation; the film proposes that after the sun's apotheosis as weapon, truth must be sought elsewhere than in the light.

1.5

The Genealogy of the Blind Seer

That elsewhere has a long genealogy, and Eli is its latest member. Sophocles's *Oedipus Tyrannus* is constructed on the chiasmus between Tiresias, who is blind and sees, and Oedipus, who sees and is blind, until he blinds himself upon seeing truly. *Odyssey* 8 presents the bard Demodocus, whom the Muse loved above all others and to whom she gave both good and evil, taking his sight and granting him sweet song; the tradition that Homer himself was blind made blindness the very emblem of epic memory. John Milton, blind by 1652, composed *Paradise Lost* (1667) by dictation, and its third book opens with an invocation of light from a poet who can no longer see it, asking that the celestial light, in compensation for the outward light he has lost, "Shine inward, and the mind through all her powers / Irradiate" (III.52–53). His sonnet "When I consider how my light is spent" ends with the consolation that "They also serve who only stand and wait." Jorge Luis Borges, appointed director of Argentina's National Library in 1955 as his sight failed, wrote in "Poema de los dones" (1960) of the magnificent irony of a God who granted him at once the books and the night. Each of these figures pairs blindness with an *archive*: the Homeric bard with the memory of a culture, Milton with the epic of Genesis, Borges with a national library. Eli inherits the pairing and radicalizes it, since he carries in his blindness not a culture's memory but its scripture, and not one library but the only book that has survived the destruction of all others.

The biblical genealogy is still more precise, and it is here that the film's figural logic becomes inescapable. The priest whose name Eli bears is introduced in 1 Samuel as a man whose "eyes began to wax dim, that he could not see" (3:2); at ninety-eight "his eyes were dim, that he could not see" (4:15); and he dies, falling backward "by the side of the gate," when he hears that the Ark of God, the vessel that housed the tablets of the Law and beside which the book of the Law was to be laid (Deuteronomy 31:26), has been captured by the enemy (4:18). The film's Eli is this figure re-imagined: a blind custodian of the Law whose

vessel is captured by an enemy power. But where the priest of Shiloh dies at the news of the Ark's capture, the walker of the wasteland survives the capture of his book, because the Law no longer resides in the vessel alone. The Pauline structure is equally determinate. Saul of Tarsus, travelling to Damascus to arrest those "of this way" (Acts 9:2), is struck by "a light from heaven" (9:3), falls, hears a voice, rises unable to see (9:8), and is commissioned to carry the name of Christ to the nations. A flash, a fall, a voice, blindness, and a mission to carry the word westward: Eli's biography, as he narrates it to Solara, is a Damascus road extended to thirty years. In Acts the scales fall from Paul's eyes after three days (9:18). In the film they never fall from Eli's; his conversion, as Day Six will show, comes not as restored sight but as a late ethical recognition, the moral scales falling where the physical ones remain.

The Johannine tradition supplies the film's governing paradox in a single sentence. After healing the man born blind, Jesus declares: "For judgment I am come into this world, that they which see not might see; and that they which see might be made blind" (John 9:39). Carnegie, the sighted reader, will be made blind before his own captured book; Eli, the blind man, sees what the book is. Jacques Derrida's *Memoirs of the Blind* (1990), written for an exhibition of drawings of the blind at the Louvre, opens with the phrase *il faut croire*, "one has to believe": the blind man advancing with hands outstretched into a space he cannot see is the figure of faith itself, of a movement that proceeds without the guarantee of sight. Derrida's remarkable conclusion is that the essence of the eye, its truth, is not to see but to weep, and that tears, not vision, are what is proper to the human eye. The film's protagonist, whose eyes are revealed only at the end, clouded and sightless, enacts the first half of Derrida's claim with a rigour the film does not quite allow itself to extend to the second.

1.6

The Inverse Molyneux Scene

In a letter of 1688 and again in 1693, the Irish natural philosopher William Molyneux posed to John Locke a question that Locke inserted into the second edition of the *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1694, II.ix.8). Suppose a man born blind, who has learned to distinguish a cube from a sphere by touch, were suddenly made to see: could he, by sight alone, before touching them, tell which was the cube and which the sphere? Molyneux and Locke answered no, and the question became the eighteenth century's laboratory for the relation between the senses. George Berkeley's *An Essay towards a New Theory of Vision* (1709) answered most radically: the objects of sight and the objects of touch are entirely heterogeneous, connected not by resemblance but only by habitual association, and the proper objects of vision constitute, in Berkeley's extraordinary formulation, "an universal language of the Author of nature" (§147), a divine speech addressed to the eye. Denis Diderot's *Lettre sur les aveugles* (1749), which cost its author three months' imprisonment at Vincennes, imagined the blind mathematician Nicholas Saunderson on his deathbed, unmoved by the argument from design because the spectacle of nature that so impressed

the sighted was nothing to him; if he was to believe in God, he would have to be made to touch Him.

The film's climax stages Molyneux's problem in inverted form. Carnegie, a sighted and literate man, has spent years and many lives to obtain a book he has known since childhood, a book whose words he believes he could recognize anywhere. When at last its lock is forced and the codex lies open before him, he cannot read a word of it. The text he knows by sight confronts him in the form in which it is known by touch, and his vision is useless before it. This is the Molyneux experiment run backward: not the blind man made to see and confronted with objects known by touch, but the seeing man confronted with a text whose only mode of existence is tangible. Berkeley's heterogeneity thesis is vindicated with brutal clarity. There is no passage from the visible to the tangible by inspection; the knowledge of the hand cannot be appropriated by the eye. And Berkeley's theology is inverted as precisely. For Berkeley, God speaks to humanity in the language of vision. In the film's world, after the visible has been destroyed by its own excess, the divine language survives only in the alphabet of touch.

1.7

Aphotic Revelation Defined

We may now define the thesis's central concept. Oceanographers call *aphotic* the zone of the sea below roughly a thousand metres into which no sunlight penetrates, a zone once presumed lifeless and now known to sustain whole ecologies independent of photosynthesis. By *aphotic revelation* I mean a mode of disclosure that operates below the threshold of light: revelation that does not unveil an object to sight but transmits a content through touch, hearing, and memory, and that is therefore immune to the catastrophe of the visible. The Greek *apokalypsis* names an uncovering, a removal of the veil from before the eyes; it is an optical concept, and the nuclear age realized its literal sense as total exposure. Aphotic revelation is revelation after apocalypse in this precise sense: a disclosure that no longer depends on the lifting of a veil, because it addresses a subject for whom the veil was never the obstacle.

The scriptural warrant for the concept lies in the very book Eli carries. "Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path" (Psalm 119:105): for a blind walker, the word does not illuminate the path; it *replaces* illumination. "For we walk by faith, not by sight" (2 Corinthians 5:7): the Pauline formula describes, with literal exactness, thirty years of westward walking by a man who cannot see the road. "Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen" (Hebrews 11:1). And the risen Christ's beatitude to Thomas, who demanded to touch the wounds before believing, is the beatitude of Eli's entire existence: "blessed are they that have not seen, and yet have believed" (John 20:29). These verses have been read for two millennia as metaphors. The film reads them

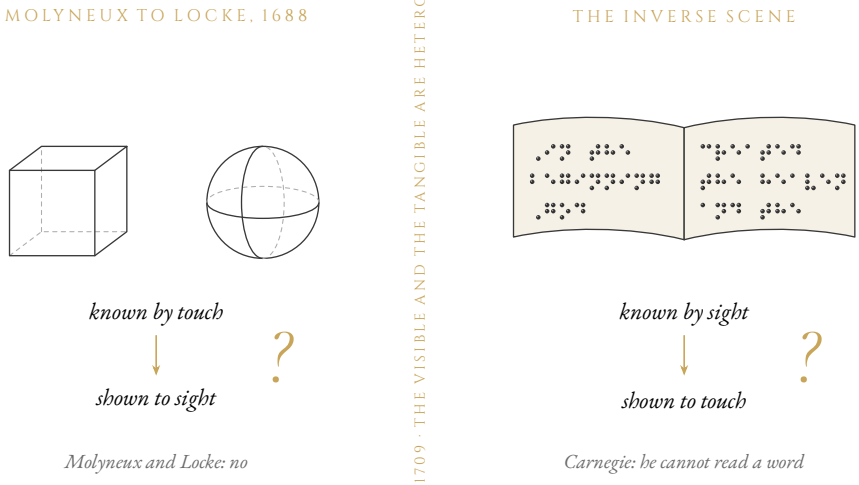


FIGURE 4

The inverse Molyneux scene

Molyneux asked whether a man born blind, who had learned cube and sphere by touch, could tell them apart by sight alone once made to see; he and Locke answered no. Carnegie, who has known the book since childhood, meets it in the form in which it is known by touch, and cannot read a word of it.

as descriptions. The remainder of this thesis traces what follows, politically, ethically, and archivally, when they are taken at their word.

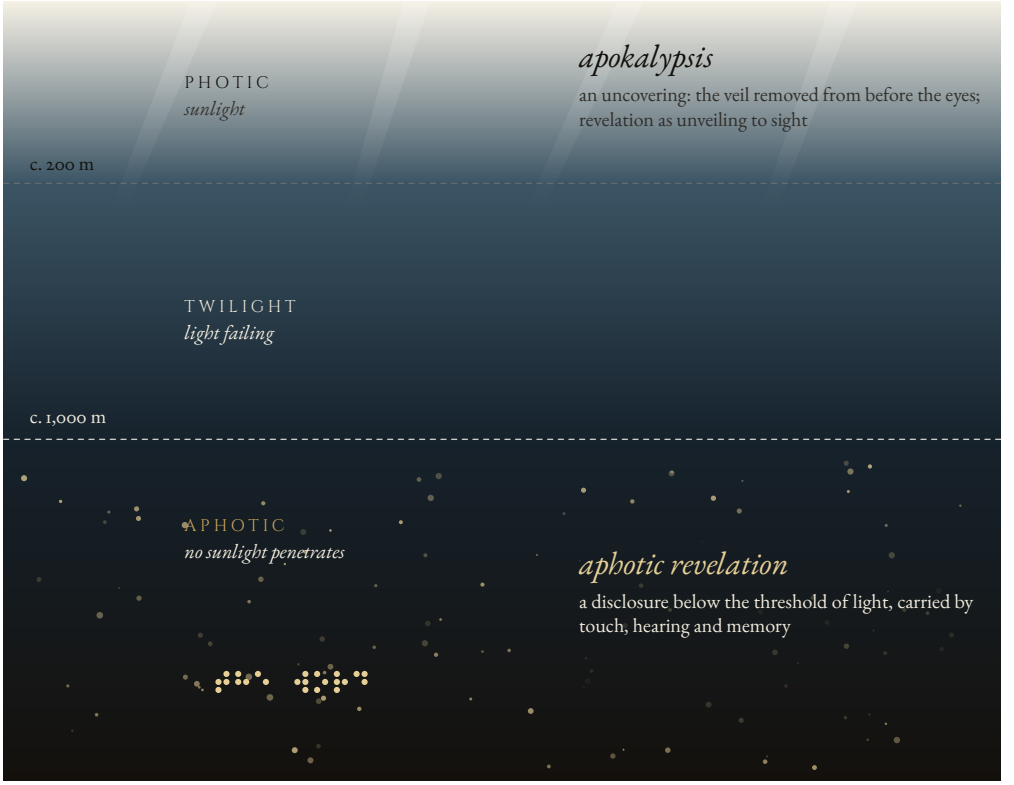
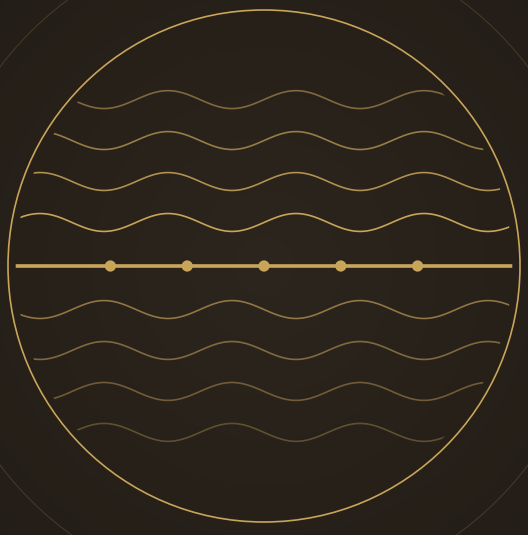


FIGURE 5

The aphotic zone

Oceanographers call aphotic the sea below roughly a thousand metres, into which no sunlight penetrates: a zone once presumed lifeless, now known to sustain whole ecologies independent of photosynthesis. The thesis borrows the word for a revelation that no longer depends on the lifting of a veil.

DAY TWO



The Firmament Dividing the Waters

Hydraulic Sovereignty and the Scriptural Supplement

And God said, Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters, and let it divide the waters from the waters.

GENESIS 1:6 (AV)

2.1

Hydraulic Sovereignty

The second day of creation is the day of division: the firmament separates the waters above from the waters below, and order is founded on a partition. Carl Schmitt, whose *Political Theology* (1922) and *The Concept of the Political* (1932) will haunt this chapter, held that the political is constituted by a primary division between friend and enemy, and that the sovereign is he who decides on the exception. Carnegie's town is founded on a division of waters in the most literal sense. Its sovereign holds the only reliable water in the region; the settlement exists because he controls the source; the bar in which Eli first tries to fill his canteen is the retail outlet of a hydraulic monopoly, and the price of water is the price of submission.

The sinologist Karl Wittfogel's *Oriental Despotism: A Comparative Study of Total Power* (1957) proposed, in a thesis now much contested in its historical claims but undiminished in its conceptual force, that the great agrarian despotisms arose where the management of large-scale irrigation required a centralized bureaucracy, so that control of water became the material basis of total power. Marc Reisner's *Cadillac Desert* (1986) told the history of the American West as a history of water and the institutions that seized it; Roman Polanski's *Chinatown* (1974), its cinematic counterpart, gave the western water baron his definitive form in Noah Cross, a patriarch whose biblical forename and cruciform surname crown a man who owns a city's water and who, the film finally reveals, fathered a child by his own teenage daughter. Carnegie is Noah Cross transposed to the end of the world, with a difference that precision requires. He controls the water; he keeps a blind woman, Claudia, as his consort, and beats her when he needs her daughter's compliance; and he orders that daughter, Solara, to seduce a stranger he wishes to recruit. Cross abuses his own daughter. Carnegie offers the daughter of his household to another man as an inducement. Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) had already joined hydraulic scarcity to engineered religion, in a desert world where water is the substance of wealth and where a sisterhood of political engineers has, over centuries, seeded planetary populations with prophecies to be activated when needed; and George Miller's *Mad Max: Fury Road* (2015), five years after *Eli*, would perfect the figure in Immortan Joe, a water-tyrant who supplements his monopoly with a manufactured cult of martyrdom. Between Herbert and Miller, Carnegie is the transitional figure: a hydraulic despot who has not yet acquired his religion, and who understands that he must.

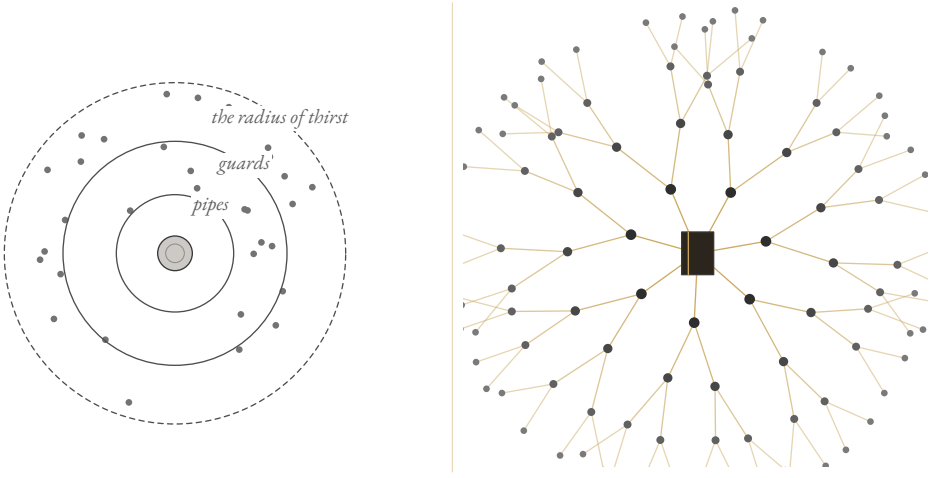


FIGURE 6

Two radii of rule

Carnegie's scalability thesis. Water rules a town, but only as far as the pipes, the guards and the radius of thirst; scripture is portable, reproducible and internalizable, and governs those who carry it in the absence of the governor. Beneath, the paired terms of Gramsci and Althusser.

2.2

The Scalability Thesis

The most intellectually serious line in the film belongs to its villain. In the scene in which Carnegie berates his lieutenant for failing to grasp why the book matters, he argues, in substance, that the Bible is not a book but a weapon, one aimed at the hearts and minds of the weak and the desperate; that with it, people will come from everywhere and do exactly what he says, provided the words are the book's; that if he wishes to rule more than a single small town he must have it; and that this has happened before and will happen again. The speech contains a complete political theory, and its centre is a claim about scale. Water rules a town. It does not rule a world, because hydraulic control is logistically bounded: it extends only as far as the pipes, the guards, and the radius of thirst. Scripture is portable, reproducible, and internalizable; it travels in the heads of those who receive it and governs them in the absence of the governor. Carnegie's insight is that material domination does not scale and ideological domination does.

The insight has an exact theoretical articulation in the twentieth-century Marxist tradition. Antonio Gramsci's *Prison Notebooks* (written 1929–1935) distinguished *dominio*, rule by coercion, from *egemonia*, leadership by consent, and argued that no ruling group maintains

itself durably by force alone: the state, in Gramsci's formula, is political society plus civil society, hegemony protected by the armour of coercion. Louis Althusser's "Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses" (1970) refined the distinction into that between Repressive State Apparatuses (police, army, prisons), which function primarily by violence, and Ideological State Apparatuses (churches, schools, families, media), which function primarily by ideology; and he observed that in pre-capitalist formations the dominant ISA was the Church. Carnegie possesses a complete RSA (armed men, a monopoly of water) and no ISA at all. He wants the book because it is the only ideological apparatus left in the world. Max Weber's typology of legitimate domination in *Economy and Society* (1922) supplies the third term. Carnegie's authority is neither traditional (there is no tradition after the flash) nor legal-rational (there is no law); it is charismatic in the degraded sense of personal force, and charisma, Weber argued, is inherently unstable and must be "routinized" into tradition or law if it is to survive its bearer. Scripture is the instrument by which Carnegie would routinize his charisma into a tradition he could pass on.

Karl Marx's dictum that religion is "the opium of the people" is usually cited as the source of Carnegie's view, and so it is, but only in a truncated form that the film's own structure corrects. The full passage of the 1844 introduction to the *Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right* reads, in my translation of the German: "Religious misery is at once the expression of real misery and a protest against real misery. Religion is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the heart of a heartless world, as it is the spirit of spiritless conditions. It is the opium of the people." Marx's religion is double: an anaesthetic administered by power, and a protest arising from the suffering that power produces. Carnegie hears only the first half. Eli lives the second. The film thus restages, within a single narrative, the ambivalence that Marx's own sentence contains and that its popular citation erases.

The logic by which water calls for scripture is the one Jacques Derrida named the supplement. Reading Rousseau in *Of Grammatology* (1967), Derrida observed that a supplement is added to something presented as complete in itself, and that the need for the addition exposes a lack the original was supposed not to have: writing supplements speech, and in doing so reveals that speech was never self-sufficient. Carnegie's water is supposed to be sovereignty; his need for the book confesses that it is not, that force cannot produce the consent that alone makes rule durable. The supplement also supplants. Once Carnegie stakes his rule on the book, his rule depends on whoever can read it, and the only reader in his domain is the woman he beats. Rousseau's "dangerous supplement," in Derrida's reading, becomes in the film a literal danger: the addition that was to complete the sovereign transfers his power to his most abused subject, and Claudia's refusal (2.6) is the moment at which the supplement's logic comes due.

2.3

The Name of the Warlord

The antagonist's name is the film's most compressed political argument. Andrew Carnegie, the steel magnate whose essay "Wealth" (1889), known as "The Gospel of Wealth," declared that the man who dies rich dies disgraced, spent much of his fortune funding more than two and a half thousand public libraries across the English-speaking world, the "Carnegie libraries" whose reading rooms made literacy a public good for working people. The film's Carnegie is this figure's photographic negative: a man who hoards books rather than distributing them, who seeks one book rather than all books, and who wants literacy not as a public good but as a private monopoly. Where the industrialist built libraries in order that the many might read, the warlord seeks the book in order that the many might obey what only he can read. Yet the negative omits half of the original. In July 1892, at the Homestead works of the Carnegie Steel Company near Pittsburgh, the company's chairman, Henry Clay Frick, locked out the union and brought in armed Pinkerton agents to break the strike, a hard line Carnegie had endorsed before leaving for Scotland; the battle with the strikers on 6 July left both workers and Pinkertons dead, and the state militia then occupied the town on the company's side. The man who gave the English-speaking world its public libraries also broke a union with hired guns. Hegemony and coercion, Gramsci's two faces of rule, were already united in the industrialist, and the warlord is less his negative than his concentrate. The surname also evokes Dale Carnegie, whose *How to Win Friends and Influence People* (1936) codified for the twentieth century a popular technology of persuasion; and it places the character in the lineage of Edward Bernays, whose *Propaganda* (1928) frankly described the "engineering of consent" as the work of an invisible government of manipulators. The warlord's name thus binds together the three faces of the modern relation between text and power: the philanthropic library, the persuasion manual, and the propaganda office. Carnegie wants to be all three, with a single book.

2.4

"It Has Happened Before": A Genealogy of Instrumental Scripture

Carnegie's claim that the conversion of scripture into an instrument of rule has happened before is historically correct, and the genealogy it gestures toward is the hidden spine of Western political theology. Its first station is in the Bible itself. In the eighteenth year of King Josiah, the high priest Hilkiah announces, "I have found the book of the law in the house of the LORD" (2 Kings 22:8); the king, after having it authenticated by the prophetess Huldah, uses it to launch a sweeping reform that destroys the rural shrines and centralizes all worship, and with it all religious authority, in Jerusalem under royal control (2 Kings 23). The reform is not bloodless in its own telling: in the cities of the north, the narrator records, Josiah "slew all the priests of the high places that were there upon the altars" (23:20). The found

book authorizes the killing of the rival clergy. Since W. M. L. de Wette's dissertation of 1805, critical scholarship has widely identified this "found" book with a form of Deuteronomy and has entertained the hypothesis that its discovery was, in the phrase of a later age, a pious fraud: a text produced or promulgated to legitimate a programme of political centralization. Josiah is the archetype of Carnegie's ambition, a king who discovers a book and uses it to extend his rule beyond its former limits. The difference is instructive. Josiah had a Huldah who would read and authenticate the book for him. Carnegie will not.

Plato's *Republic* supplies the philosophical prototype. The "noble lie" of Book III (414b–415d), the myth of the metals by which citizens are to be persuaded that the god mixed gold into the rulers, silver into the auxiliaries, and iron and bronze into the producers, is the first systematic proposal in Western thought that political order requires a sacred fiction administered by those who know it to be a fiction. Niccolò Machiavelli's *Discourses on Livy* (I.11–15) supplied the historical case: Numa Pompilius, Rome's second king, consolidated the city founded by the violent Romulus by pretending to receive his laws from the nymph Egeria, and Machiavelli observes that there was never an extraordinary lawgiver who did not have recourse to God, because otherwise his laws would not have been accepted. Carnegie is a Romulus who knows he needs a Numa and, lacking an Egeria, seeks a book. *The Prince* (ch. 6) adds a distinction that the film dramatizes with uncanny exactness. All armed prophets have conquered, Machiavelli writes, and all unarmed prophets have come to ruin, as Savonarola did in Florence. Eli is an *armed prophet*: he carries a blade and uses it with lethal proficiency. Carnegie is *arms without prophecy*: he has guns, men, and water, but no word. The film's conflict is between these two incomplete figures, and its resolution is the refusal of the armed prophet to become a founder. Eli, who could have taken Carnegie's town, never wants it.

Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) is the decisive modern station, and Carnegie is, without knowing it, a strict Hobbesian. Hobbes devoted the third and fourth parts of his treatise, "Of a Christian Commonwealth" and "Of the Kingdom of Darkness," to the proposition that the sovereign must control the interpretation of scripture, since whoever can determine what God commands can determine what subjects must do; the books of scripture are law, Hobbes argues, only by the authority of the sovereign who declares them so (ch. 33, 42). His "Kingdom of Darkness" is a confederacy of deceivers who, to obtain dominion over men in this present world, endeavour by dark and erroneous doctrines to extinguish in them the light of nature and of the gospel (ch. 44). Carnegie wishes to be the Hobbesian sovereign, the sole authorized interpreter of the sole remaining scripture; he would also be, by Hobbes's own definition, a prince of the Kingdom of Darkness. The famous frontispiece of *Leviathan* depicts the sovereign towering over his commonwealth, his body composed of the bodies of his subjects, holding in his right hand a sword and in his left a crozier: temporal and spiritual power united in one person. The film's iconography divides this emblem. Eli carries the sword and the book; Carnegie seeks both. But Eli holds

them as a custodian rather than a sovereign, and the film's argument is that the sword and the book can be borne together without composing a Leviathan only by someone who wants no commonwealth.

Baruch Spinoza's *Tractatus Theologico-Politicus* (1670) is the first great anatomy of Carnegie's project from the side of its victims. Its preface diagnoses, in R. H. M. Elwes's translation, "the supreme mystery of despotism, its prop and stay," which is "to keep men in a state of deception, and with the specious title of religion to cloak the fear by which they must be held in check, so that they will fight for their servitude, as if for salvation." No sentence in the literature describes more exactly what Carnegie means when he calls the Bible a weapon aimed at the desperate. But Spinoza's treatise also supplies the counter-hermeneutic by which the film defeats its villain. Scripture, Spinoza argues in chapters 13 and 14, demands nothing of its readers but obedience, and obedience consists solely in the love of one's neighbour; its theological speculations are accommodations to the understanding of its first audiences, while its moral core is simple, universal, and accessible to all. Eli's final realization, that the substance of the book he spent thirty years protecting is the injunction to do more for others than for oneself, is Spinoza's reduction of scripture to its ethical kernel, reached by a blind man in a stolen truck on the road to the sea.

Jean-Jacques Rousseau's *Social Contract* (1762) completes the classical theory. The Legislator of Book II, chapter 7, must persuade a people to accept laws whose wisdom they cannot yet understand, and therefore, in G. D. H. Cole's translation, puts his decisions "into the mouth of the immortals, in order to constrain by divine authority those whom human prudence could not move." The civil religion of Book IV, chapter 8, is a minimal creed established by the sovereign for its social utility. Carnegie is Rousseau's Legislator without Rousseau's virtue: a founder who would put his own commands into the mouth of God.

The early modern history of the very version Eli carries belongs to this genealogy. The Authorized Version was commissioned by James VI and I after the Hampton Court Conference of 1604, and among the king's evident motives was hostility to the Geneva Bible, whose marginal notes he regarded as seditious, since several appeared to sanction disobedience to tyrannical rulers; the new translation was to carry no such annotation. James was the author of *The True Lawe of Free Monarchies* (1598) and *Basilikon Doron* (1599), the most uncompromising defences of the divine right of kings in the English language. The King James Bible is, in its origin, a monarch's Bible, and its traditional title announces that it was *authorized*. Carnegie's project is therefore not a perversion of the history of Eli's book but a return to one of its origins. Against that origin stands another. William Tyndale, from whose translations much of the Authorized Version's New Testament wording descends, is reported by John Foxe to have told a learned opponent that he would cause a boy who drives the plough to know more of the scripture than he did; betrayed in Antwerp in 1535 by Henry Phillips and condemned for heresy under the authority of the Emperor Charles V, Tyndale was strangled and burned at Vilvoorde in 1536 for making the Bible available to that

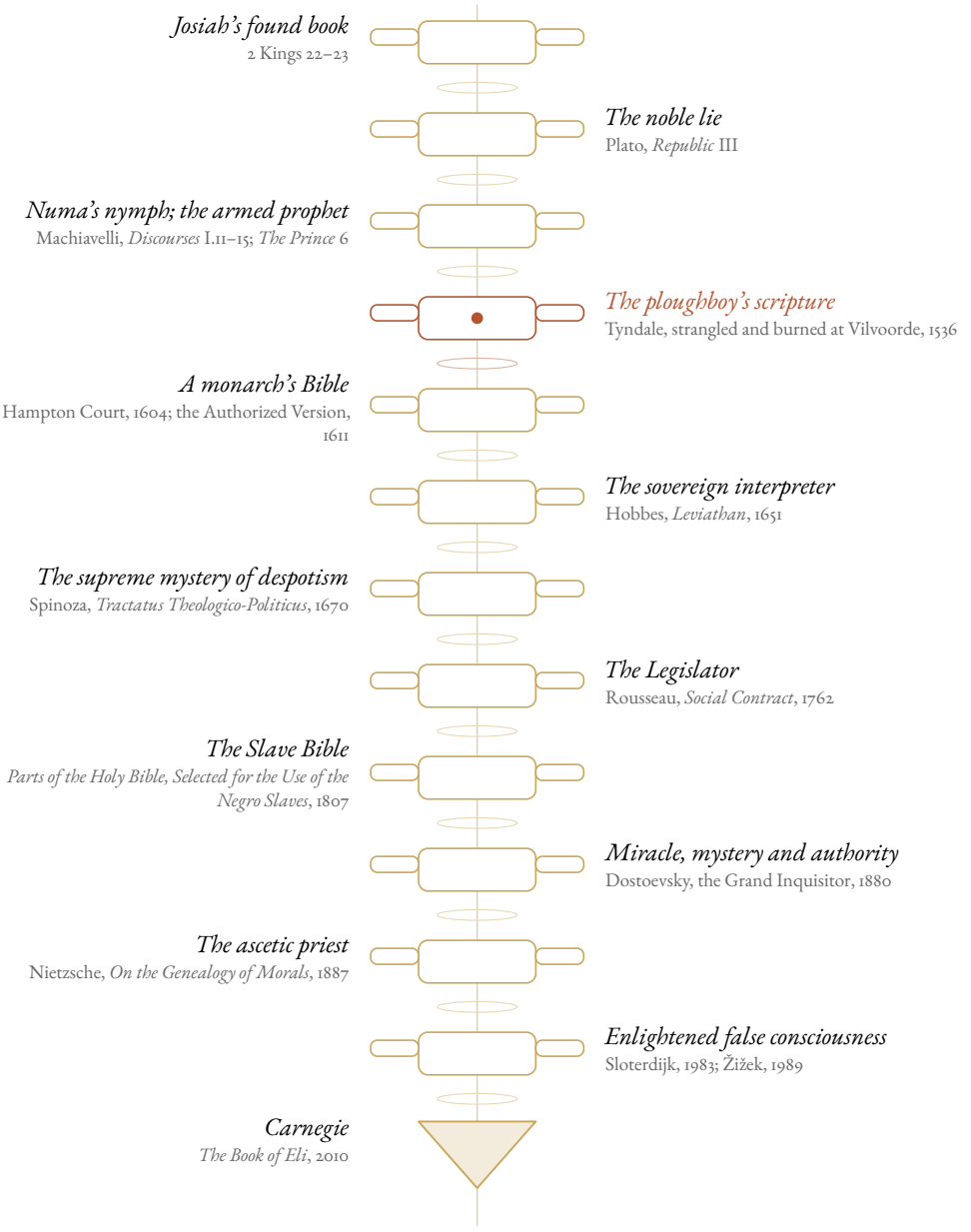


FIGURE 7

The hidden spine

The genealogy of instrumental scripture that Day Two assembles behind Carnegie's claim that this has happened before, read from Josiah's found book to the warlord. In red, Tyndale: the counter-genealogy the same book carries, the martyr's vernacular gift.

ploughboy. The book Eli carries thus bears within its own history the two genealogies the film sets in conflict: the sovereign's authorized instrument and the martyr's vernacular gift.

The darkest station is American. In 1807 a London society for the conversion of enslaved Africans in the British West Indies published *Parts of the Holy Bible, Selected for the Use of the Negro Slaves*, an edition from which the narratives of liberation, above all the Exodus, had been excised, while texts commanding servants to be obedient to their masters (Ephesians 6:5) were retained. This "Slave Bible" is the historical realization of Carnegie's plan: scripture edited into an instrument of domination aimed at the hearts and minds of the desperate. That the film's custodian of the complete Bible is played by a Black actor, and its would-be editor of scripture into an instrument of rule is a white warlord surrounded by an armed retinue, gives this genealogy a charge that Day Six will develop.

Finally, the literary apotheosis of the instrumental theory is Fyodor Dostoevsky's "Grand Inquisitor" (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880, Book V, ch. 5). The Inquisitor, confronting a returned Christ in sixteenth-century Seville on the day after he has had nearly a hundred heretics burned in an auto-da-fé before the king, the court, and the city, explains that the Church has corrected His work by relieving humanity of the unbearable gift of freedom; in Constance Garnett's translation, there are "three powers, three powers alone, able to conquer and to hold captive for ever the conscience of these impotent rebels for their happiness," namely "miracle, mystery and authority." The Inquisitor's speech is a commentary on the three temptations in the wilderness (Matthew 4:1–11), in which Satan offers bread, a miraculous sign, and "all the kingdoms of the world, and the glory of them." The film restages the temptation in Carnegie's town. The warlord offers the wanderer food, water, lodging, a share in rule, and a woman, in exchange for his service; he shows him, from his own seat of power, the only kingdom left in the world. Eli refuses as Christ refused, and his refusal, like Christ's before the Inquisitor, is nearly wordless. Dostoevsky's Christ answers the Inquisitor's long argument with a kiss. Eli answers Carnegie's offer by leaving.

Friedrich Nietzsche gives the genealogy its most unsparing psychology. The ascetic priest of *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887, III.15–16) is the physician of a suffering herd who governs it by changing the direction of its *ressentiment*, teaching the sufferer that someone must be to blame, namely himself. Carnegie wishes to be such a priest, administering the suffering of the desperate. *The Antichrist* (1895) distinguishes the practice of Jesus, a way of life without resentment, resistance, or doctrine, from the priestly religion that Paul, in Nietzsche's polemic, constructed out of it as an instrument of power; it is the evangelical practice alone, Nietzsche insists, that leads to God. The film enacts Nietzsche's distinction with surprising fidelity: Carnegie wants the doctrine, Eli finally arrives at the practice. That it closes, nonetheless, on a Pauline sentence is a contradiction to which Day Seven will return. Peter Sloterdijk's *Critique of Cynical Reason* (1983) names Carnegie's state of mind: "enlightened false consciousness," the condition of those who know their ideology to be false and maintain it anyway as an instrument. Sloterdijk opposes to modern *cynicism* the

ancient *kynicism* of Diogenes, the plebeian, embodied, mocking refusal of power by one who has renounced its comforts; and Eli, who sleeps in ruins, eats a stray cat, and walks away from the only comfortable room in the world, is a kynic in exactly this sense. Slavoj Žižek's formula for cynical ideology in *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (1989), that its subjects know very well what they are doing and do it nonetheless, describes Carnegie perfectly, with one decisive addition: Carnegie also believes, against his own cynicism, that the book possesses a power independent of any reader, which is why he cannot imagine that it might be withheld from him by its very form.

2.5

The Iconoclasts: The Other Answer to Carnegie

Carnegie's instrumental theory has a mirror image, and the film's backstory belongs to it. If scripture is a weapon, one may seize it, or one may destroy it. The survivors of the flash, persuaded that religion had caused the war, chose destruction, and the Bibles of the old world were burned. The scene belongs to a long history. Heinrich Heine's tragedy *Almansor* (1821), set in Granada after the Christian conquest, contains the line that a later century would read as prophecy: where they burn books, they will in the end burn people too. The occasion in Heine's play is the burning of the Qur'an in Granada, an echo of the Arabic books that Cardinal Jiménez de Cisneros had burned there around 1500. On 10 May 1933 the line's first half was enacted in the Opernplatz in Berlin, where students organized by the German Student Union, addressed by Joseph Goebbels, threw into the fire the books of Jewish, socialist, and other proscribed authors, Heine's among them. The regime that staged that burning went on to murder some six million Jews, and the crematoria of its extermination camps fulfilled the second half with a literalness Heine could not have meant. Bradbury's firemen and Miller's Simpletons belong to the same lineage, and so does the Qin emperor's burning of the classics in 213 BCE (to which Day Seven returns), which the historian Sima Qian follows with the emperor's execution, the next year, of more than four hundred and sixty scholars, by tradition buried alive. Some modern historians doubt the account; its pairing of the two acts is Heine's sentence written two thousand years early. The burners and the seizers share a premise: both believe that the book is a power, and both locate that power in the object.

Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) dramatizes the burners' logic with a precision that illuminates Whitta's backstory. Its three pilgrims cross a ruined Zone toward a Room said to grant one's innermost wish; one of them, the Professor, has brought a small nuclear device with which he intends to destroy the Room, lest it fall into the hands of those who would use it to rule. The Professor is the conscientious iconoclast: he would destroy the sacred in order to prevent its political misuse. Tarkovsky's film, like Whitta's, refuses his solution without endorsing the tyrant's. The book-burners of *Eli* are Tarkovsky's Professor writ large: a civilization that, having diagnosed the danger of the sacred, chose to annihilate it. The

film's third position, neither seizure nor destruction, is custody: the sacred object is neither used nor burned but carried, withheld, and finally released in a form that no sovereign can seize.

2.6

Claudia's Refusal

The decisive political act of the film is not performed by its hero. It is performed by a blind woman who says no. When Carnegie at last forces open the captured codex and finds it written in a tactile script, his project has one remaining hope: Claudia, his abused consort, who is blind and can read Braille. Without her, the instrument is mute; with her, he could have his scripture read aloud, memorized by his lieutenants, preached to his town, and carried to other towns. She refuses, pleading that she has forgotten how. The film plays the claim as a feint: she answers his demand by telling him, calmly, that his wound has turned septic and that he has lost too many men to hold the town.

The act is a lie told by a beaten woman to the man who beats her, and its form has a name. James C. Scott's *Weapons of the Weak* (1985) and *Domination and the Arts of Resistance* (1990) catalogued the everyday resistance of those who cannot risk open revolt, among them foot-dragging, false compliance, dissimulation, and feigned ignorance, and placed it in the "hidden transcript" that the dominated keep beneath the public performance of submission. Claudia's forgetting is that transcript surfacing at the one moment it can no longer be punished.

Claudia's refusal must be read against three figures. The first is Huldah, the prophetess to whom Josiah sent the found book of the law for authentication (2 Kings 22:14–20): the female reader without whom the king's scriptural reform could not have proceeded. Claudia is the Huldah who will not authenticate, and her refusal undoes in advance the Josianic reform that Carnegie has been planning. The second is the wife of Pontius Pilate, to whom later tradition gave the name Claudia Procula, who sent word to her husband during the trial of Jesus: "Have thou nothing to do with that just man: for I have suffered many things this day in a dream because of him" (Matthew 27:19). The ruler's wife, who sees in darkness what the ruler cannot see in daylight, warns him against the persecution of the righteous man; Carnegie's Claudia, who sees in a darkness more permanent than dream, is beaten by him so that her daughter will betray the righteous man. The third resonance is etymological: *claudus* in Latin means "lame," and the Claudian name was associated in Roman tradition with that disability. The film's two disabled readers, Eli and Claudia, are the only literate subjects of the tactile scripture, and both use their literacy to refuse sovereign appropriation.

The philosophical form of Claudia's act is that of Herman Melville's Bartleby, the copyist of "Bartleby, the Scrivener" (1853), who answers every request to copy or check a document with the formula "I would prefer not to." Gilles Deleuze's essay "Bartleby; or, The Formula" (1989) and Giorgio Agamben's "Bartleby, or On Contingency" (1993) read the scrivener's

formula as the purest expression of potentiality, specifically of the potentiality-not-to, the capacity that remains a capacity precisely by not passing into act. Bartleby is a scribe who refuses to write; Claudia is a reader who refuses to read. Bartleby prefers not to in the open; Claudia, who has learned in Carnegie's house what open refusal costs, refuses under cover of incapacity. In both cases the apparatus of textual power, the law office and the scriptural state, depends upon a functionary whose cooperation it assumes, and in both cases the apparatus stops when the functionary withholds it. Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) located in the proletarian general strike a pure means that does not make law but suspends it; Claudia's refusal is a general strike of one, conducted at the precise point where scriptural sovereignty would have to pass from the object to a reader. The film thereby locates the vulnerability of every theocratic project not in the sanctity of the text but in the freedom of its readers. A scripture that must be read in order to rule can be stopped by anyone who can read it.

2.7

The Captured Ark and the Wounded King

The consequences of Carnegie's possession of the book follow a biblical pattern that the film's figural logic makes unmistakable. When the Philistines captured the Ark of the Covenant, the event at whose report the blind priest Eli fell dead, they carried it into the temple of their god Dagon at Ashdod, and the next morning "Dagon was fallen upon his face to the earth before the ark of the LORD" (1 Samuel 5:3); then "the hand of the LORD was heavy upon them of Ashdod, and he destroyed them" (5:6), and the plague followed the Ark from city to city until the Philistines sent it back. The birth-narrative that closes the preceding chapter names the condition of Israel in the Ark's absence: Eli's daughter-in-law, dying in childbirth, names her son Ichabod, "saying, The glory is departed from Israel: because the ark of God was taken" (4:21). The film's world is Ichabod, a world from which the glory has departed. And Carnegie's town, once it holds the captured book, suffers the fate of Ashdod: its sovereign sickens, its men desert, its order dissolves. The captured sacred object destroys the power that captured it, not by any miracle but by its own illegibility and the refusal of the one reader who could have unlocked it.

Carnegie's sickness has a second genealogy. During his pursuit of Eli he is wounded in the leg, and the wound festers until, by the film's end, it is killing him while his town riots around him. The motif is that of the Fisher King of the Grail romances, whose wound in the thigh or groin is mirrored by the barrenness of his land, as Jessie Weston argued in *From Ritual to Romance* (1920) and as T. S. Eliot made canonical in *The Waste Land* (1922), whose notes acknowledge Weston. In the romances the wounded king awaits a knight who will ask the right question and heal both king and land. Carnegie inverts the type. He is not the wounded king awaiting redemption but the usurper who has seized the vessel himself, and the vessel, once seized, will not speak. His wound is the wound of a sovereignty that

has spent its coercive capital (the men killed in pursuit of the book, the water expended on the chase) without acquiring the ideological capital it sought. The hydraulic king dies of a corruption of his own body's fluids, in a waste land of his own making, holding a grail he cannot read. The second day separated the waters; it also, the film suggests, separates the sovereign from the sacred, and it does so permanently.

DAY THREE



Let the Dry Land Appear

Road, Frontier, Pilgrimage, and the Seed of the Word

And God said, Let the waters under the heaven be gathered together unto one place, and let the dry land appear: and it was so.

GENESIS 1:9 (AV)

3.1

Westward the Course of Empire

Eli walks west. The direction is never explained within the film beyond the voice's instruction, but it is the most overdetermined vector in American culture. In 1726 the philosopher George Berkeley, preparing an ill-fated project to found a college in Bermuda for the education of colonists and Native Americans, composed "Verses on the Prospect of Planting Arts and Learning in America," whose final stanza became the motto of a continent: "Westward the course of empire takes its way; / The first four acts already past, / A fifth shall close the drama with the day: / Time's noblest offspring is the last." In 1866 the trustees of the College of California, seeking a name for the town that would house their campus on the eastern shore of San Francisco Bay, chose Berkeley's, reportedly at the suggestion of a trustee who recalled the verse while looking toward the Golden Gate. The University of California at Berkeley stands within sight of Alcatraz. The prophet of the westward course was also a slaveholder: during his years in Rhode Island, from 1729 to 1731, Berkeley bought enslaved Africans to work his farm at Whitehall, and in a sermon before the Society for the Propagation of the Gospel after his return to London he urged their Christian instruction without urging their freedom. The film's protagonist thus walks the entire course of Berkeley's prophecy, from the burned East to the western sea, and ends his journey across the water from a city named for the philosopher who prophesied that westward movement and who, as Day One showed, held that vision is the language in which God addresses humanity. The fifth act that was to close the drama with the day has closed it with the flash. Time's last offspring is a blind man.

Frederick Jackson Turner's "The Significance of the Frontier in American History" (1893) argued that American democracy and character had been forged at the moving line where civilization met wilderness, and that the closing of that frontier, announced by the census of 1890, marked the end of the first period of American history. John O'Sullivan's phrase "Manifest Destiny" (1845) gave the westward movement its providential sanction, and the sanction covered what the movement did: the war on Mexico of 1846–48; the removal of Native nations from their lands; and, in California, a campaign of killing that the state's first governor, Peter Burnett, told the legislature in 1851 must be expected to continue as "a war of extermination" until the Indian race became extinct, and that California's governor formally acknowledged as genocide in 2019. Its iconographic summa is John Gast's painting *American Progress* (1872), in which a colossal, luminous woman in white floats westward across the continent, carrying a schoolbook in one hand and stringing telegraph wire with the other; behind her, in the east, the sky is bright; before her, in the west, darkness and the fleeing Indigenous peoples and bison recede. *American Progress* is a picture of a book carried westward as light driving out darkness. *The Book of Eli* is its photographic negative. The book-bearer is not a radiant white goddess but a Black man who cannot see; the light comes not from the bearer but from the catastrophe that destroyed the East; the West is not

darkness to be enlightened but the last refuge of the written word. Gast's Columbia carried the book to conquer; Eli carries it to escape. And when, at the end, the burden passes to a young woman who walks back into the continent, the film completes its revision of Gast: the female bearer now walks *east*, or at least away from the sea, carrying not the book, which remains in the archive, but the way.

3.2

The Stranger Who Comes to Town

Generically, Eli is the stranger of the Western, and his arrival in Carnegie's town is staged according to the conventions of the form: the lone rider (here the lone walker) enters a corrupt settlement dominated by a boss and his gang, displays a capacity for violence in the saloon, is courted by the boss, refuses, and leaves the town transformed. George Stevens's *Shane* (1953) established the stranger as a figure of quasi-sacred violence who protects a community he cannot join. Clint Eastwood's *High Plains Drifter* (1973) and *Pale Rider* (1985) made the stranger explicitly supernatural; the latter's protagonist, a nameless gunfighter known as the Preacher, arrives as the answer to a girl's reading of Revelation 6:8, "And I looked, and behold a pale horse: and his name that sat on him was Death," and bears on his back the scars of bullet wounds that should have killed him. Eli inherits the Preacher's ambiguous invulnerability, his scriptural aura, and his status as the answer to a prayer, with the difference that he is not a revenant but a living man whose protection, as Day Four argues, the film refuses to adjudicate.

The Western's stranger was itself a translation of the Japanese *rōnin*, the masterless samurai, by way of Sergio Leone's *A Fistful of Dollars* (1964), an unauthorized remake of Akira Kurosawa's *Yojimbo* (1961). And in the samurai tradition the film's protagonist has a specific ancestor: Zatōichi, the blind masseur and gambler-swordsman created by the novelist Kan Shimozawa and incarnated by Shintarō Katsu in a cycle of films beginning with *The Tale of Zatoichi* (1962). Zatōichi is a wanderer who cannot see, who fights by hearing, whose opponents consistently underestimate him, and whose blade is hidden in a cane; Phillip Noyce's *Blind Fury* (1989) transplanted him to America. Eli is Zatōichi's heir with one structural transformation: Zatōichi's blindness is known from the first frame and is the premise of every encounter, while Eli's is concealed from the audience and revealed only at the end. The samurai film makes blindness a visible paradox; the American film makes it a twist. The difference measures the distance between a culture comfortable with the paradox of the blind master and one that must surprise itself into it.

The samurai lineage supplies a further term. Miyamoto Musashi, the most celebrated swordsman of seventeenth-century Japan, spent his last years in a cave writing *The Book of Five Rings* (*Go rin no sho*, 1645), and in the week before his death composed the twenty-one precepts of the *Dokkōdō*, "The Path of Aloneness." The wandering swordsman who ends his life as the author of a book of the Way is Eli's nearest Japanese analogue, and the word that

binds them is *path*. Eli's discipline is summed up in the injunction he gives himself when tempted to intervene in violence that does not concern his mission: stay on the path. The word carries the full weight of the traditions the film draws upon. In the Book of Acts, before they were called Christians, the followers of Jesus were called those "of this way" (Acts 9:2), *hē hodos*, the Way; Saul was travelling to arrest them when the light struck him. Jesus names himself "the way, the truth, and the life" (John 14:6). The Chinese *dao* and the Japanese *dō* name the same concept in the traditions that produced the samurai film. And the Sermon on the Mount supplies the destination: "Enter ye in at the strait gate ... Because strait is the gate, and narrow is the way, which leadeth unto life, and few there be that find it" (Matthew 7:13–14). The Authorized Version's *strait* means *narrow*; it is also the geographer's word for a narrow passage of water between two lands. Eli's way ends at the Golden Gate, the strait through which San Francisco Bay meets the Pacific. The narrow way leads, with a literalness that only the King James English makes visible, to the strait gate.

3.3

The Pilgrim's Regress: Bunyan After the Flash

The master-intertext of the film's narrative structure is not a film but the most widely read work of English prose fiction before the novel. John Bunyan's *The Pilgrim's Progress* (1678) opens with a dreamer who sees "a man clothed with rags, standing in a certain place, with his face from his own house, a book in his hand, and a great burden upon his back." The man opens the book, reads, weeps, and trembles, and then sets out from the City of Destruction toward the Celestial City. Eli's first appearance in the film is this image almost exactly: a man in ragged layers, a pack upon his back, a book that he reads alone, setting his face away from a destroyed world toward a distant city. The correspondences extend across the whole itinerary. Bunyan's Christian passes through Vanity Fair, a town devoted to commerce in which every kind of merchandise is sold, including, in Bunyan's catalogue, "lusts, pleasures, and delights of all sorts," and wives, husbands, and children; there the pilgrims are mocked for their strange speech and dress, put on trial, and Christian's companion Faithful is executed. Carnegie's town is Vanity Fair after the flash: a market in which water, batteries, and women are traded, whose ruler tries the pilgrim and attempts to purchase him, and from which he escapes only by violence. After Faithful's death Christian is joined by a second companion, Hopeful, who travels with him to the end; Solara, who follows Eli out of Carnegie's town, is his Hopeful. Before the Celestial City lies the River of Death, which the pilgrims must cross through deep water; beyond it the gate where each must present the certificate given him at the start of the journey, and at which one pilgrim, Ignorance, having no certificate, is thrown into a door in the side of the hill, so that Bunyan's dreamer observes that there was a way to hell even from the gates of heaven. Eli crosses the bay by boat to reach the island; he arrives at its gate without the book that should have been his certificate; and he is admitted nonetheless, because the certificate is in him.

Bunyan's text contains a further episode that the film recapitulates with remarkable fidelity. Midway up the Hill Difficulty, Christian falls asleep in an arbour, and the roll he was given at the beginning of his pilgrimage, the scroll that is to be his passport at the Celestial Gate, slips from his hand; he must retrace his steps in anguish to recover it. The loss of the book is thus a structural moment in the founding narrative of Protestant pilgrimage. Eli too loses his book, to Carnegie, at the homestead; but unlike Christian he does not go back for it. The difference measures the film's theology against Bunyan's. For Bunyan the roll is indispensable, an external assurance without which the pilgrim cannot pass the gate. For the film the book can be lost because it has been interiorized; the pilgrim no longer carries the Word, he has become its carrier in the stronger sense of its vessel.

The historical circumstances of Bunyan's book give the correspondence its sharpest edge. Bunyan was a tinker, a working-class lay preacher without a licence, imprisoned in Bedford gaol for twelve years under the Restoration's Act of Uniformity (1662) and associated statutes for refusing to stop preaching outside the established Church. He wrote much of *The Pilgrim's Progress* in prison. The book that became the second bible of English-speaking Protestantism was thus composed by an unauthorized preacher imprisoned by the state church for unlicensed proclamation of the Authorized Version's text. Eli is Bunyan's lay prophet: an unlicensed, uncredentialled man without church or office, carrying the authorized text outside every authority. And his journey ends, as Bunyan's composition began, in a prison.

3.4

Dust Bowl and Open Road

The American road narrative supplies the film's second structural matrix. John Steinbeck's *The Grapes of Wrath* (1939) follows the Joad family westward from the Dust Bowl along Route 66 to California, through a landscape that the 1930s experienced as a proto-apocalypse of dust storms, foreclosures, and mass migration. Its title comes from Julia Ward Howe's "Battle Hymn of the Republic" (1862), whose first line, "Mine eyes have seen the glory of the coming of the Lord," and whose "grapes of wrath" derive from the apocalyptic winepress of Revelation 14:19–20: the American road narrative is apocalyptic in its very title. The novel's most theologically charged figure is Jim Casy, a former preacher, his initials those of Jesus Christ, who has lost his faith in doctrine and found in its place a conviction that all human beings share a single great soul; he dies defending striking workers. Casy's movement from doctrine to solidarity anticipates Eli's movement from guardianship to love. And the novel's final image, in which Rose of Sharon, having lost her child, gives her breast to a starving stranger in a flooded barn, is the archetype of the gift of the body to the dying that the film's ending inverts: in Steinbeck the young woman nourishes the old man with her body; in Whitta the old man nourishes the young woman, and the world, with his memory, and dies.

Jack Kerouac's *On the Road* (1957) secularized the westward pilgrimage into the Beat search for experience, but Kerouac, a Catholic who glossed "beat" as "beatific," never fully secularized it. The film's road is Kerouac's road with the jazz replaced by Al Green and the speed replaced by the walk. Its distinctive temporality is the slowness of a journey that takes thirty years to cross a continent that Kerouac's characters crossed in days: a slowness that marks the walk not as experience-seeking but as vocation.

3.5

Ely and Eli: The Apophatic and the Cataphatic Prophet

Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* (2006), released as John Hillcoat's film in November 2009, is the film's nearest contemporary and its most illuminating foil. Its father and son walk south through an ash-shrouded America toward the sea, sustained by the father's insistence that they are "the good guys" who are "carrying the fire," pursued by cannibals, scavenging canned goods from the ruins. The father dies; the boy is taken in by a family whose mother speaks to him of God. The novel's closing paragraph turns away from the human story to the brook trout that once lived in mountain streams, bearing on their backs patterns that were maps of the world in its becoming, a thing that could not be put back. Midway through the novel the travellers meet an old, nearly blind man who says his name is Ely, though he later admits it is not. He speaks to the father of God, and of the end of men, and tells him: "There is no God and we are his prophets."

The coincidence is so precise that it constitutes, within the constellation of 2009–2010, a dialectical pair. Two nearly or wholly blind wanderers named Ely and Eli appeared in American cinemas within two months of one another, each in a burned America, each in a narrative about walking toward the sea. McCarthy's Ely is the apophatic prophet carried to its atheistic terminus: the *via negativa* of Pseudo-Dionysius, which negates every predicate of God in order to approach a God beyond predication, here negates the subject itself, and leaves only the prophecy. Whitta's Eli is the cataphatic prophet: he affirms, in the most literal way possible, that God has spoken, since he carries every word that God is held to have said. Yet the two converge at the level of practice. McCarthy's novel, despite Ely's declaration, ends in a mother's speech about the breath of God passing from person to person; Whitta's film, despite its affirmations, ends with an ethical reduction of the whole canon to a single obligation toward others. Ely denies God and the novel discovers grace; Eli affirms God and the film discovers ethics. The two prophets of 2009–2010 meet at the point where theology becomes the care of the one who walks beside you.

3.6

The Psalter Triptych: Psalm 22, Psalm 23, Psalm 24

The only scriptural text recited at length within the narrative before Alcatraz is the Twenty-Third Psalm, which Eli speaks with Solara as they travel. The choice is conventional, the most familiar psalm in the English-speaking world, but its function in the film is structural, for Psalm 23 is a précis of the entire narrative. "The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want": Eli, in a world of absolute want, lacks nothing he needs. "He leadeth me beside the still waters": in a world whose waters are monopolized by a tyrant, the psalm promises waters no one owns. "He leadeth me in the paths of righteousness": the path. "Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil": the wasteland is the valley of the shadow of death, and the walk is literal. "Thy rod and thy staff they comfort me": the blade. "Thou preparest a table before me in the presence of mine enemies": the meal Eli shares with Solara, at which he teaches her to give thanks, takes place in a room in Carnegie's own house, a table prepared in the presence of the enemy. "My cup runneth over": in a hydraulic despotism, the overflowing cup is an eschatological image of abundance against scarcity. "Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life": Solara, uninvited, follows him out of the town. "And I will dwell in the house of the LORD for ever": the archive.

The psalm's canonical neighbours complete the figure. Psalm 22 opens with the cry that Jesus quotes from the cross: "My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?" In Matthew's Greek transliteration of the Hebrew, the cry begins *Eli, Eli* (Matthew 27:46). The film's title, read through the cry of dereliction, is *The Book of My God*, and it names a world that has every reason to believe itself forsaken. Psalm 24 then proclaims: "Lift up your heads, O ye gates; and be ye lift up, ye everlasting doors; and the King of glory shall come in" (24:7). Christian homiletic tradition has long read Psalms 22, 23, and 24 as a triptych of the cross, the shepherd, and the crown: suffering, guidance, and entry through the gates. The film distributes the triptych across its structure. Psalm 22 is in the protagonist's name; Psalm 23 is in his mouth; Psalm 24 is his destination, the gate of the island at the Golden Gate. The narrative moves through the Psalter as Eli moves through the continent, from dereliction through guidance to the gates.

3.7

The Seed Is the Word

The film opens in a dead forest. Ash falls like snow through grey, leafless trunks; nothing grows. The image inverts the third day of creation, on which the earth brought forth "grass, the herb yielding seed, and the fruit tree yielding fruit" (Genesis 1:11), and recalls the prophet Joel's lament over a land stripped by locusts and drought, in which "the seed is rotten under their clods" (Joel 1:17). The dead forest poses the question of what can be sown in a world that grows nothing, and the film's answer comes from the parable that Jesus himself interprets:
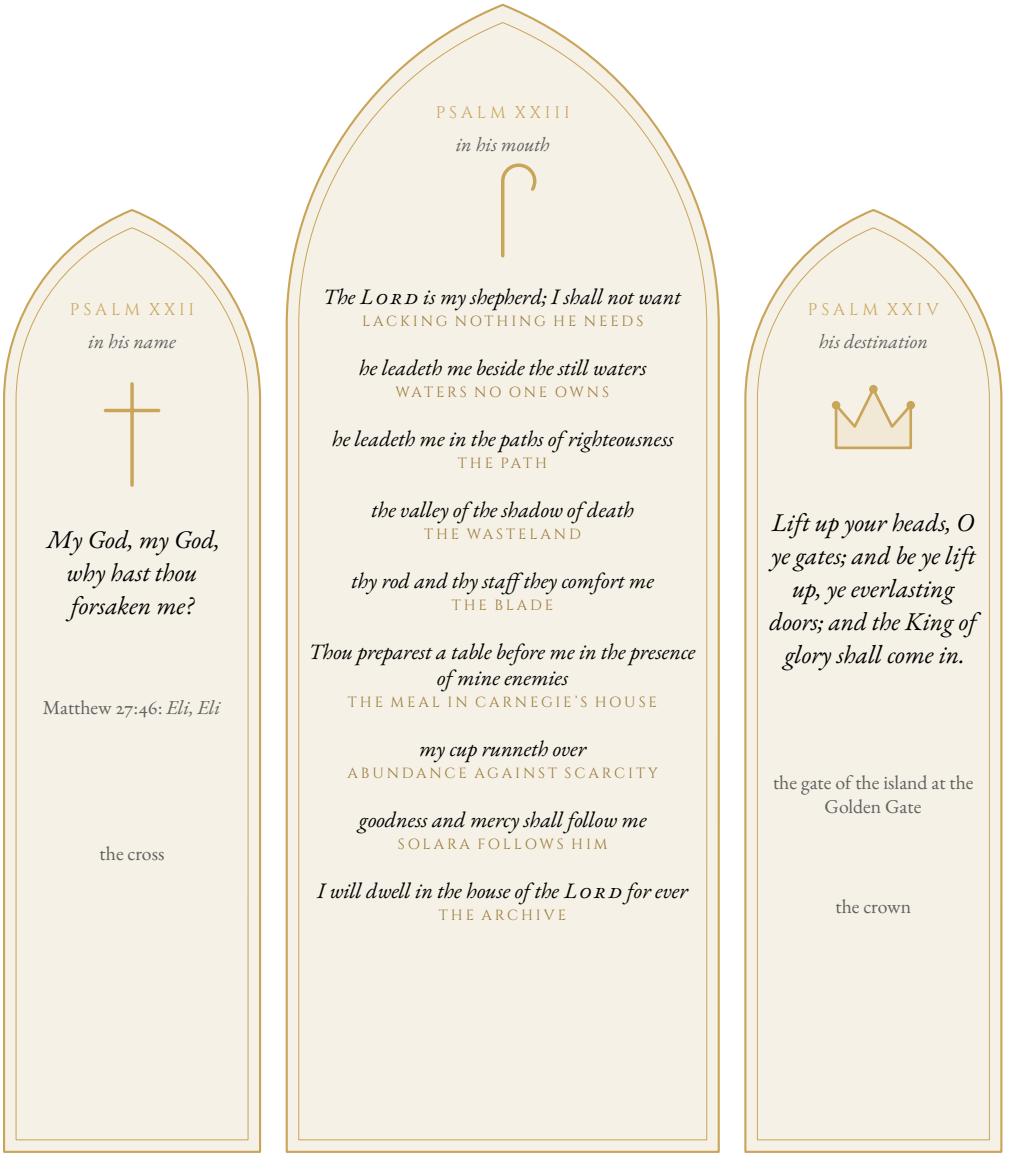


FIGURE 8

The Psalter triptych

Psalms 22, 23 and 24, read in Christian homiletic tradition as the cross, the shepherd and the crown, distributed across the film: the first in the protagonist's name, the second in his mouth, the third at his destination. The centre follows Day Three's reading of the Twenty-Third Psalm as a précis of the narrative.

"Now the parable is this: The seed is the word of God" (Luke 8:11). Some of it falls by the wayside, some on rock, some among thorns, and some on good ground, which "bare fruit an hundredfold" (8:8).

Read through the parable, a feature of the film that criticism has treated as mere decorum becomes structural. Eli is celibate, and his refusal of Solara's sexual offer is not only an ethical refusal of a coerced encounter; it is a refusal of the biological seed in favour of the verbal. He does not father a child; he engenders a successor and a text. The hundredfold yield of the good ground is realized by the printing press at Alcatraz, which multiplies the dictated word into copies; and the one in whom the seed takes root in a human life is Solara, who becomes a sower in her turn. The patristic tradition knew this doctrine as that of the *logos spermatikos*, the "seminal word" that Justin Martyr (*Second Apology*, 8 and 13) held to be scattered among all peoples. The film's seminal logic is literal: in a world where nothing grows and children are few, the only reproduction that matters is the transmission of the Word.

The film's composition coincided with the most spectacular real-world realization of this logic. The Svalbard Global Seed Vault, dug into the permafrost of a Norwegian Arctic island and opened in February 2008, was designed to preserve duplicates of the world's crop diversity against regional or global catastrophe; the press called it the "doomsday vault." It is the agronomic twin of the Alcatraz archive: an island fortress holding the seeds of a civilization against its own destruction. Miller's *A Canticle for Leibowitz* had imagined the same logic in ecclesial form. At the end of its third part, as a second nuclear war consumes the earth, a starship departs carrying monks, children, and the Memorabilia to the stars, so that the Church becomes a seed borne out of a dying world. *Eli*'s ending is quieter and, I will argue, more radical. The seed is not carried away from the earth but sown back into it: printed for whoever will read, and walked back into the continent by a young woman who does not carry the book, but carries the way of the one who did.

DAY FOUR



Lights for Signs and Seasons

Malachian Architecture and the Post-Eschatological Katechon

And God said, Let there be lights in the firmament of the heaven to divide the day from the night; and let them be for signs, and for seasons, and for days, and years.

GENESIS 1:14 (AV)

4.1

The Time of the End

On the fourth day the luminaries are set in the firmament "for signs, and for seasons, and for days, and years": the sun and moon are created not as sources of light, which already exists, but as instruments of time. The fourth day is the day of chronology, and the post-apocalyptic genre is, before it is anything else, a problem of chronology: how to narrate time after the end of time. Frank Kermode's *The Sense of an Ending* (1967) argued that fictions of apocalypse are the paradigm of all plotted fiction, which confers meaning on the middle by projecting an end; he distinguished *chronos*, mere successive time, from *kairos*, time charged with significance by its relation to the end, and observed that in modernity the end ceases to be *imminent* and becomes *immanent*, pervading the present as a permanent crisis. James Berger's *After the End: Representations of Post-Apocalypse* (1999) identified the structural peculiarity of the post-apocalyptic text: it takes place after an end that should have ended everything, in a time that by its own logic should not exist, and its characteristic task is to work through the remainder of a catastrophe that both happened and failed to complete itself. Günther Anders gave this condition its sharpest philosophical formulation. Since 1945, Anders argued, humanity lives not in the *Zeitenende*, the end of time, but in the *Endzeit*, the time of the end: an epoch defined by the permanent possibility of its own termination.

The film's chronology is precisely Berger's "after the end." It takes place thirty years after the flash, in a time the flash should have abolished. But it refuses both of the great modern schemas by which the West has narrated time after catastrophe. It is not progressive: Karl Löwith's *Meaning in History* (1949) argued that the modern philosophies of progress were secularized eschatologies, and Hans Blumenberg's *The Legitimacy of the Modern Age* (1966) contested the thesis; the film's world has no progress to secularize. Nor is it cyclical in the manner of Miller's *Canticle*, whose three parts (*Fiat Homo*, *Fiat Lux*, *Fiat Voluntas Tua*) trace a civilization rebuilding itself only to destroy itself again, or of Oswald Spengler's *The Decline of the West* (1918), with its organic morphology of cultures. The nearest classical model is Giambattista Vico's *Scienza nuova* (1725; third edition 1744), whose history passes through an age of gods, an age of heroes, and an age of men, and which ends in a "barbarism of reflection" more inhuman than the original barbarism of sense, a condition of calculating, cynical intellect in which every bond dissolves; from it a *ricorso* returns humanity to a new age of gods. Carnegie is Vico's barbarism of reflection personified, the cynic for whom religion is calculation. The film's post-apocalypse is a *ricorso*: the return of an age in which the sacred again structures human life. But Vico's *ricorso* repeats the cycle. The film's, as the conclusion argues, opens something the cycle cannot contain.

The film's time is therefore best described in the terms of Jacques Derrida's essay on nuclear criticism, "No Apocalypse, Not Now (full speed ahead, seven missiles, seven missives)" (1984). Derrida observed that nuclear war was, in 1984, a "fabulously textual" event, existing

only in discourse, and that its absolute referent was the total and remainderless destruction of the archive, of the symbolic capital of humanity: literature, which depends on an archive more radically than any other institution, is the thing most at stake. *The Book of Eli* imagines the nuclear war that was, for Derrida, only textual, and imagines it as precisely a destruction of the archive that is *nearly* total and therefore not remainderless. The remainder is one book. The whole film is the time of that remainder.

Two of this thesis's keywords name that time precisely. The first is the remnant. Isaiah gave one of his sons the name Shearjashub, which means "a remnant shall return" (Isaiah 7:3; compare 10:21), and Paul adopted the figure for the faithful of his own day: "Even so then at this present time also there is a remnant according to the election of grace" (Romans 11:5). Agamben's *The Time That Remains* reads the Pauline remnant not as a surviving part destined to become a new whole but as what prevents any whole from closing: neither all nor part, the remainder that divides every division. The film's survivors are a remnant in the numerical sense, and Carnegie's project is to make them a people, a totality under a new law. Eli is a remnant within the remnant, and the archive he founds declines to become a totality: it prints for anyone and rules no one. The second keyword is messianic time, which Agamben, glossing Paul's "the time is short" (1 Corinthians 7:29), defines as the time that time takes to come to an end, a contracted time within chronology rather than a time after it. Walter Benjamin's "On the Concept of History," written in 1940, months before his death at Portbou on the Spanish border in flight from the Nazi occupation of France, attributes to every generation a weak messianic power over the past and warns that not even the dead will be safe from the enemy if he wins. The Alcatraz archive keeps the dead of the burned world from Carnegie. Eli's thirty years are messianic time in Agamben's sense: not the end, but the remaining time in which what the end left can still be carried.

4.2

Malachian Architecture

I propose that the film's narrative is architected, whether by authorial design or by the gravitational pull of its typology, by the final chapter of the Old Testament in the Christian canonical order, Malachi 4, which the Authorized Version prints as the last page before the Gospel of Matthew. The chapter is four verses of compressed eschatology in which each of the film's governing elements appears in sequence.

It opens with the burning day: "For, behold, the day cometh, that shall burn as an oven; and all the proud, yea, and all that do wickedly, shall be stubble: and the day that cometh shall burn them up" (4:1). This is the flash. It continues with the sun: "But unto you that fear my name shall the Sun of righteousness arise with healing in his wings" (4:2). In a world in which the sun has become a destroyer and every eye is shielded against it, the prophet promises another sun that heals; and the film's successor, the figure who will carry its covenant into the future, is named Solara. It turns to the prophet: "Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet



FIGURE 9

Malachian architecture

The verses of Malachi 4 in which Day Four finds the film's theological skeleton, in canonical order: the burning day, the healing sun, Elijah, and the turning of the hearts of fathers and children. The Authorized Version prints the chapter as the last page before the Gospel of Matthew.

before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD" (4:5). The protagonist bears the abbreviated name of Elijah. And it closes with the work that Elijah is to accomplish: "And he shall turn the heart of the fathers to the children, and the heart of the children to their fathers, lest I come and smite the earth with a curse" (4:6). The relationship that the film develops between the old man and the young woman, initially transactional, then protective, then filial, culminating in his confession to her and her inheritance of his mission, is precisely a turning of the heart of a father to a child and of a child to a father, accomplished in a world already smitten with a curse.

The Malachian sequence (burning day, healing sun, Elijah, the reconciliation of generations) is the film's plot in its theological skeleton. Its position in the canon gives it a further significance. Malachi 4 is the hinge of the Christian Bible, the point at which the Old Testament closes on a promise and the New opens on its fulfilment; the Gospels identify the promised Elijah with John the Baptist (Matthew 11:14; 17:10–13), the "voice of him that crieth in the wilderness" of Isaiah 40:3. The film's Elijah is likewise a voice in the wilderness, preparing a way, and the hinge on which the film turns is the same: from the burned world of the old covenant to the dictated, printed, and transmitted word of a new one.

4.3

The Post-Eschatological Elijah

The Malachian architecture contains a temporal scandal. Elijah is to be sent *before* the great and dreadful day. The film's Elijah arrives *after* it. The day has already burned; the curse has already smitten the earth; and the forerunner comes thirty years late. This belatedness is not a flaw in the typology but its most original feature. Franz Kafka, in a notebook entry of December 1917, imagined a Messiah who arrives only once he has become superfluous: he will come a day after his own advent, not on the last day but on the very last. Kafka's paradox names the condition of redemption in a world for which the eschatological schedule has broken down. The film's Eli is a Kafkan Elijah: a forerunner without a successor event to precede, whose task is no longer to announce the end but to carry something across it. The Jewish liturgy has long kept a place for this belated Elijah. At the Passover *seder* a cup is poured for him, and the door is opened in the hope of his arrival; the cup remains full and the chair empty year after year, a ritual institution of expectant delay. At Alcatraz, as Day Seven will show, a place on a shelf awaits the book he brings.

The Mosaic typology sharpens the paradox into a chiasmus. At the end of Deuteronomy, Moses is taken to the summit of Nebo and shown the whole of the promised land, and the LORD says to him: "I have caused thee to see it with thine eyes, but thou shalt not go over thither" (34:4). The narrator adds that at his death, at a hundred and twenty years, "his eye was not dim, nor his natural force abated" (34:7). Moses sees and does not enter. Eli enters and does not see. The undimmed eye of the lawgiver who may not cross the Jordan is answered by the sightless eye of the custodian who crosses the bay and reaches the island, only to die there. Between them stands the whole economy of the film: entry is purchased by blindness, and arrival coincides with death.

4.4

The Katechon: He Who Withholds

The most consequential eschatological concept for the film's political theology is one that appears only once in scripture, in a passage of notorious obscurity. In the Second Epistle to the Thessalonians, Paul warns that the day of the Lord will not come until "that man of sin be revealed, the son of perdition; who opposeth and exalteth himself above all that is called God, or that is worshipped; so that he as God sitteth in the temple of God, shewing himself that he is God" (2:3–4); and he adds that "the mystery of iniquity doth already work: only he who now letteth will let, until he be taken out of the way" (2:7). The Authorized Version's archaic *letteth* means *hinders*; the Greek is *ho katechōn*, "the one who withholds" or "restrains," and its neuter form *to katechon* appears in the preceding verse. Patristic exegesis commonly identified the restrainer with the Roman Empire, whose order delayed the advent of lawlessness. Carl Schmitt, in *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950), made the *katechon* the key

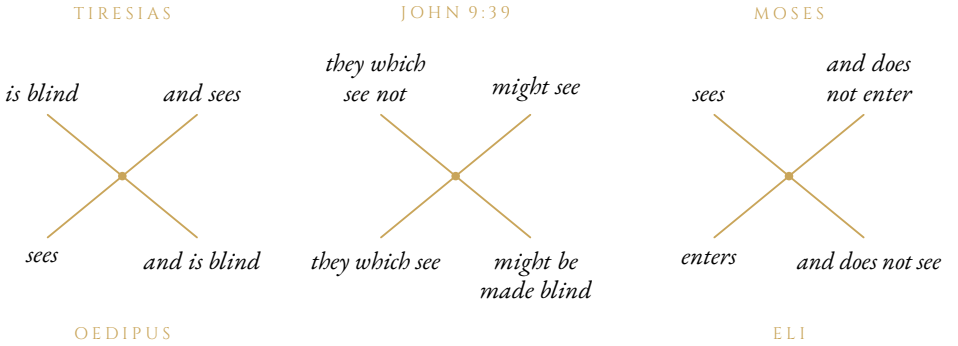


FIGURE 10

Three chiasmi of sight

Tiresias, who is blind and sees, and Oedipus, who sees and is blind (Day One); the judgement of John 9:39; and Moses on Nebo answered by Eli at the island: "Moses sees and does not enter. Eli enters and does not see."

concept of a Christian political theology, arguing that the Christian empire of the Middle Ages understood itself as the force restraining the Antichrist and so deferring the end, and that this self-understanding was the condition of its historical capacity. The concept cannot be borrowed without its author's history. Schmitt joined the Nazi party in 1933, defended Hitler's killing of his rivals in the purge of June 1934 in an article titled "The Führer Protects the Law," and in 1936 convened a conference of jurists that called for Jewish authors to be purged from German legal scholarship; the theorist of the restraining power served, in those years, a power that restrained nothing. Jacob Taubes, Schmitt's Jewish interlocutor and antagonist, read Paul against Schmitt as a messianic thinker hostile to every restraining order (*The Political Theology of Paul*, lectures of 1987, published 1993). Giorgio Agamben's *The Time That Remains* (2000) and Massimo Cacciari's *Il potere che frena* (2013) reopened the question for twenty-first-century political philosophy.

The film offers a figure that none of these theorists anticipated: a *post-eschatological katechon*. Its Antichrist is legible with almost diagrammatic clarity. Carnegie is the man who exalts himself above every authority and would sit, as God, in the temple, if only he could possess the book that would make his throne a temple. But the end that the *katechon* traditionally restrains has already happened. What Eli withholds is not the eschaton but the conversion of its remainder into sovereignty. He restrains not the coming of the end but the coming of a new order founded on the instrumentalized word. And the film distributes the katechontic function across three agencies. The first is Eli himself, who withholds the book from Carnegie for as long as he can, and surrenders it only to save a life. The second is the book's script: Braille withholds its content from the sighted, so that the codex, once captured, continues to restrain its captor; the text itself is a *katechon*. The third is Claudia,

whose refusal to read withholds the content at the last point where it could have passed into Carnegie's power. Paul's restrainer operates "until he be taken out of the way"; when Eli is taken out of the way by death, what is revealed is not the man of sin, who is dying in his own disintegrating town, but the printed text and the empty road. The katechon's removal coincides with the Antichrist's collapse. The film thus proposes a form of guardianship, *katechontic custody*, that withholds the sacred from sovereignty until it can be released into a condition in which no sovereign can seize it.

The concept needs one further distinction, and literature has already drawn it. In Umberto Eco's *The Name of the Rose* (1980), set in an abbey in 1327, the blind monk Jorge of Burgos, whose name and blindness Eco took from Borges, guards in the library the only surviving copy of the lost second book of Aristotle's *Poetics*, on comedy, because he believes that laughter dissolves the fear on which faith and order rest. He poisons its pages, so that the monks who wet their fingers to turn them die; when he is discovered he tears out the pages and eats them, and the library burns. Jorge is the counterfeit *katechon*: a blind custodian who withholds a book from readers in order to preserve an authority founded on fear. Eli is his inverse at every point. Jorge withholds the book so that no one may read it; Eli withholds it so that no sovereign may own it. Jorge eats the book to destroy it; Eli has eaten the book, in the prophetic sense of Ezekiel 3, to preserve it. Jorge's custody ends in a burned library; Eli's founds one. Katechontic custody is distinguished from its counterfeit not by the act of withholding but by what the withholding serves.

4.5

Signs: Providence and Hesitation

The luminaries were made "for signs," and the film is preoccupied with signs whose status it refuses to settle. Eli claims divine protection, and the narrative appears to bear him out: in the sequence of his departure from Carnegie's town he walks away from a volley of gunfire without being hit, an image that recalls the promise of the Ninety-First Psalm, "A thousand shall fall at thy side, and ten thousand at thy right hand; but it shall not come nigh thee" (91:7), and its assurance against "the arrow that flieth by day" (91:5), an arrow the film itself supplies, since Eli hunts with a bow. Yet the twist of the final act retroactively complicates every such sign. If Eli was blind throughout, his survival of so many encounters may be read as a sign of providence, or as evidence of a trained, hyper-acute, embodied competence, or as both. Tzvetan Todorov defined the fantastic, in *The Fantastic* (1970), as the hesitation experienced by a reader who cannot decide whether an apparently supernatural event has a natural or supernatural explanation; the genre lives as long as the hesitation lasts. The film sustains Todorovian hesitation about its central miracle to the end. David Hume's "Of Miracles" (1748) argued that no testimony suffices to establish a miracle unless its falsehood would be more miraculous than the fact it attests; the film's twist offers a peculiar inversion of Hume, in which the natural explanation (a blind man has crossed a continent of killers by

skill alone) is itself so extraordinary that it competes with the supernatural one. Providence and competence become indistinguishable, which is perhaps the most precise theological claim the film makes: that grace, if it acts at all in such a world, acts through a disciplined body.

4.6

Solara: The Sun of Righteousness

The heir of Malachi 4:2 bears the name of the sun. In a world where the sun destroyed and must be shielded against, a young woman named Solara becomes the bearer of the film's future, and the film's last image of her, walking alone into a sunlit landscape wearing her dead mentor's dark glasses and carrying his blade, reconciles the human figure with the luminary that had become the enemy. The Second Epistle of Peter supplies the internalized form of this reconciliation: the prophetic word is "a light that shineth in a dark place, until the day dawn, and the day star arise in your hearts" (1:19). The day star rises in the heart, not in the sky: the luminary of the fourth day is interiorized, as the word of the first day was interiorized in Eli's memory. Her name also recalls Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) and Andrei Tarkovsky's adaptation (1972), in which a planetary ocean materializes the memories of those who study it as living bodies; the film inverts Lem, since where Solaris makes memory flesh, Eli makes flesh memory, and Solara is its heir.

A last luminary belongs to the island. The lighthouse on Alcatraz, first lit in 1854, was the first American lighthouse on the Pacific coast, a light for signs set at the western edge of the continent before the island became a fortress, a prison, and, in the film, an archive. And a last myth belongs to the season. In Hesiod's *Works and Days* (90–105), when Pandora opened the jar from which every evil escaped into the world, one thing remained within, beneath its lip: *Elpis*, hope. Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* (1954–1959) made of that remainder an ontology of the Not-Yet. Eli's codex, carried closed and locked across the burned continent, is a Pandoran vessel in reverse: everything has already escaped into the world, and what remains inside, under the clasp, is the hope that the fourth day sets in the sky as a sign.

DAY FIVE



Let the Waters Swarm and the Fowl Fly

Voice, Vocation, and the Media A Priori of Blindness

And God said, Let the waters bring forth abundantly the moving creature that hath life, and fowl that may fly above the earth in the open firmament of heaven.

GENESIS 1:20 (AV)

5.1

Vocation: The Voice in the Rubble

On the fifth day the creation account changes its grammar. Through the first four days God speaks in the jussive, *about* what is to be: let there be light, let there be a firmament, let the dry land appear, let there be lights. On the fifth, having made the creatures of the waters and the birds of the air, "God blessed them, saying, Be fruitful, and multiply" (Genesis 1:22). For the first time the divine word is addressed *to* creatures rather than pronounced over them; the fifth day is the day on which speech becomes address. Eli's biography begins in the same grammatical mood. In the ruins after the flash, as he tells Solara, a voice spoke to him, led him to the place where the book lay buried in rubble, and charged him to carry it west to a place where it would be safe. Everything that follows is the consequence of an address.

The Latin name for such an address is *vocatio*, and the history of the word is itself a history of translation. Max Weber's *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (1904–05) argued that the modern concept of the *Beruf*, the calling in the sense of a worldly occupation invested with religious significance, entered the European languages through Luther's translation of the Bible, specifically his rendering of Jesus Sirach 11:20–21, and that the Protestant sanctification of ordinary labour as vocation was among the religious conditions of capitalist rationality. Eli's vocation is a calling in both of Weber's senses, a summons and a job. His labour is walking, and he performs it with the methodical, unremitting discipline that Weber attributed to the Puritan saint, rising each day to the same task for thirty years without visible reward.

The scene of vocation has a canonical form in the Latin West. In the eighth book of the *Confessions*, Augustine, weeping in a garden at Milan, hears from a neighbouring house the voice of a child chanting *tolle lege, tolle lege*, "take up and read"; he takes up the codex of the apostle, opens it at random, reads Romans 13:13–14, and is converted (VIII.12.29). A voice, a book, an act of taking up: Eli's vocation is Augustine's with the final term transformed. The voice in the ruins did not say *take up and read*; it said, in effect, *take up and carry*. The shift from reading to carrying is the film's first intimation that its subject is not the interpretation of scripture but its custody. Augustine's codex was one among the many of late-antique Milan, and he took it up to understand it. Eli's is the last, and he takes it up to save it.

The deeper typology is that of this thesis's epigraph. In 1 Samuel 3 the boy Samuel, sleeping in the temple "where the ark of God was," hears a voice calling his name; three times he runs to the old priest Eli, who has not called him; and the third time "Eli perceived that the LORD had called the child" (3:8) and taught him the formula of response: "Speak, LORD; for thy servant heareth" (3:9). The biblical Eli does not hear the voice. Dim-eyed, he recognizes it in another and teaches the young the right posture of reply. The film's Eli unites the two figures. Like Samuel, he hears the voice himself; like the priest of Shiloh, he teaches a young person how to answer, for the grace he teaches Solara over their shared meal (Day Six) is

precisely a formula of address to the one who speaks. The chapter's first verse names the condition of the world in which this happens: "the word of the LORD was precious in those days; there was no open vision" (3:1). The Hebrew *ḥāzôn niprāṣ* suggests vision that does not break through or spread abroad: a time of scarce revelation, in which the word is precious because it is rare. The film's world, in which a single copy of the word survives, is the hyperbole of that verse. And the call came, the narrator specifies, before "the lamp of God went out in the temple" (3:3). The film's call comes after every lamp has gone out.

5.2

Conviction and Responsibility: The Saint with a Sword

Weber's lecture "Politics as a Vocation," delivered in Munich in January 1919 amid the collapse of the German empire, supplies the ethical grammar of Eli's vocation and of its crisis. Weber distinguished an ethic of conviction (*Gesinnungsethik*), whose adherent does what is right and leaves the outcome to God, from an ethic of responsibility (*Verantwortungsethik*), whose adherent must answer for the foreseeable consequences of action. The paradigm of the first is the Sermon on the Mount, an absolute ethic that, Weber insisted, cannot be taken up and set down at convenience: one must be a saint in everything or not invoke it at all. And he warned that whoever seeks the salvation of souls, his own or others', should not seek it by the avenue of politics, whose specific means is legitimate violence, and which therefore contracts with diabolical powers. Eli's discipline is the ethic of conviction in its purest form. When, early in the film, a gang of hijackers falls upon two travellers within his hearing, robbing and killing them both and, by the scene's plain implication, raping the woman, he tells himself that it is not his concern and that he must stay on the path, and he walks on. His mission is the only consequence for which he holds himself answerable.

Yet Eli is also what Weber thought impossible: a saint who wields the sword. He refuses politics, in the form of Carnegie's offer of a share in rule, while practising its means, lethal violence, in defence of a non-political end. The film stages a figure that Weber's typology excludes, and its narrative is the slow discovery that the figure is unstable. The ethic that let travellers die on the road is not, the film concludes, the ethic of the book Eli carries. The passage out of it does not lead to Weber's ethic of responsibility, the politician's sober calculation of consequences, which is Carnegie's ethic rather than Eli's. It leads to the ethic of the neighbour, whose analysis belongs to Day Six.

5.3

Hearing as Obedience: The Acoustic Covenant

The covenant of Israel begins with an imperative to hear: "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God is one LORD" (Deuteronomy 6:4). The Hebrew *shama'* means both to hear and to obey, and the Latin *oboedire*, from *ob-audire*, "to hear toward," preserves the identity of the two acts. Paul formulated the principle that would govern the Protestant theology of the word: "So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God" (Romans 10:17), *fides ex auditu*. Luther, lecturing on Hebrews in 1517–18, drew the radical conclusion: *solae aures sunt organa Christiani hominis*, the ears alone are the organs of a Christian. If Luther is right, the blind lose nothing that faith requires. Eli's religious life, from the voice that called him to the dictation that ends his life, is conducted in the acoustic register the Reformation declared sufficient.

The opposition between a visual Hellenism and an acoustic Hebraism has a long and compromised history. Thorleif Boman's *Hebrew Thought Compared with Greek* (1952) proposed that Hebrew thought was dynamic, temporal, and auditory, Greek thought static, spatial, and visual; James Barr's *The Semantics of Biblical Language* (1961) demolished the method by which such contrasts had been derived from vocabulary, showing that they projected philosophical stereotypes onto words. The film is best read not as an endorsement of the Boman binary but as its complication by a third term, since touch belongs to neither stereotype. Here the film has an ally in the very philosopher who opened the *Metaphysics* with the praise of sight. In *De Anima* Aristotle ranks touch as the most fundamental sense, without which no animal can exist at all (III.12–13, 434b–435b), and he argues that human beings are the most intelligent of animals because their touch is the most discriminating (II.9, 421a). Aristotle's metaphysics privileges sight; Aristotle's psychology grounds intelligence in touch. The film recovers the second Aristotle against the first.

5.4

Secondary Orality and the Phonographic Relic

The world of the film is post-literate. The generation born after the flash cannot read: Solara cannot, and neither can the men Carnegie sends to scour the ruins, who can retrieve only objects that look like books and must bring them to their master to learn whether they have found the one he wants. Literacy survives only in the old (Carnegie, Eli, Claudia, Lombardi), and is therefore a generational monopoly that will die with them. Walter Ong's *Orality and Literacy* (1982) argued that writing restructures consciousness, and that cultures of primary orality organize knowledge through formula, repetition, and the agonistic performance of memory; Eric Havelock's *Preface to Plato* (1963) read the Homeric poems as the tribal encyclopedia of such a culture, and Plato's expulsion of the poets as the revolt of literate abstraction against it; Jack Goody and Ian Watt's "The Consequences of Literacy"

(1963) attributed to alphabetic writing the emergence of historical consciousness and logical scepticism. The post-apocalyptic imagination has repeatedly asked what becomes of these consequences when literacy is lost: the last sequence of *Threads* shows a child born after the war who speaks only a broken, affectless English, and *Riddley Walker* is written in a degraded future English in which sacred history survives as garbled legend. *The Book of Eli* imagines the loss of literacy as a political rather than merely cognitive event. A population that cannot read cannot check what it is told a book says. Carnegie's project depends on that incapacity.

Against this collapse Eli carries a device of what Ong called secondary orality, the orality of telephone, radio, and recording, which presupposes writing and print. His iPod, recharged by the trader the film calls the Engineer, plays Al Green's version, released in 1972, of "How Can You Mend a Broken Heart," a song written by Barry and Robin Gibb the year before. Within four years Green would become pastor of the Full Gospel Tabernacle in Memphis; the voice Eli listens to at the end of the world is that of a soul singer who crossed, in the same decade, from the secular to the sacred. The device has a darker significance. A blind man who places buds in his ears in a hostile wasteland deprives himself of the sense on which his survival depends; he blinds himself a second time. The act can be read as recklessness, as trust in the protection he claims, or as a ritual of remembrance. In each case it is a sabbath of the ears, a withdrawal from vigilance into the stored voice of the dead world.

The history of sound recording is entangled with blindness from its first day. When Thomas Edison published "The Phonograph and Its Future" in the *North American Review* in 1878, the first use he listed for his invention was "letter writing and all kinds of dictation without the aid of a stenographer"; the second was "phonographic books, which will speak to blind people without effort on their part." Dictation and the blind reader: the inventor of the phonograph named, as its first two purposes, the two poles of the film's climax. The American Foundation for the Blind and the Library of Congress realized the second in 1934 with the first Talking Books. Friedrich Kittler's *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986), which opens with the declaration that media determine our situation, argued that the technical media of the nineteenth century were born from the prosthetic needs of the disabled sensorium. Among the ancestors of the typewriter is the machine Pellegrino Turri built around 1808 so that the blind Countess Carolina Fantoni da Fivizzano could write letters; Nietzsche, nearly blind, acquired in 1882 a writing ball devised by Rasmus Malling-Hansen, director of Copenhagen's institute for the deaf, and wrote that year the sentence Kittler made the motto of media theory, *Unser Schreibzeug arbeitet mit an unseren Gedanken*, our writing equipment takes part in the forming of our thoughts; Alexander Graham Bell came to the telephone through the education of the deaf. Mara Mills's work on disability and communication engineering (2011) has extended the argument. Modern media have, in this sense, a disabled *a priori*: they begin as compensations for a missing sense and become the conditions of everyone's experience.

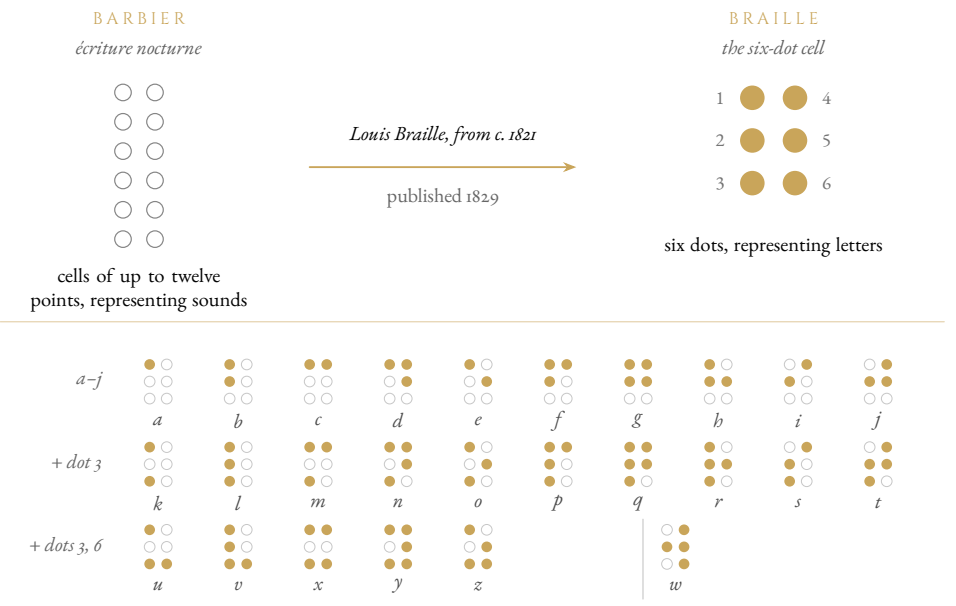


FIGURE 11

From twelve points to six

Barbier's night writing, devised so that soldiers could write and read in darkness, used cells of up to twelve raised points representing sounds; Braille reduced it to a six-dot cell representing letters. Below, the alphabet in uncontracted braille: k–t repeat a–j with dot 3 added, u–z with dots 3 and 6; w, absent from French, stands apart.

5.5

Night Writing: The Military Origin of Aphotic Script

The script of Eli's book has the most striking genealogy of all. In the first decades of the nineteenth century the French artillery officer Charles Barbier de la Serre developed what he called *écriture nocturne*, night writing: a code of raised dots, arranged in cells of up to twelve points and representing sounds rather than letters, which would allow soldiers to compose and read messages in darkness without striking a light that would betray their position to the enemy. Barbier presented it to the Royal Institute for Blind Youth in Paris around 1821. There a twelve-year-old pupil, Louis Braille, blinded at three by an awl in his father's harness workshop at Coupvray, recognized its promise and its faults and reduced it to a six-dot cell representing the letters of the alphabet; he published the system in 1829, and the Institute adopted it officially in 1854, two years after his death.

The genealogy confers on the film's central object an irony so exact that it approaches the figural. The tactile scripture that survives a war waged with light descends from a military technology designed for a war in which light was lethal. Kittler's observation that media

history is in large part a history of the misuse of army equipment finds here its most humane instance: a code for soldiers in the dark became the literacy of the blind, and in the film the last vessel of scripture. The tool's history doubles the inventor's. Braille was blinded by an awl, and the stylus with which braille is written by hand is an awl's descendant; the instrument of his wounding became the instrument of his writing. When, on the centenary of his death in 1952, the Republic transferred his remains to the Panthéon, his native village kept his hands, which remain in an urn at Coupvray. The nation enshrined the body; the village kept the hands that read.

Two further features of the script bear directly on the film. First, Braille's transformation of Barbier's phonetic code into an alphabetic one makes braille a writing of writing: it transcribes not speech but the letters of a visual alphabet, so that a braille Bible reproduces the spelling of the Authorized Version, not the sound of a voice reading it. Derrida's critique of phonocentrism in *Of Grammatology* (1967), the claim that writing is not a mere supplement to speech, finds in braille an unusually pure vindication: a writing that represents neither speech nor sight and can be read without voice or light. Second, braille written by hand with slate and stylus is punched from the reverse of the sheet, and must therefore be written from right to left and in mirror image, so that it reads from left to right when the sheet is turned. The braille scribe writes as a Hebrew scribe writes and is read as an English reader reads; every handwritten braille page passes through a mirror. The Authorized Version's word for a mirror is "glass," and the significance of a script always written as if through a glass will appear only in the conclusion.

A last material fact cannot be passed over. The complete English Bible in contracted braille occupies not one volume but more than a dozen large ones. The single codex Eli carries is a physical impossibility, a library compressed into a book. The impossibility is a theological truth in disguise. *Bible* derives from the Greek *ta biblia*, "the books," a neuter plural that medieval Latin received as a feminine singular, and late-antique and early medieval usage could call the complete scriptures a *bibliotheca*, a library. The film's impossible object restores the plural hidden in the singular: Eli carries a library in the form of one book, as he will deliver it in the form of one voice.

5.6

The Fifth Day's Creatures: Cat, Raven, Pelican, Albatross

The creatures of the fifth day have nearly vanished from the film's world, which realizes Jeremiah's vision of un-creation: "I beheld, and, lo, there was no man, and all the birds of the heavens were fled" (Jeremiah 4:25). The first living creature the film shows is a hairless cat, which Eli kills with an arrow in the dead forest and eats. The scene acquires in retrospect a second meaning: the archer is blind. The modern mythology of the master who shoots in darkness has its locus in Eugen Herrigel's *Zen in the Art of Archery* (1948), whose teacher strikes the target at night and splits his first arrow with his second; Yamada Shōji's critique

(2001) has shown how much of Herrigel's account was a Western projection. The film inherits the myth and, as Day Four argued, grounds it in a disciplined body. The meal is also theologically marked. In the priestly creation account human beings are given only plants for food (Genesis 1:29); the eating of flesh is conceded after the flood (9:3), with two limits: that the blood not be eaten, and that human blood not be shed, "for in the image of God made he man" (9:6). Eli's cat is a post-diluvian meal; the cannibals of Day Six transgress the post-diluvian limit.

The prophet whose name Eli bears was himself sustained by birds. Having announced to King Ahab a drought, "there shall not be dew nor rain these years, but according to my word" (1 Kings 17:1), Elijah hid by the brook Cherith, where "the ravens brought him bread and flesh in the morning, and bread and flesh in the evening" (17:6). Drought and fire are Elijah's signature miracles: he closes the heavens' water, and he calls down the heavens' fire, on the altar at Carmel (18:38) and on the soldiers sent to seize him (2 Kings 1:10–12). These are the two conditions of the film's world, scarcity of water and fire from heaven, and its survivor bears the name of the prophet who commanded both. The typology extends to the antagonist. Ahab greeted Elijah with the question "Art thou he that troubleth Israel?" (1 Kings 18:17), and coveted the vineyard of Naboth, the inheritance of his fathers; when Naboth would not sell it, Jezebel had him killed and Ahab took possession (1 Kings 21). Carnegie, who covets another man's inheritance and will kill to take it, is Ahab after the flash.

The fifth day also made "great whales" (Genesis 1:21), the *tanninim*, the sea-dragons of Canaanite and Babylonian combat myth, whose demotion to mere creatures Hermann Gunkel's *Schöpfung und Chaos* (1895) read as the priestly writer's polemic against the *Chaoskampf*. Hobbes took the motto of his frontispiece from Job's Leviathan, *Non est potestas super terram quae comparetur ei*, there is no power on earth to be compared to him (Job 41:24 in the Vulgate). Genesis had already answered Hobbes: the sea-monster is a creature, blessed and mortal like the rest. Carnegie's would-be Leviathan ends as a creature dying of a wound.

The decisive bird gave the film's destination its name. In 1775 the expedition of Juan Manuel de Ayala charted San Francisco Bay and named an island *La Isla de los Alcatraces*, the island of the pelicans or seabirds; the name later settled on the rock that bears it. The Spanish *alcatraz* is commonly derived from the Arabic, perhaps from *al-ghaṭṭās*, "the diver," or, by another proposed derivation, from *al-qādūs*, the bucket of a water-wheel, in allusion to the pelican's pouch; and the English *albatross* is an alteration of the same word under the influence of the Latin *albus*, white. Eli's road ends on the island of the pelican, and the pelican is the oldest Christian emblem of a body that nourishes others with its own substance. The *Physiologus*, compiled in Alexandria in the early Christian centuries, tells how the pelican revives its dead young on the third day by piercing its own side and pouring its blood upon them, a figure of the side pierced on the cross, from which "forthwith came there

out blood and water" (John 19:34). Aquinas's eucharistic hymn *Adoro te devote* addresses Christ as *pie pelicane*, loving pelican, and asks to be cleansed by his blood; Shakespeare's Laertes vows to receive his father's friends "like the kind life-rend'ring pelican" and "repast them with my blood" (*Hamlet* IV.v). Tudor political theology appropriated the bird for the sovereign: the "Pelican Portrait" of Elizabeth I, attributed to Nicholas Hilliard, shows the queen wearing the pelican-in-her-piety at her breast, the monarch as the mother who feeds her people with her own blood. Carnegie is the anti-pelican, the sovereign who feeds upon his people. Eli, dying on the island of the pelicans after pouring the whole of his memory into the archive, is the pelican itself.

Through the etymology the pelican becomes the albatross. Coleridge's *The Rime of the Ancient Mariner* (1798) is the English language's great poem of a curse at sea: the Mariner shoots the albatross, and the becalmed ship is cursed with thirst, "Water, water, every where, / Nor any drop to drink," a hydraulic agony in the midst of water; the dead bird is hung about his neck. The curse lifts when the Mariner, seeing the water-snakes in the moonlight, blesses them "unaware," and the albatross falls from his neck into the sea. His penance is to wander and tell his tale to the one who must hear it, and its moral is the moral of the fifth day: "He prayeth best, who loveth best / All things both great and small." Eli at Alcatraz is the Mariner at his landfall, compelled to tell the whole of what he carries to the one appointed to receive it, released from his burden only by the telling; and his release, like the Mariner's, depends upon a love he discovered late.

DAY SIX



Let Us Make Man

Cannibal and Eucharistic Tables, the Face, and the Fleshy Tables of the Heart

So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them.

GENESIS 1:27 (AV)

6.1

The Image After the Image

The sixth day culminates in the making of a creature "in the image of God" (Genesis 1:27), and the first law given after the flood grounds the prohibition of homicide in that image: "Whoso sheddeth man's blood, by man shall his blood be shed: for in the image of God made he man" (9:6). In a world in which human beings hunt, rob, enslave, and eat one another, the *imago Dei* is the most endangered of the film's images, and the question of Day Six is whether it can be perceived by any faculty other than sight. The Decalogue forbids the making of images (Exodus 20:4), and the Bible's most intimate scene of divine encounter is acoustic: "the LORD spake unto Moses face to face, as a man speaketh unto his friend" (Exodus 33:11). Yet when Moses asks to see God's glory he is told, "Thou canst not see my face: for there shall no man see me, and live" (33:20), and is shown only the back of the passing presence. The biblical face is spoken to; it is not seen.

Emmanuel Levinas made this structure the foundation of an ethics. In *Totality and Infinity* (1961) the face of the other is not a phenomenon presented to vision but an expression that addresses me and whose first signification is the commandment not to kill; ethics, Levinas wrote, is an optics, but one that is "a 'vision' without image," stripped of vision's synoptic and objectifying powers. In the conversations published as *Ethics and Infinity* (1982) he went further, suggesting that to notice the colour of another's eyes is already to have stepped out of the ethical relation into mere perception. Levinas's ethics is, in the terms of this thesis, an aphotic optics, and the film distributes it with precision. Carnegie sees faces and reads them as resources: Solara's face is currency, Eli's a measure of usefulness, Claudia's an object of domination. Eli cannot see any face and must learn, over the course of the film, to answer the face he cannot see. His failure and his conversion are failures and conversions of response, not of perception.

6.2

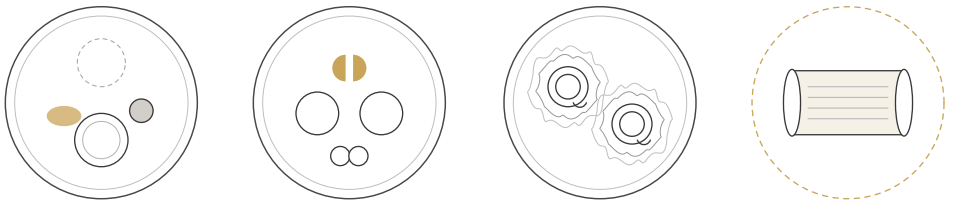
Three Tables and a Scroll

The film is organized around meals, and their arrangement constitutes its sacramental theology. The first table is Carnegie's. Having watched Eli's capacity for violence in the bar, the warlord invites him to eat, offers him water, food, lodging, and a woman, and proposes that he stay. The meal is the first temptation of the wilderness restaged in a dining room: bread offered in exchange for allegiance, to which the answer is the one Jesus gave out of Deuteronomy: "Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God" (Matthew 4:4; Deuteronomy 8:3). Eli possesses every word that proceeds out of the mouth of God. He declines the bread.

The second table is set in the room to which Carnegie sends Solara. Eli refuses the sexual offer, shares his food with her, and before they eat teaches her to give thanks, joining

hands with her in a grace. The act is liturgically exact. The Greek verb for giving thanks is *eucharistein*, and the institution of the Lord's Supper is narrated as thanksgiving over bread: "he took bread, and gave thanks, and brake it" (Luke 22:19). The grace Eli teaches is, etymologically and structurally, a eucharist. It is also the act by which the book is betrayed. The next morning Solara repeats the grace at her mother's table, and Carnegie, hearing it, understands what his guest carries. The prayer travels faster than the book: the word passes from Eli's mouth through Solara's to the tyrant's ear before the codex leaves the room. The scene recalls the most aphotic recognition in the Gospels. On the road to Emmaus two disciples walk with the risen Jesus without knowing him, for "their eyes were holden that they should not know him" (Luke 24:16), until at table he takes bread, blesses, and breaks it, "and their eyes were opened, and they knew him" (24:31); afterwards they tell how "he was known of them in breaking of bread" (24:35). Recognition comes not through sight, which failed for the length of a road, but through a meal shared at its end.

The third table belongs to George and Martha, the elderly couple whose homestead Eli and Solara reach after leaving the town. They are hospitable, garrulous, and well armed; they serve tea; and they eat their guests. Eli recognizes what they are by the tremor of their hands, the sign of a prion disease of the kind the Fore people of New Guinea called *kuru*, "trembling," transmitted through funerary cannibalism, whose investigation earned Carleton Gajdusek the Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine in 1976. The twist obliges us to reconstruct how a blind man detected it: not by sight, but by the rattle of china on a saucer or the vibration of a cup passed from hand to hand. The couple's names are doubly overdetermined. They are the names of the first presidential couple of the United States, so that the founding household of the republic reappears as a cannibal household on its ruins; and they are the names of the hosts in Edward Albee's *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?* (1962), whose long night with a younger couple includes a game George calls "Get the Guests." The homestead is the anti-Eucharist, the table at which the flesh consumed is literally human. Early Christians were accused by their pagan neighbours of exactly this crime; Athenagoras's *Plea for the Christians* (c. 177) rebuts the charge of "Thyestean feasts," a slander that misread eucharistic language as cannibal confession. Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) reversed the apologist's defence, proposing that the communion repeats in sublimated form the primal totem meal at which the brothers devoured the murdered father. The film separates what Freud's genealogy conflates: its eucharistic table and its cannibal table stand side by side as alternatives. Montaigne's provocation in "Of Cannibals" (1580), that Europeans who torture the living are more barbarous than the Tupinambá who eat the dead, finds its echo in the relation between George and Martha and Carnegie. The cannibals eat bodies; the warlord would consume a people. Achilles's insult to Agamemnon names his kind exactly: *dēmoboros basileus*, "people-devouring king" (*Iliad* 1.231). Hobbes, in the dedicatory epistle of *De Cive* (1642), set the two possibilities of human relation side by side: *homo homini deus*, man is a god to man, and *homo homini lupus*, man is a wolf to man. The film builds a table for each.



I
CARNEGIE'S
bread offered for allegiance
the tyrant who would eat the people by means of the book

II
THE ROOM
a grace, hands joined
the custodian who shares bread in thanksgiving
homo homini deus

III
GEORGE AND MARTHA
tea, and the tremor of hands
the cannibals who eat the image of God
homo homini lupus

IV
THE SCROLL
Ezekiel 3:1–3
the custodian who has eaten the scroll

FIGURE 12

Three tables and a scroll

The meals of Day Six as four relations between the body and the word. Hobbes set two possibilities of human relation side by side, *homo homini deus* and *homo homini lupus*; the film, the essay observes, builds a table for each.

The fourth meal is a book. Ezekiel is commanded, "Son of man, eat that thou findest; eat this roll," and it was "in my mouth as honey for sweetness" (Ezekiel 3:1–3). John of Patmos eats a little book, sweet in his mouth and bitter in his belly (Revelation 10:9–10). Jeremiah confesses, in a sentence whose first verb recalls the finding of Josiah's book, "Thy words were found, and I did eat them" (Jeremiah 15:16). Monastic reading took the metaphor as a method. The Carthusian Guigo II's *Scala claustralium* (c. 1150) describes reading as placing food whole in the mouth, meditation as chewing it, prayer as extracting its savour, and contemplation as the sweetness itself; Mary Carruthers's *The Book of Memory* (1990) showed how this *ruminatio* made memory a digestive organ in which texts were incorporated into the reader's body. Eli has eaten the book. The film's four meals thus articulate four relations between the body and the word: the tyrant who would eat the people by means of the book; the cannibals who eat the image of God; the custodian who shares bread in thanksgiving; and the custodian who has eaten the scroll so completely that its loss cannot starve him.

6.3

The Priest Who Passed By

The film's ethical crisis is inscribed in its protagonist's name. Eli was a priest. In the parable of the Good Samaritan, Jesus's answer to a lawyer who asked, "And who is my neighbour?" (Luke 10:29), a man falls among thieves on the road to Jericho and is left half dead; "by chance there came down a certain priest that way: and when he saw him, he passed by on the other side" (10:31), and a Levite after him; it is a Samaritan, a member of a despised people, who "had compassion on him" (10:33). The scene in which Eli walks on while hijackers fall upon travellers is the parable's priest after the flash, with one exact modification. The priest

of Luke "saw him"; Eli only hears. The scandal of the parable is that perception was not enough; the scandal of the film is that the man who cannot see is the one who passes by. Jesus's reply inverts the lawyer's question: the neighbour is not the one I am obliged to help but the one who "shewed mercy," and the parable ends in an imperative of imitation: "Go, and do thou likewise" (10:37). Eli's conversion from the parable's priest to its Samaritan begins on the road out of Carnegie's town, when he turns back to save Solara from men who have ambushed her, and is completed only in his confession at the end.

The philosophical form of Eli's early discipline is Kierkegaard's teleological suspension of the ethical. In *Fear and Trembling* (1843) Johannes de Silentio asks whether there can be a duty to God that suspends the universal ethical obligation, and finds its terrible instance in Abraham, who rose early to sacrifice Isaac at a command no ethics could justify. "Stay on the path" is Eli's Moriah: the religious mission suspends the duty to the stranger. Levinas, who regarded Kierkegaard's suspension of the ethical with alarm, offered in "A propos of *Kierkegaard vivant*" (collected in *Proper Names*, 1976) a counter-reading of the same story. That Abraham obeyed the first voice, the command to sacrifice, is astonishing; what is essential, Levinas argued, is that he kept enough distance from that obedience to hear the second voice, the angel's call: "Lay not thine hand upon the lad" (Genesis 22:12). Eli is a man of voices. The first told him to carry the book west and keep to the path. The film's moral argument is that he heard the second only at the end of the road, when he told Solara that he had spent so long protecting the book that he had forgotten to live by what it taught, and that what it taught was to do more for others than for oneself.

The reduction of the whole of scripture to that single obligation has an exact rabbinic precedent. The Babylonian Talmud (Shabbat 31a) tells of a gentile who asked Hillel to teach him the whole Torah while standing on one foot; Hillel answered that what is hateful to you, you should not do to your fellow; that this is the whole Torah, the rest is commentary; go and learn. Asked for the greatest commandment, Jesus answered with the love of God and the love of neighbour, and added: "On these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets" (Matthew 22:40). Augustine raised the principle into a rule of interpretation. Whoever thinks he has understood the divine scriptures, he wrote in *De doctrina christiana* (I.36.40), but cannot build upon that understanding the double love of God and neighbour, has not yet understood them; and in his homilies on the First Epistle of John he condensed the rule to four words: *dilige, et quod vis fac*, love, and do what you will (7.8). Eli had memorized the scripture without, in Augustine's precise sense, understanding it, until he applied the rule of charity. The custodian of the whole Bible learns at the end what Hillel taught on one foot.

Levinas's essay "Loving the Torah More than God" (1955; collected in *Difficult Freedom*, 1963) supplies the final term. Levinas was commenting on "Yosl Rakover Talks to God," a monologue written by Zvi Kolitz in 1946 and long circulated as an authentic testament found in the ruins of the Warsaw ghetto, in which a dying Jew declares that he loves God but loves God's Torah more. Levinas read the declaration as the refusal of a God approached without

law, a God of consolation rather than commandment: to love the Torah more than God is to approach God only through the teaching that binds one to others. The text found in the ruins was a fiction, and its fictionality changes nothing in its argument, as the fictionality of the film changes nothing in its own. Eli loved the book more than the neighbour. He learned that the book's content was the neighbour.

6.4

The Black Custodian and the Talking Book

The film was made by directors whose own work bears on this reading. Albert and Allen Hughes, the sons of an African American father and an Armenian American mother, began with *Menace II Society* (1993) and *Dead Presidents* (1995), studies of violence in Black American life, before turning in *The Book of Eli* to a Black custodian of scripture in a world of violence.

Whether or not the premise required it, the casting of Denzel Washington as custodian of the last Bible, against a white warlord who wishes to make the book an instrument of rule over an illiterate people, gives the film's argument a racial charge. The charge is historically exact. Henry Louis Gates Jr.'s *The Signifying Monkey* (1988) identified the founding trope of the African American literary tradition in a scene repeated across the earliest narratives of the Black Atlantic, from James Albert Ukawsaw Gronniosaw (1772) through John Marrant (1785), Quobna Ottobah Cugoano (1787), and Olaudah Equiano (1789) to John Jea (1815): the trope of the Talking Book. In Gronniosaw's version the enslaved boy watches his master read aloud and believes the book is speaking to him; alone, he opens it and puts his ear close to it, "in great hope that it would say something to me," and when it stays silent concludes that "every body and every thing despised me because I was black." Equiano tells the same story of putting his ears to a book in hope of an answer. Gates read the trope as the scene in which the Black subject confronts a culture that defined humanity by literacy and denied literacy to those it enslaved, and traced its revision until, in Jea's narrative, God himself teaches the illiterate man to read. The film's climax, the inverse Molyneux scene of Day One, inverts this trope as well. It is now the white master who holds the Black man's book and finds it mute. The book that would not speak to Gronniosaw because he was Black will not speak to Carnegie because he is sighted; and, as in Jea, the Black man's literacy came to him through a voice.

The political economy of Carnegie's town reproduces that of the slaveholding South. After the Stono Rebellion, South Carolina's Negro Act of 1740 forbade teaching the enslaved to write; in 1831, the year of Nat Turner's rising, Virginia outlawed assemblies for teaching free Black people to read or write and penalized the teaching of the enslaved; other states followed. Frederick Douglass recounts in his *Narrative* (1845) how his master forbade his mistress to continue teaching him the alphabet, on the ground that learning would unfit him for slavery, and draws the conclusion: "From that moment, I understood the pathway from

slavery to freedom." Carnegie's monopoly of literacy over a population that cannot read is the anti-literacy regime of slavery transposed to the end of the world, and his hope of preaching from a Bible that no one can check is the hope of the editors of the 1807 Slave Bible (Day Two). Against it stands a counter-tradition of selective refusal. Howard Thurman recalled in *Jesus and the Disinherited* (1949) that his grandmother, born into slavery, would not let him read to her from the letters of Paul, except the thirteenth chapter of First Corinthians, because the plantation preachers of her youth had taken their texts again and again from the Pauline injunctions to servants to obey their masters. Claudia's refusal is total; Thurman's grandmother's was discriminating. Both refuse a scripture power has made its instrument. And the chapter the grandmother kept, the hymn to charity, will prove in the conclusion to be the chapter the film keeps.

Thurman's grandmother belongs to a tradition of counter-reading that the argument must now name. The enslaved and their descendants made the Exodus, the narrative the Slave Bible cut, the centre of their scripture; the spirituals sent Moses down into Egypt to tell Pharaoh to let the people go. James H. Cone's *A Black Theology of Liberation* (1970) made the claim systematic: the God of the Bible is revealed in the liberation of the oppressed, so that a theology that does not begin from the oppressed is not Christian theology. Cornel West's *Prophesy Deliverance!* (1982) traced the Afro-American prophetic tradition that joins scriptural to social critique. Eli, custodian of the complete Bible, is custodian of the text the enslavers cut. The tradition contains its own correction, and the film's women require it. Delores S. Williams's *Sisters in the Wilderness* (1993) argued that the Exodus paradigm passes over those whom liberation does not reach, and proposed instead the figure of Hagar, the Egyptian slave woman whom Sarai gave to Abram to bear him a son, who fled into the wilderness from Sarai's harsh treatment and was later expelled into it by Abraham with her child (Genesis 16; 21). Hagar's God is not a liberator but a provider of survival: when the water in her bottle is spent, "God opened her eyes, and she saw a well of water" (21:19); and she is the one figure in scripture who gives God a name, as the God who sees her: "Thou God seest me" (16:13). Claudia and Solara are Hagar and her child in a hydraulic despotism, a mother and daughter whom the patriarch of the household keeps, beats, and trades, left to survive in the desert of his rule. In Islamic tradition Hagar, as Hājar, mother of Ishmael, is remembered in the pilgrims' running between Safa and Marwa in search of water, hills the Qur'an names among the signs of God (2:158): the woman in the desert belongs as well to the book shelved beside Eli's.

The Bible supplies its own precedent for an African reader on a desert road. In Acts 8 Philip is sent "unto the way that goeth down from Jerusalem unto Gaza, which is desert" (8:26), where he meets an Ethiopian official of Queen Candace, a eunuch, reading Isaiah aloud in his chariot. "Understandest thou what thou readest?" Philip asks, and the Ethiopian answers, "How can I, except some man should guide me?" (8:30–31). The first gentile convert in the narrative of Acts is an African reading scripture on a desert road, a man without

descendants. The prophecy addressed to such men in Isaiah 56 bears upon the childless Eli: the eunuch is not to say "Behold, I am a dry tree," for God will give him "in mine house and within my walls a place and a name better than of sons and of daughters" (56:3–5). The Hebrew of "a place and a name," *yad vashem*, gave its name in 1953 to Israel's memorial to the victims of the Shoah, an archive of names for those whose descendants were destroyed. Eli, who fathers no child, receives at the end a place on a shelf and a name on a book: the film's title itself.

The actor's body carries one further text. Washington's most celebrated earlier role was Malcolm X in Spike Lee's film of 1992, which draws on the episode, recounted in *The Autobiography of Malcolm X* (1965), in which the young prisoner in Norfolk Prison Colony copies the dictionary by hand, page by page, and so makes himself a reader, before embracing Islam. The prisoner who copied a dictionary returns, eighteen years later, as the prisoner of a mission who dictates the Bible in a former penitentiary; and the book Malcolm came to revere stands on the Alcatraz shelf beside the one Eli dictates.

6.5

Mothers, Daughters, and the Decisive Margin

The women of the film are, by the conventions of its genre, peripheral: Claudia is the consort the warlord beats to control her daughter, Solara the daughter he sends to a stranger's bed as an inducement, Martha a cannibal, and the woman whom the hijackers rape and kill while Eli walks on is never named. Carnegie offers Solara to Eli as an inducement and promises her to his lieutenant Redridge as a reward; on the road she is ambushed by men who would rape her. The film's women live under what Samuel foretold of kingship when the people demanded a king "like all the nations": the king "will take your daughters to be confectionaries, and to be cooks, and to be bakers" (1 Samuel 8:5, 13). Yet the two acts that decide the fate of the book are performed by women, Claudia's refusal to read and Solara's inheritance of the road. The film's politics of gender is a politics of the decisive margin: its women are excluded from the struggle of armed men over the book, and it is at that margin that the struggle is decided.

Claudia's refusal has a mythic prototype that the film's configuration of mother and daughter makes visible. In the Homeric *Hymn to Demeter*, Hades, lord of the underworld, whose cult title Plouton names him master of the wealth beneath the earth, seizes Demeter's daughter Persephone; the grieving mother withholds the growth of the grain until the earth bears nothing and the gods receive no offerings, and Zeus is compelled to restore the daughter for part of every year. Demeter's is Western literature's archetypal strike, a mother's withdrawal of the harvest from a cosmic order that permitted her daughter's seizure. Carnegie, lord of a buried resource, who has taken Claudia's daughter as currency, meets Demeter's refusal in Claudia's: she withholds the only harvest he still needs, the reading of the book.

Solara's inheritance places her in the line of the biblical prophetesses: Huldah, who authenticated Josiah's book (Day Two); Deborah, who judged Israel beneath a palm tree in the

age when there was no king (Judges 4:4–5); and the daughters to whom Joel promised the spirit, "your sons and your daughters shall prophesy" (Joel 2:28), a promise Peter declared fulfilled at Pentecost (Acts 2:17). Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chainsaws* (1992) identified in the horror film the "Final Girl," the young woman who survives the slaughter and takes up the weapon. Solara, who leaves Alcatraz with Eli's blade, resembles her, with the decisive difference that she inherits not survival but a vocation. She is Elisha as a young woman, and the film's last image hands the mantle of the most masculine prophetic succession in the Hebrew Bible to the daughter of a blind mother.

6.6

Disability Beyond the Blind Seer

The genealogy of the blind seer traced in Day One must now be submitted to the critique of disability studies, which has shown how often that genealogy uses blindness as a metaphor while ignoring blind people. David Mitchell and Sharon Snyder's *Narrative Prosthesis* (2000) argued that narrative leans on disability as a crutch, deploying it as a device of characterization, a problem to be solved, or a surprise, without attending to it as lived experience. The film's twist is a narrative prosthesis in exactly this sense: blindness is withheld from the audience in order to be revealed as a coup de théâtre. The film also courts the figure activists call the "supercrip," the disabled hero endowed with compensatory powers, in the lineage of Zatōichi and the comic-book vigilante Daredevil. Georgina Kleege, a blind writer, argued in *Sight Unseen* (1999) that the sighted imagine blindness either as total darkness and tragedy or as mystical compensation, and in both cases fail to see it as what it is for most blind people: a variable condition and a set of learned skills. The theologian John M. Hull, who lost his sight in middle age and recorded the experience in *Touching the Rock* (1990), devoted *In the Beginning There Was Darkness* (2001) to reading the Bible as a blind man, exposing its persistent use of blindness as a figure for sin, ignorance, and unbelief: the "blind guides" of Matthew 23:16, the blind who lead the blind into the ditch (Matthew 15:14), the blindness from which converts are delivered.

The film both participates in this metaphorics and contests it. It participates by making blindness the occasion of a twist and the sign of election. It contests it in three ways. First, it refuses the cure. No scales fall from Eli's eyes as they fell from Paul's, and he is not healed as the man born blind was healed in John 9; blindness is neither punished nor repaired but presented as the condition of a vocation. Second, it inverts the biblical equation of blindness with ignorance: in this world the sighted cannot read, and the two blind characters are the only competent readers of the book. Pieter Bruegel's *Parable of the Blind* (1568) shows the blind leading the blind into the ditch; in the film it is the sighted who lead the sighted, Carnegie's men following their master to ruin, while the blind alone know the way. Third, the twist, read in retrospect, converts the action-film spectacle of Eli's prowess into a record of learned skill: attention to sound, economy of movement, the use of touch, smell,

and memory that Kleege describes as the ordinary expertise of blind life. The supercrip, re-viewed, becomes a skilled worker. Hull, who came to speak of his own blindness as a dark and paradoxical gift, would have recognized the ambivalence.

6.7

The Fleshy Tables of the Heart

The book is captured at the homestead; the word is not. Eli surrenders the codex to save Solara's life, and Carnegie, who has it, has nothing, because its content has passed into the body of the man he has shot and left for dead. The scriptural warrant for this transfer is the promise of the new covenant, "I will put my law in their inward parts, and write it in their hearts" (Jeremiah 31:33), which Paul echoes in contrasting tables of stone with "fleshy tables of the heart" (2 Corinthians 3:3). Proverbs bids the reader write the commandments "upon the table of thine heart" (3:3; 7:3), and the Shema prescribes the full anatomy of incorporation: the words are to be in the heart, taught and spoken, bound "for a sign upon thine hand," and worn "as frontlets between thine eyes" (Deuteronomy 6:6–8), whence the *tefillin* of arm and head. Eli wears the word on the hand, where the braille passes under his fingers, and in the heart, where it is memorized. The frontlets between the eyes have become superfluous.

The opposition of book and memory is as old as Western reflection on writing. In Plato's *Phaedrus* (274c–275b) Socrates tells how the god Theuth offered writing to the Egyptian king Thamus as a *pharmakon* for memory and wisdom, and how Thamus replied that it would produce forgetfulness in those who learned it, since they would trust external marks instead of remembering from within: it was a remedy not for memory but for reminding. Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) showed how the *pharmakon*, remedy and poison at once, unsettles every opposition Plato builds upon it. The film stages the Platonic argument and suspends it. Eli's memory of scripture was formed by thirty years of reading a written book, so that writing, far from destroying his memory, produced it; and his memory, far from rendering writing superfluous, exists to restore it. The *pharmakon* has become a circulation: book into body, body into book.

Frances Yates's *The Art of Memory* (1966), Carruthers's *The Book of Memory*, and Eric Jager's *The Book of the Heart* (2000) traced the techniques and metaphors by which whole texts were inscribed in the heart. Eli's total memory of the canon is hyperbolic, but it is the hyperbole of real traditions, that of the *ḥāfiẓ* who holds the whole Qur'an in memory and of the Vedic reciters to whom Day Seven returns. Its dark twin is Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919). On an island penal colony an officer demonstrates a machine whose needles inscribe into the condemned man's flesh, over twelve hours, the commandment he has broken; the prisoner, who has not been told his sentence, deciphers it through his wounds, and understanding, the officer promises, dawns around the sixth hour. When the visiting traveller declines to endorse the apparatus, the officer takes the prisoner's place, and the

machine, failing, kills him without the promised illumination. Kafka's apparatus writes the law into the body by torture and is read with the body in agony. Carnegie is Kafka's officer, the believer in an apparatus of inscription destroyed by his devotion without the revelation he awaited. Eli is the condemned man's antithesis: a body in which the law was written by touch over thirty years, and which reads it in peace. And Kafka's island penal colony anticipates the island prison where the film ends.

One more verse of the same Pauline chapter governs the sequel: "the letter killeth, but the spirit giveth life" (2 Corinthians 3:6). The sixth day ends with a creature formed of dust into whose nostrils God "breathed … the breath of life" (Genesis 2:7), and the Pastoral Epistles call scripture *theopneustos*, "given by inspiration of God" (2 Timothy 3:16), literally God-breathed. The film's seventh day consists of a dying man breathing the scripture back into writing.

DAY SEVEN



Sabbath of the Book

Dictation, Press, Shelf, and Mantle

And on the seventh day God ended his work which he had made; and he rested on the seventh day from all his work which he had made.

GENESIS 2:2 (AV)

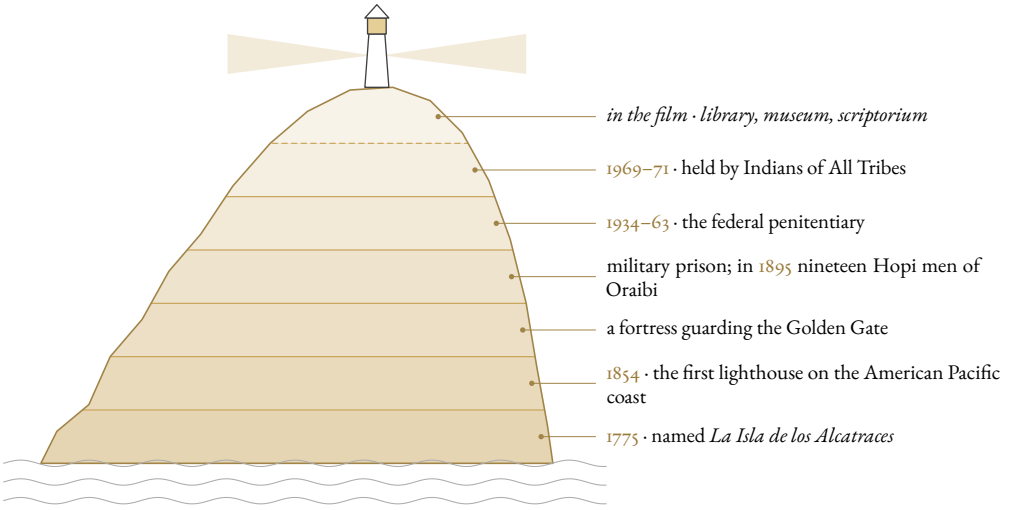


FIGURE 13

The island in section

Alcatraz as Day Seven narrates it, the oldest layer lowest: a rookery named by Spanish navigators, the first lighthouse on the Pacific coast, fortress, military prison, federal penitentiary, the occupation of 1969–71, and, dashed, the archive the film imagines.

7.1

The Island

Eli's road ends on a rock in a bay. Alcatraz has been, in succession, a seabird rookery named by Spanish navigators; the site of the first lighthouse on the American Pacific coast; a fortress guarding the Golden Gate; a military prison from the Civil War onward, in which nineteen Hopi men from Oraibi were confined in 1895 for resisting the removal of their children to government boarding schools and the allotment of their lands; and, from 1934 to 1963, the federal penitentiary that held Al Capone and Robert Stroud, the "Birdman of Alcatraz" of John Frankenheimer's film of 1962, whose ornithological research and books on the diseases of birds had in fact been produced at Leavenworth, since he was forbidden to keep birds on the island that gave him his name. On 20 November 1969 a group calling itself Indians of All Tribes occupied the island and held it until June 1971. Their proclamation, addressed with savage irony "to the Great White Father and all his people," offered to buy the island for glass beads and red cloth, and enumerated the features that made it a fitting reservation by federal standards: no fresh running water, inadequate sanitation, no industry, rocky and unproductive soil, and a population that had always been held as prisoners and kept dependent upon others. The occupiers proposed to turn the island into a centre for Native American studies, a spiritual centre, a centre of ecology, a training school, and a museum.

The film's Alcatraz realizes the occupiers' programme in another key. A prison has become a library, a museum, and a spiritual centre; a fortress built to hold human beings now holds the memory of a civilization. Michel Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975) took Jeremy Bentham's panopticon (1791), a prison designed for the total and continuous visibility of its inmates, as the diagram of modern disciplinary power, and the cellhouse of Alcatraz was among the most completely surveilled spaces ever built in the United States. The film installs in this house of total visibility a dying blind man whose speech becomes scripture: the panopticon becomes a scriptorium, and the architecture of the gaze becomes the site of aphotic transmission. The transformation has a conspicuous limit, to which the conclusion returns. The shelf on which the restored scripture is placed holds the books of the Abrahamic faiths, the peoples of the book. It holds nothing of the oral traditions of the peoples of the land, the Ohlone of the Bay and the nations whose members occupied the island in 1969. The archive at the western edge of the continent is an archive of books on the land of peoples whose memory was never a book. The exclusion has a history, and the island was one of its instruments. The boarding schools for which the Hopi prisoners of 1895 refused to give up their children took Native children from their families to teach them English letters and Christian scripture, and punished them for speaking their own languages; Richard Henry Pratt, founder of the system's model school at Carlisle, summarized its aim in 1892: "Kill the Indian in him, and save the man." The archive of the book stands on an island where Native men were imprisoned for refusing that education to their children.

The archivist who receives Eli is played by Malcolm McDowell, whose most famous image in the history of cinema is his own eye held open by surgical clamps in Stanley Kubrick's *A Clockwork Orange* (1971), as his character is forced to watch films of violence in the name of rehabilitation. Cinema's emblem of coerced vision returns, nearly four decades later, as a listener taking dictation from a blind man. The eye forced open has become the ear that attends: the actor whose career was defined by cinema's most violent image of seeing is now bent over a page, writing what he hears.

7.2

Dictation and the Mytheme of Restitution

At Alcatraz Eli asks for a scribe and dictates. He begins as the canon begins, with Genesis 1:1–2, though not in the words of 1611. Where the Authorized Version has God create "the heaven and the earth," the film's Eli says "heavens," the wording of the New King James Version of 1982, and the volume the island prints is that revision, although at the gate Eli presented his book as the King James Version. Knowingly or not, the film lets the restored text arrive revised. The scene is the latest instance of what I propose to call, adapting Claude Lévi-Strauss's term from "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955), a *mytheme of scriptural restitution*: a narrative unit recurring across the scriptural traditions of the world, in which a sacred text destroyed by fire, war, or catastrophe is restored from the memory of a survivor,

with divine assistance, by dictation to a scribe, often with a change of script or form, so that the restored text is not merely recovered but refounded.

The Hebrew Bible narrates the mytheme within itself. In Jeremiah 36 the scribe Baruch writes "from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the LORD" (36:4); the scroll is read before King Jehoiakim, who, as each three or four leaves are read, cuts them off with a penknife and casts them into the fire on the hearth, "until all the roll was consumed" (36:23). It is the first book-burning in the biblical record, and the response is immediate: "Then took Jeremiah another roll, and gave it to Baruch the scribe ... who wrote therein from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the book which Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire: and there were added besides unto them many like words" (36:32). The restored book exceeds the burned one. Restitution is not a copy but a second, enlarged edition.

The second biblical instance is the most extraordinary, and it was contained in the version Eli names at the gate, as that version was first printed. The 1611 edition included, between the Testaments, the Apocrypha, among them the Second Book of Esdras, whose fourteenth chapter (4 Ezra 14 in modern scholarly usage) tells how, after the destruction of Jerusalem, Ezra lamented that "thy law is burnt" (14:21) and asked for the spirit to write again all that had been in it. "And the next day, behold, a voice called me, saying, Esdras, open thy mouth, and drink that I give thee to drink. Then opened I my mouth, and, behold, he reached me a full cup, which was full as it were with water, but the colour of it was like fire. And I took it, and drank: and when I had drunk of it, my heart uttered understanding, and wisdom grew in my breast, for my spirit strengthened my memory" (14:38–40). Every element of the film is in these verses: a voice that calls; a cup that is water and fire at once, the two elements of the film's world, hydraulic scarcity and the flash, mixed in one drink; and a memory strengthened to restore a burned law. Ezra then dictates for forty days to five scribes, who write books the Latin tradition numbers at ninety-four (the King James translators, following a variant, print "two hundred and four"), and he is commanded to publish the first of them, twenty-four in the Latin reckoning, the number of the Hebrew canon, "openly, that the worthy and unworthy may read it," and to keep the last seventy for "such as be wise among the people" (14:45–46). The Authorized Version that Eli names contained, in its first edition, the story of its own restoration by a man who drank fire and water and dictated it from memory. The New King James Version that the island prints contains no Apocrypha: the restored Bible omits the chapter that narrates restoration.

Rabbinic tradition extends the figure. The Babylonian Talmud records that when the Torah was forgotten in Israel, Ezra came up from Babylon and established it; when it was forgotten again, Hillel came up and established it; and when it was forgotten yet again, Rabbi Ḥiyya and his sons established it (Sukkah 20a). The Hillel of the one-foot Torah (Day Six) is himself a restorer. The Talmud further holds that the Torah was first given in the Hebrew script and given again in Ezra's day in the Assyrian square script (Sanhedrin 21b–22a): restitution coincides with a change of alphabet. At Alcatraz the scripture passes

from tactile braille, through the voice, into Roman type, Ezra's privilege of refounding the text in a new script. Halakha, characteristically, guards against the danger of that privilege: a Torah scroll may not be written from memory but only from a written exemplar, lest a single letter be lost (Megillah 18b). By that standard the Alcatraz Bible, whose exemplar is a body, would be unfit for liturgical use. The rabbis knew what every restitution risks.

The mytheme is not Abrahamic alone. In 213 BCE, on the advice of his chancellor Li Si, the First Emperor of Qin ordered the burning of the classics held outside the imperial archive. The scholar Fu Sheng hid a copy of the *Book of Documents* in a wall of his house; when the Han restored learning he recovered twenty-nine chapters, and in his nineties, too old to travel, he transmitted them to the court scholar Chao Cuo, with, according to a later tradition, his daughter interpreting the old man's speech. An old man, a daughter, and a scribe of the new order: the triad of Eli, Solara, and Lombardi. In the Puranic account of the fish *avatāra* of Vishnu (*Bhāgavata Purāṇa* 8.24), the demon Hayagrīva steals the Vedas as they issue from the mouth of the sleeping Brahmā at the dissolution of a world-age; Vishnu, as the fish Matsya, carries the king Satyavrata through the deluge in a boat bound to his horn, slays the demon, and restores the Vedas. A creature of the fifth day rescues scripture through the flood. The Vedas themselves were transmitted orally for millennia through recitation patterns, the *pada*, *krama*, *jaṭā*, and *ghana*, designed to make the alteration of a single syllable detectable, a tradition UNESCO recognized in 2003. Zoroastrian tradition, in the *Ardā Wirāz Nāmag* and the *Dēnkard*, holds that Alexander "the accursed" burned the Avesta, which had been written in gold on prepared ox-hides and kept in the archive at Istakhr, and that later kings and priests, from the Arsacid Valakhsh to the Sasanian Ardashir and his priest Tansar, and Adurbād ī Mahraspandān under Shapur II, recollected it from scattered fragments and from memory. The Avestan alphabet was devised in the Sasanian period precisely to notate the oral recitation with phonetic exactness: a script invented for an oral scripture, as braille was invented for the blind.

Islamic tradition records that after the battle of Yamama, in which many of those who had memorized the Qur'an were killed, Abu Bakr commissioned Zayd ibn Thabit to collect the revelation, and that Zayd gathered it, by his own account in Bukhari's collection, from palm-leaf stalks, thin white stones, and the breasts of men who knew it by heart; the caliph Uthman later established a standard recension and ordered other codices burned. In the most rigorous of the restitution narratives, codification casts the shadow of a new burning. The revelation itself had begun with a command to a man the tradition calls unlettered: *Iqra'*, "Recite" (Qur'an 96:1); the name *Qur'ān* means recitation.

The Christian scriptures carry the mytheme's scribal structure in their own fabric. Paul dictated his letters; once his scribe greets the readers in his own name: "I Tertius, who wrote this epistle, salute you in the Lord" (Romans 16:22). Paul closes Galatians by remarking "how large a letter I have written unto you with mine own hand" (6:11), a phrase some readers have connected, speculatively, with the Galatians' willingness to "have plucked out your own

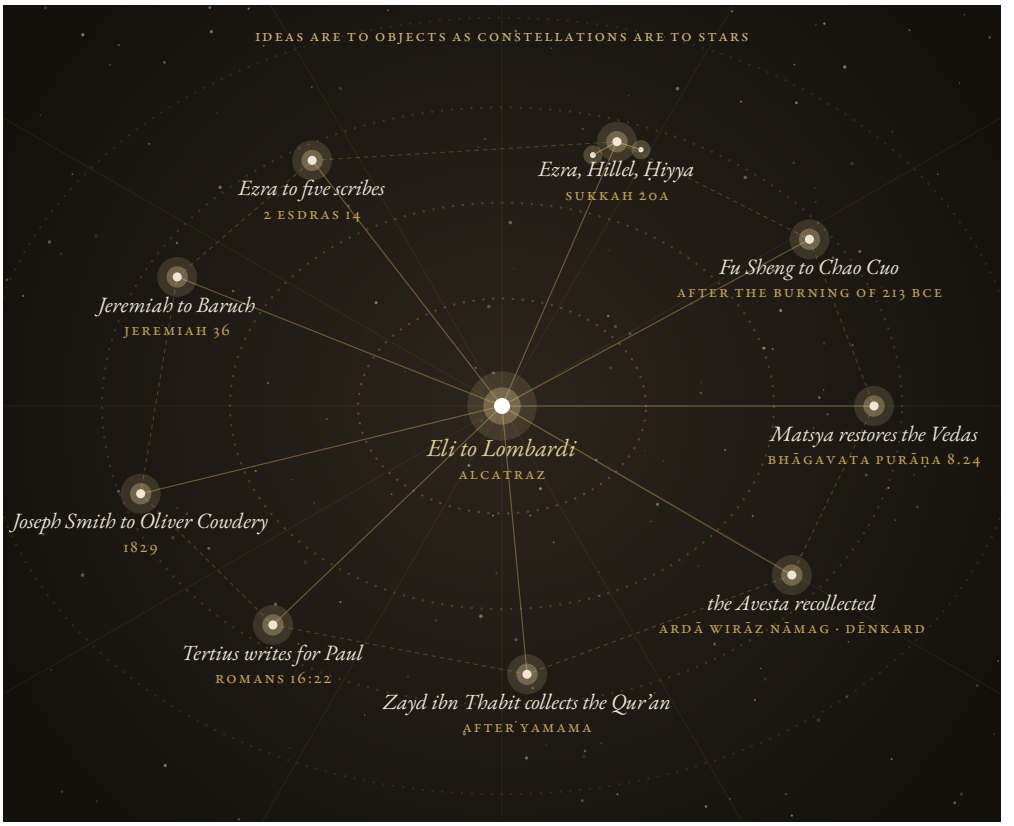


FIGURE 14

A constellation of restitutions

The mytheme of scriptural restitution drawn as a constellation in Benjamin's sense: the scenes Day Seven gathers around the dictation at Alcatraz, in each of which a destroyed or dispersed scripture is restored, from memory, by dictation, or by collection.

eyes, and have given them to me" (4:15). The apostle blinded at Damascus may have been, to the end, a man of weak sight who wrote through others. Calvin called the apostles *certi et authentici Spiritus sancti amanuenses*, sure and authentic amanuenses of the Holy Spirit (*Institutes* IV.8.9), and the doctrine of verbal inspiration has often imagined scripture as divine dictation. The film secularizes and resacralizes that doctrine at once: the amanuensis is Lombardi, and the dictating voice is a blind man's memory of a book that was itself held to have been dictated.

The American instance of the mytheme is the nearest of all to the film. In 1829, at Harmony, Pennsylvania, and Fayette, New York, Joseph Smith dictated the Book of Mormon to scribes, Oliver Cowdery chief among them; by the accounts of witnesses, which the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints acknowledged in an essay of 2013, he did so with

his face in a hat, looking at a seer stone shielded from the light. An American scripture was produced by dictation in the dark. Its narrative supplies Eli with an ancestor. The record presents itself as an abridgement engraved on metal plates and completed by Moroni, the last survivor of a people destroyed, in the book's account, by their enemies, who wanders alone for the safety of his life rather than deny Christ (Moroni 1:1–3) and hides the record in the earth for a future reader (Mormon 8:4). A lone survivor carries the last record of a destroyed civilization across a catastrophe to a scribe who will see it printed; the Book of Mormon was printed at Palmyra, New York, in 1830.

Borges's "Pierre Menard, Author of the *Quixote*" (1939) imagined a modern writer who composes, without copying, chapters word for word identical with Cervantes's, and argued that the identical text is richer and stranger for having been written three centuries later. The Alcatraz Bible is Menard's *Quixote*: word for word the Authorized Version, and yet a different text, authored by memory, dated after the end of the world, and freighted with every death that made it necessary. The danger of such a text is infidelity. In 1631 the King's Printers Robert Barker and Martin Lucas issued an Authorized Version that omitted one word from the seventh commandment, so that it read "Thou shalt commit adultery"; the "Wicked Bible" cost them a fine of three hundred pounds and their licence. One lost word inverts the law. The scene of dictation is therefore a scene of terror as well as grace, since everything depends on a dying man's memory and a living man's hand. Walter Benjamin observed in "The Storyteller" (1936) that "Death is the sanction of everything that the storyteller can tell." Eli's dictation borrows its authority from death, and he dies when it is complete.

7.3

The Press: Typos *and* Figura

The dictated text is set in movable type and printed. The archive's first book is the Bible, as Gutenberg's was: the forty-two-line Bible of Mainz, completed around 1454–55, inaugurated European printing with movable type. Elizabeth Eisenstein's *The Printing Press as an Agent of Change* (1979) attributed to print the fixity, standardization, and dissemination that made the Reformation's appeal to scripture alone technically possible; Marshall McLuhan's *The Gutenberg Galaxy* (1962) described print as the technology that completed the conversion of an oral-aural culture into a visual one. Lombardi's press reverses the passage the film has followed. The word that survived the catastrophe of light in tactile, oral, and mnemonic form returns at Alcatraz to the visual regime: inked, printed, legible by sight. Aphotic revelation, it becomes clear, is not an absolute rejection of light but a passage through darkness from one regime of light to another.

The passage has a precise name, hidden in the vocabulary of printing. The Greek *typos* means a blow, the impression left by a blow, a stamp or seal, and, by extension, a model or figure. It is the source both of the printer's "type," the struck letter, and of the exegete's "type," the figure that prefigures its fulfilment, as when Paul calls Adam "the figure of him

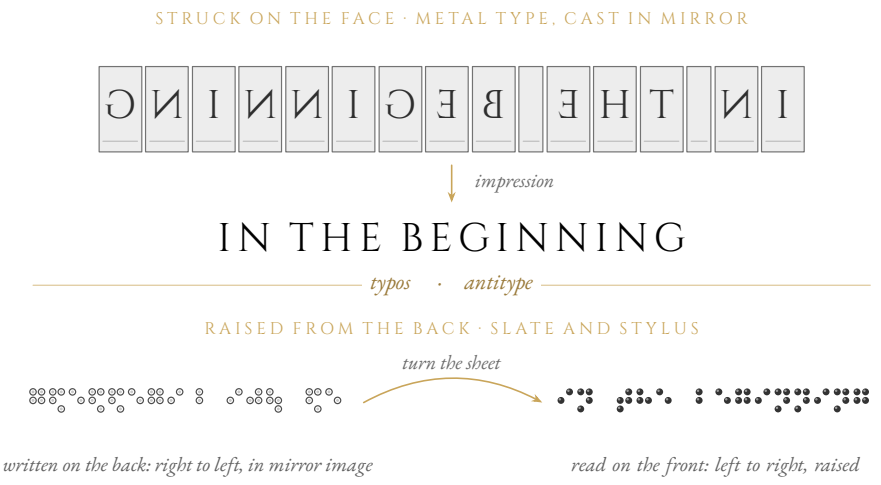


FIGURE 15

Two impressions

Metal type is cast in mirror image and struck on the face of the page; braille written by hand with slate and stylus is punched from the back of the sheet, right to left and in mirror image, and read raised on the front. The printed text, the essay concludes, is "the antitype of the tactile one, the same impression received from the other side."

that was to come" (Romans 5:14), where the Greek is *typos*. Auerbach's "Figura" showed that the Latin *figura* entered Christian exegesis, above all in Tertullian, as the rendering of *typos*. The press and figural reading are named by the same word. Eli's braille codex is a book of *typoi* in the most literal sense, impressions raised by the blows of a stylus from the back of the page; the printed Bible is a book of *typoi* struck by inked metal on its face. The printed text is the antitype of the tactile one, the same impression received from the other side, and the method of this thesis finds in the plot of the film its technical emblem.

Benjamin's "The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technical Reproducibility" (1935–36) argued that mechanical reproduction destroys the aura of the unique original, its singular presence in time and place. Eli's codex, the last Bible, is the most auratic object imaginable, the only copy of a text that once existed in hundreds of millions; and the film's resolution is the dissolution of its aura. The unique codex is lost to Carnegie, who can do nothing with it, while its reproducible content is multiplied on the island. The archive values the reproducible text over the relic; the last copy ceases to be the last. The rhythm of the creation account confirms the pattern. Each day of Genesis closes with the formula "And the evening and the morning were the first day" (1:5), and the Jewish day begins accordingly at nightfall: in every day of creation, darkness precedes light. Aphotic revelation is the evening with which a new day begins. The film's darkness is not the opposite of its final printed page but the first half of the day that produces it.



FIGURE 16

The shelf

Lombardi places the printed Bible between a Tanakh and a Qur'an: Lessing's ring parable as a museological arrangement, three books side by side and none adjudicated. Beside them, dashed, the place the conclusion asks such an archive to keep for what is not a book.

7.4

The Shelf: Rings and Books

Lombardi places the printed Bible on a shelf between a Tanakh and a Qur'an. The place kept for it answers the cup poured for Elijah at the seder (Day Four): the cup stays full because the guest does not come, and the shelf is filled because he did. The gesture is the film's most explicit statement about religious plurality, and its genealogy runs through the most famous parable of toleration in European literature. In the third act of Gotthold Ephraim Lessing's *Nathan the Wise* (1779), the Jewish merchant Nathan, asked by the sultan Saladin which of the three religions is true, tells of a father who possessed a ring with the power to make its wearer beloved of God and men, and who, loving his three sons equally, had two perfect replicas made and gave each son a ring. After his death the sons quarrelled over which ring was genuine, and a wise judge told them that the original could no longer be determined, and that each should strive to prove his ring genuine by gentleness, charity, and devotion. Lessing took the parable from Boccaccio's *Decameron* (I.3), where the Jew Melchizedek escapes Saladin's trap with the same story. The Alcatraz shelf is the ring parable as a museological arrangement: three books side by side, none adjudicated, each to be proved by the lives of its readers.

The arrangement is more intricate than the parable. The Christian Bible contains the Tanakh as its Old Testament, and the Qur'an recalls the figures of both, so that each book on

the shelf contains or rewrites its neighbour; the shelf is less a row of rivals than a sequence of rereadings. The Qur'an names Jews and Christians *ahl al-kitāb*, the People of the Book, and the shelf is an iconography of that kinship; the Qur'an's own principle, *lā ikrāha fī al-dīn*, "there is no compulsion in religion" (2:256), is the verse most directly opposed to Carnegie's project. The film's moment gives the shelf a precise contemporary resonance. On 13 October 2007, a hundred and thirty-eight Muslim scholars and clerics published an open letter to the leaders of the Christian churches, "A Common Word Between Us and You," taking its title from the Qur'anic invitation to the People of the Book to come to a common word (3:64), and proposing the twin commandments of love of God and love of neighbour as the ground shared by both scriptures. The letter followed the controversy provoked by Pope Benedict XVI's lecture at Regensburg in September 2006. The ethical reduction Eli reaches in Day Six, the whole of scripture hanging on love of the neighbour, is the grammar of that letter, and the shelf is its material form.

The shelf also raises the question that Agamben's *Profanations* (2005) poses to every museum. To consecrate, in Roman law, was to remove a thing from human use into the sphere of the gods; to profane was to restore it to common use. The museum, Agamben argues, is the secular form of consecration, the exhibition of what can no longer be used. The printed Bible on the Alcatraz shelf is suspended between the two: museified, a specimen beside other specimens, and profaned, in Agamben's positive sense, by the press that has made it reproducible and so available to anyone. Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) recalled that the archive takes its name from the *arkheion*, the house of the *archons*, the magistrates who held and interpreted official documents, and that *arkhē* names both commencement and commandment. The library of the ancient world was a *Mouseion*, the precinct of the Muses at Alexandria, and its burning became the type of every later catastrophe of the archive: the House of Wisdom at Baghdad, destroyed when the Mongol army of Hülegü sacked the city in 1258; the National and University Library of Bosnia and Herzegovina at Sarajevo, set ablaze with incendiary shells on the night of 25–26 August 1992 by the Bosnian Serb forces besieging the city, which destroyed most of its collection, three months after the same forces had burned the manuscripts of Sarajevo's Oriental Institute; the National Library and Archives of Iraq, looted and burned in April 2003, as Baghdad fell to the US-led invasion, by arsonists never conclusively identified, while the occupying forces left it unguarded. None of these was an accident. Each had agents, and at Sarajevo the agents chose the libraries as targets. Alcatraz is the *Mouseion* after the last burning. Whether it becomes a new *arkheion*, a house of magistrates, depends on what happens to the book on its shelf and to the woman on the road.

7.5

The Mantle and the Letter

The book goes to the shelf; the mantle goes to the road. When Elijah first called his successor, he found Elisha "plowing with twelve yoke of oxen before him" and "cast his mantle upon him" (1 Kings 19:19). Elisha was a ploughman, the type of the boy that driveth the plough to whom Tyndale vowed to give the scripture (Day Two). At the Jordan, before Elijah is taken up, Elisha asks for "a double portion of thy spirit" (2 Kings 2:9), and Elijah sets a condition: "if thou see me when I am taken from thee, it shall be so unto thee" (2:10). A chariot of fire and horses of fire part them, Elijah goes up by a whirlwind into heaven, "And Elisha saw it, and he cried, My father, my father" (2:12): the turning of the heart of the child to the father that Malachi assigned to Elijah (Day Four). Elisha takes up the fallen mantle, strikes the waters of the Jordan, and asks, "Where is the LORD God of Elijah?" and the waters part (2:13–14). Fire, water, sight, and the mantle: the succession narrative contains the film's elements in their final configuration. The double portion is conditioned on sight. Solara, who is sighted, is with Eli at the end; she inherits his gear, his blade, and his dark glasses, and puts them on. She takes the insignia of blindness while keeping her sight; her double portion is sight joined to the discipline of the blind. And she takes no book. The scripture stays in the archive; she goes out with the way.

The division is the film's answer to the Pauline sentence that has shadowed this thesis: "the letter killeth, but the spirit giveth life" (2 Corinthians 3:6). The letter is kept on the shelf, where no sovereign can wield it, because it is held in a house that rules nothing and printed in copies no one can monopolize. The spirit goes out on the road, where it can impose nothing, because it carries no letter to impose. Neither abolishes the other. The settlement must be distinguished from the most influential medieval attempt to separate letter and spirit. Joachim of Fiore (d. 1202) divided history into three states: of the Father under the law, of the Son under the letter of the Gospel, and of the Spirit, a coming age of contemplative freedom in which the letter would yield to a spiritual understanding, the "everlasting gospel" of Revelation 14:6. Radical Franciscans adopted the prophecy, and Gerard of Borgo San Donnino's *Introduction to the Eternal Gospel* (1254) was condemned in 1255. Bonaventure's *Collationes in Hexaemeron*, whose form this thesis has borrowed, answered Joachimism by keeping Christ, and with him the scriptural letter, at the centre of history; Joseph Ratzinger's habilitation thesis on Bonaventure's theology of history (published 1959) reconstructed that answer, and its author was the reigning pope when *The Book of Eli* was released. Eric Voegelin's *The New Science of Politics* (1952) traced the totalitarian movements of the twentieth century to secularized Joachimite eschatologies, attempts to immanentize the eschaton by founding the third age within history. The film's division of letter and spirit is anti-Joachimite in Bonaventure's sense. Solara's road is not a third age that abolishes the letter: the letter stays on the shelf, and the spirit walks.

The film's last words, spoken in Eli's voice, are Pauline: a modern rendering of 2 Timothy

4:7, in which Paul has fought the good fight, finished the race, and kept the faith, where the Authorized Version has him finish "my course." Day Two noted the apparent contradiction between a film that arrives at what Nietzsche called the evangelical practice and a closing sentence from the apostle Nietzsche held responsible for converting that practice into doctrine. The contradiction dissolves on inspection. The verse contains no doctrine. Its *course*, *dromos*, is a race and a road; its verb for keeping, *tetērēka*, is a verb of guarding and custody. The same epistle charges Timothy to keep "that good thing which was committed unto thee" (1:14), the *parathēkē*, the deposit; and in the same chapter as Eli's last words, the apostle, a prisoner awaiting death, asks for two things: "The cloke that I left at Troas with Carpus, when thou comest, bring with thee, and the books, but especially the parchments" (4:13). The cloak and the books: the film's final distribution, the coat to Solara and the book to the shelf, is prefigured in the chapter from which it takes its last sentence. Whether 2 Timothy was written by Paul or, as most critical scholarship holds, by a disciple writing in his name, it is, like the Authorized Version and like the film, a composite text, and the question of authorship with which this thesis began returns at its close as a custodian's farewell. Paul in a Roman prison, Boethius awaiting execution at Pavia, Bunyan in Bedford gaol, Gramsci in the prisons of Fascist Italy, Malcolm X at Norfolk: the prison has been one of the great scriptoria of the West, and Eli dies in one.

The day on which this happens is the seventh, and the chapter's title makes a claim that must be stated. The first thing scripture sanctifies is neither a place nor an object but a day: "God blessed the seventh day, and sanctified it" (Genesis 2:3). Abraham Joshua Heschel's *The Sabbath* (1951) called it a palace in time and argued that biblical religion sanctifies time before space; the film's resolution moves holiness the same way, from the auratic object, captured and illegible in Carnegie's hands, to the completed work and the life that follows it. Deuteronomy gives the Sabbath a second ground that bears on Carnegie directly. Where Exodus grounds it in creation, Deuteronomy grounds it in the memory of bondage: the manservant, the maidservant, the ox, and the stranger are to rest, "And remember that thou wast a servant in the land of Egypt" (Deuteronomy 5:14–15). The Sabbath is scripture's earliest limit on a master's claim to another's time. Carnegie's town, which runs on water, coercion, and the search for the book, knows no rest. Eli, having finished the dictation, rests from all his work, and dies. "There remaineth therefore a rest to the people of God" (Hebrews 4:9).

7.6

Franciscan Coda: The Canticle of the Creatures

The city across the water from Eli's deathbed bears the name of Francis of Assisi, whose mission, San Francisco de Asís, was founded on the bay in 1776, and the name carries a history the coda must state before it praises. The Franciscan missions of Alta California baptized the Ohlone and other Native peoples of the region and then required them to live

and labour at the missions; those who left could be pursued and brought back by soldiers, and were flogged; and thousands died there, chiefly of diseases the colonists brought, many of them buried in the mission's own cemetery. The coincidence completes the film's elemental argument with a precision no screenplay could have planned. In the winter of 1224–25, after receiving the stigmata on La Verna, Francis lay in a dark cell at San Damiano, nearly blind from a disease of the eyes that made daylight agony to him, and composed in the Umbrian vernacular the *Canticle of the Creatures*, among the earliest monuments of Italian literature. The man who could not bear the sun praised it first: "Praised be you, my Lord, with all your creatures, especially Sir Brother Sun, who is the day, and through whom you give us light; and he is beautiful and radiant with great splendour; of you, Most High, he bears the likeness." He praised "Sister Water, who is very useful and humble and precious and chaste," and "Brother Fire, through whom you light the night." When his physicians resolved to cauterize his temples to treat his eyes, Francis, according to Thomas of Celano, addressed the glowing iron as Brother Fire and asked it to be courteous to him, and afterwards said he had felt no pain. And in his last days, in 1226, he added a stanza praising "our Sister Bodily Death, from whom no living man can escape."

Every element of the film's agon is reconciled in this poem. The sun that destroyed the world is praised as the bearer of God's likeness by a man who could not look at it; the water that a tyrant monopolized is a humble sister, owned by no one; the fire that burned the world is the brother who lights the night; and death, which the film has dealt in abundance, is a sister to be welcomed. The Canticle is the liturgy of aphotic revelation: the praise of light by one who lives in darkness. The poem reconciles what the mission did not: Francis's praise of creatures owned by no one was carried to this bay by an order that held the land and labour of its converts in tutelage.

The Franciscan tradition contributes, finally, the juridical concept the conclusion requires. In the controversy over apostolic poverty the Franciscans maintained that they had the use of things (*usus*) without their ownership (*dominium*). Bonaventure defended the distinction in his *Apologia pauperum* (1269); Pope John XXII repudiated it in the bulls *Ad conditorem canonum* (1322) and *Cum inter nonnullos* (1323), declaring heretical the claim that Christ and the apostles owned nothing; William of Ockham answered the pope in his *Opus nonaginta dierum* (c. 1332). Agamben's *The Highest Poverty* (2011) read the Franciscan rule as an attempt to live a form of life outside the law of property altogether. Eli had the use of the book for thirty years and never claimed its ownership; Carnegie wanted only its *dominium*. On that distinction the film's final covenant is founded. The distinction also cuts against this thesis. The California missions were Franciscan custody without formal dominium: by colonial theory the friars held the mission lands in trust for their converts until the converts should be judged ready to receive them, a readiness never declared before secularization in the 1830s passed the lands, for the most part, to others. Custody without ownership can itself be a form of rule.

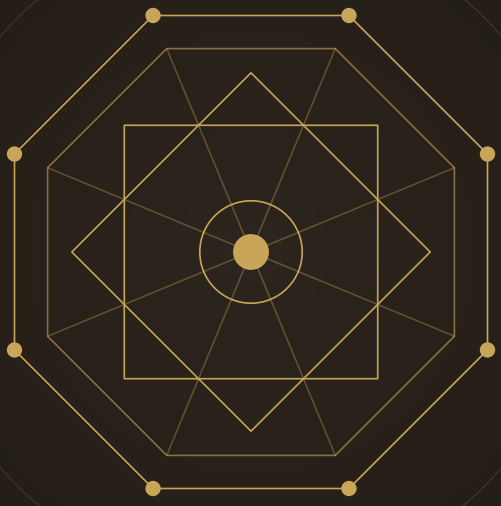


FIGURE 17

The Canticle reconciled

Francis composed the *Canticle of the Creatures* in the winter of 1224–25, nearly blind, praising first the sun he could not bear to look at. Day Seven's coda reads it as the liturgy of aphotic revelation: each element of the film's agon received as kin.

THE EIGHTH DAY



Octava Dies

Toward an Anarchival Covenant

... the sabbath which I have made, in the which, when I have set all things at rest, I will make the beginning of the eighth day which is the beginning of another world.

EPISTLE OF BARNABAS 15.8 (TRANS. J.B. LIGHTFOOT)

8.1

The Week and Its Remainder

The early Church counted beyond seven. The Epistle of Barnabas, probably written around the turn of the second century and often assigned to Alexandria, has God reject the sabbaths of the present age in favour of the sabbath on which, having brought all things to rest, he will make the beginning of an eighth day, the beginning of another world; "wherefore also we keep the eighth day for rejoicing, in the which also Jesus rose from the dead" (15.8–9). Justin Martyr found the eighth day prefigured in circumcision on the eighth day after birth and in the eight souls saved in Noah's ark (*Dialogue with Trypho* 41, 138), a figure the First Epistle of Peter had already read as a type of baptism: "eight souls were saved by water. The like figure whereunto even baptism doth also now save us" (1 Peter 3:20–21). The Greek for "the like figure" is *antitypos*, the vocabulary of Day Seven's press. Baptisteries were built as octagons for this reason, and the inscription traditionally attributed to Ambrose for the baptistery of Santa Tecla at Milan explains that it was fitting for the hall of holy baptism to rise in the number by which true salvation returned to the peoples. Augustine closes *The City of God* (XXII.30) on the eighth day: the seventh will be our sabbath, whose end will be not an evening but the Lord's day, an eighth and eternal day, on which *vacabimus et videbimus, videbimus et amabimus, amabimus et laudabimus*, we shall rest and see, see and love, love and praise.

The eighth day is the proper name of the post-apocalyptic condition as the film conceives it. It is not the end, the seventh day on which the work is finished; nor the eternal return of the first day, the regeneration of time by cosmogonic repetition that Eliade described; nor Vico's *ricorso*, the cycle beginning again. It is a first day that remembers the week: a commencement that comes after completion and carries completion's memory into what begins. Eli's dictation opens with "In the beginning," but it is spoken after the end, and every word of it is charged with the knowledge of the fire. The eighth day is Genesis recited by a survivor.

8.2

The Sixfold Passage of the Word

The argument of the preceding chapters can now be stated as a single movement. The Word passes through six media, each of which places it beyond the reach of a form of power that the preceding medium could not escape.

Read as a sequence, the six stations constitute a progressive divestiture of sovereignty from the Word. The voice cannot be possessed; the tactile script cannot be read by the sighted sovereign; the memorized text cannot be taken from its bearer except by killing him, which destroys it; the printed text cannot be monopolized once it exists in many copies; the archived text is kept by an institution that governs nothing; and the road carries the text's practice

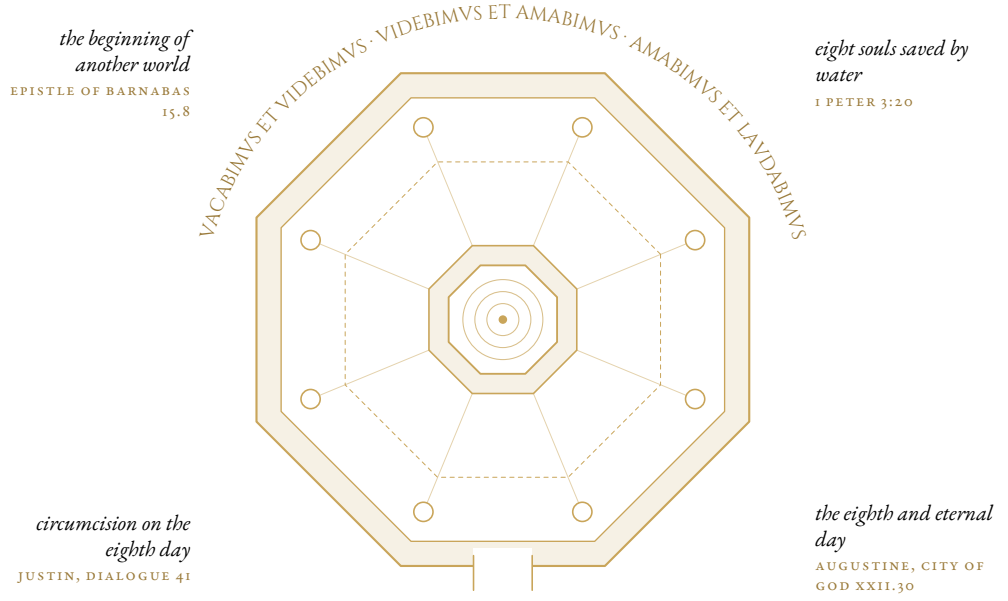


FIGURE 18

Octava dies

The eighth day as architecture: an octagonal baptistery, built in the number "by which true salvation returned to the peoples," ringed with the close of Augustine's *City of God*: *vacabimus et videbimus, videbimus et amabimus, amabimus et laudabimus*, we shall rest and see, see and love, love and praise.

without its letter. At no station does the Word acquire the form Carnegie sought, that of a single, sovereign, legible instrument in the hands of one ruler. This is the precise sense in which the film's scripture survives its own instrumentalization: not by being shielded from power, which is impossible in a world of force, but by passing, at each moment of danger, into a medium in which it cannot serve power.

8.3

The Anarchival Covenant

I propose to call the settlement toward which the film moves an *anarchival covenant*, and to define it by five theses.

The first is custody without dominium. The covenant distinguishes the use of the sacred from its ownership, in the sense of the Franciscan *usus* defended by Bonaventure and recovered by Agamben. Eli held the book for thirty years without claiming it, gave it up to save a life, and at the end gave its contents to an archive that does not own them either, since it prints them for anyone. Carnegie's sin is not that he wanted the book but that he wanted

	STATION	MEDIUM	BEARER	SCRIPTURAL TYPE	WHAT THE MEDIUM WITHHOLDS	TREATED IN
	*Phonē*	The voice in the ruins	Eli as hearer	1 Samuel 3; 1 Kings 19:12; 2 Esdras 14:38	It cannot be seized as an object	Days One, Five
	Haptic *grammē*	The braille codex	Eli's hand	Deuteronomy 6:8; Barbier's night writing	It cannot be read by sight	Days One, Five
	*Mnēmē*	Memory	Eli's body	Jeremiah 31:33; 2 Corinthians 3:3; Ezekiel 3:1–3	It cannot be taken without being destroyed	Day Six
	*Typos*	Print	Lombardi's press	Jeremiah 36:32; Romans 5:14	It cannot be monopolized once multiplied	Day Seven
	*Archeion*	The shelf	The Alcatraz archive	2 Esdras 14:45; Lessing's rings	It is held, but not wielded	Day Seven
	*Hodos*	The road	Solara	1 Kings 19:19; 2 Kings 2:13–14; Acts 9:2	It carries no letter to impose	Days Three, Seven

TABLE 1

The sixfold passage of the Word

Each station places the Word beyond the reach of a form of power that the preceding medium could not escape: at no station does it take the form Carnegie sought.

to own the Word. Day Seven's coda adds the condition this thesis requires: custody protects only when what the custodian holds is a text and not persons. The California missions held their converts' land and labour in a trust that never ended, and tutelage over persons is dominium under another name. The covenant's custody is of a text, and it ends, as Eli's ended, in release.

The second is publication without sovereignty. The command given to Ezra in 2 Esdras, to publish "openly, that the worthy and unworthy may read it" (14:45), is the covenant's charter, and the exact negation of Carnegie's project, which required that no one but its master be able to read the book. The anarchival covenant keeps no secret seventy. It does not decide who is worthy to read.

The third is the right of refusal. The covenant protects the reader's potentiality not to read, the Bartlebyan act by which Claudia stopped Carnegie's theocracy at the threshold of its realization, and the katechontic act by which Eli withheld the book from the sovereign as long as he could. A scripture that its readers can refuse cannot be made an instrument of rule.

The fourth is the plurality of the shelf, together with its critique. The covenant places the restored scripture beside the scriptures of others, without adjudication, in the manner of Lessing's rings and of the common word of 2007. But it must also acknowledge what the shelf excludes. The island on which the shelf stands held Hopi men prisoner in 1895 for refusing to surrender their children to schools that taught the book and punished their

languages, and its occupiers of 1969 proposed a centre for the memory of peoples whose traditions were never written in books; an anarchival covenant worthy of its island would keep a place for what is not a book: song, oral tradition, ceremony, the land itself. The shelf of the peoples of the book is the beginning of the archive, not its completion.

The fifth is commencement without commandment. Derrida observed that *arkhē* names both the beginning and the rule. The anarchival covenant keeps the first and renounces the second: it preserves "In the beginning" while refusing every claim to govern in its name. The biblical warrant for the renunciation is ancient. When the Israelites offered Gideon the crown, he answered, "I will not rule over you, neither shall my son rule over you: the LORD shall rule over you" (Judges 8:23); and when the people demanded of Samuel a king "like all the nations," the prophet who as a boy had answered the voice in the temple warned them that the king would take their sons, their daughters, their fields, and the tenth of their flocks, "and ye shall be his servants" (1 Samuel 8:17). Martin Buber's *Kingship of God* (1932) read these texts as testimony to an early Israelite theopolitics that acknowledged no human sovereign, and Jacques Ellul's *Anarchy and Christianity* (1988) drew from them a Christian anarchism. Levinas, in *Otherwise than Being* (1974), used *anarchy* in a sense prior to politics, for a responsibility that precedes every principle and origin; Reiner Schürmann's *Heidegger on Being and Acting: From Principles to Anarchy* (1982) described the withering of the epochal principles by which ages have governed themselves. The anarchival covenant is not Tolstoy's Christian non-resistance (*The Kingdom of God Is Within You*, 1894), since its founding figure carried a sword. It is the covenant of an armed prophet who refused to found a state: the custody of a beginning by those who will not rule in its name.

8.4

Through a Glass, Darkly

The film keeps the chapter Thurman's grandmother kept. Eli's confession, that he guarded the book and failed to live by it, is a gloss on the thirteenth chapter of First Corinthians: "though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, and have not charity, I am nothing" (13:2). Eli had a faith that carried him across a continent for thirty years, and by his own account lacked charity. The chapter goes on to subordinate to charity everything else the film has prized: "Charity never faileth: but whether there be prophecies, they shall fail; whether there be tongues, they shall cease; whether there be knowledge, it shall vanish away" (13:8). Prophecy, speech, and knowledge, the voice, the dictation, and the archive, are among the things that pass; the book itself is among them. "And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity" (13:13). The word the Authorized Version uses was itself the object of a struggle over scriptural authority. Tyndale rendered *agapē* as "love"; Thomas More, in his *Dialogue Concerning Heresies* (1529), attacked that rendering, together with Tyndale's "congregation" for *ekklēsia* and "elder" for *presbyteros*, as a subversion of the

Church's authority; the King James translators chose "charity." Even the name of love in Eli's book bears the mark of the conflict between the sovereign's scripture and the ploughboy's.

The same chapter contains the verse that names the epistemic condition of aphotic revelation: "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known" (13:12). The Greek is *di' esoptrou en ainigmati*, through a mirror, in a riddle. The braille scribe, Day Five showed, always writes in mirror image, as if through a glass; Solara walks out at the end wearing a dead man's dark glasses. The verse defines aphotic revelation and fixes its limit. It is the mode of the *now*, the time that remains between the burning and the face. It is not the abolition of vision but its eschatological deferral: the Christian hope the film inherits ends, as Augustine's eighth day ends, in *videbimus*, we shall see. "We walk by faith, not by sight" (2 Corinthians 5:7) describes a road, not a destination. The thesis of aphotic revelation is therefore not an anti-ocular absolutism. It holds that, after a catastrophe of light, the Word must pass through darkness and be carried by touch, hearing, and memory; that while it is so carried it cannot become an instrument of the gaze or of the sovereign; and that the light toward which it travels is promised, not possessed.

The thesis must also name its remainder. *The Book of Eli* is an action film, and its ethics of the neighbour are carried by a protagonist who kills many men. On the night of his arrest Jesus told his disciples that whoever had no sword should sell his garment and buy one, and when they produced two swords answered, "It is enough" (Luke 22:36–38); medieval political theology drew from those two swords its doctrine of the two powers, from Pope Gelasius I's letter to the emperor Anastasius (494) to Boniface VIII's *Unam sanctam* (1302). The film gives its heir both the garment and the sword. The anarchival covenant, as the film imagines it, does not resolve the question of violence; it inherits it. That the custodian of the Word must be armed in a world of killers is the film's realism; that the armed custodian must refuse to rule is its hope. Between the two lies a question the film leaves to its heir, and this thesis to its reader.

8.5

Into Life

The film ends where Genesis begins, and the thesis must end there too: with a beginning. The scripture is on the shelf; the dead man lies on the island of the pelicans; and the young woman who inherited his mantle walks out through the gate of the archive onto the continent the flash destroyed. Franz Rosenzweig's *The Star of Redemption* (1921), drafted in large part on military postcards sent home from the Balkan front, ends with a section called "Gate," and with the prophet's summary of what is required of a human being: "to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with thy God" (Micah 6:8). Its last words are *ins Leben*, into life. Micah's requirement is a walk. The book has been carried, dictated, printed, and shelved; its last station is not a page but a gait. The Word that passed through voice, hand, memory,

type, and archive leaves through the gate in the one form no sovereign can seize, because it is no longer a thing to be possessed but a way to be walked: the form of a life. On the eighth day it goes out of the gate, into life.

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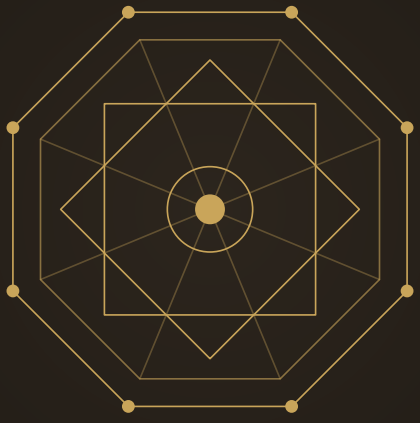
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KEYWORDS

The Book of Eli; Gary Whitta; Albert and Allen Hughes; post-apocalyptic cinema; nuclear criticism; aphotic revelation; apocalypse and *apokalypsis*; ocularcentrism; haptic hermeneutics; Braille; blindness and revelation; Molyneux's problem; George Berkeley; political theology; katechon; Carl Schmitt; Giorgio Agamben; the remnant; messianic time; Malachi 4; Elijah and Elisha; Eli of Shiloh; Ezra and 4 Ezra 14; Pauline hermeneutics; "the letter killeth"; New Covenant (Jeremiah 31:33); scriptural sovereignty; Hobbes's *Leviathan*; Spinoza's *Tractatus Theologico-Politicus*; Rousseau's Legislator; Machiavelli's armed prophet; the Grand Inquisitor; hydraulic despotism; Karl Wittfogel; hegemony and ideological state apparatuses; King James Version and the Authorized Version; William Tyndale; the Slave Bible; trope of the Talking Book; African American prophetic tradition; Howard Thurman; disability studies; narrative prosthesis; John M. Hull; Levinasian ethics; the face; the Good Samaritan; Hillel; Kierkegaard; cannibalism and the Eucharist; Freud's *Totem and Taboo*; archive and *arkheion*; Derrida's *Archive Fever*; *Memoirs of the Blind*; Plato's *Phaedrus* and the *pharmakon*; orality and literacy; Walter Ong; Friedrich Kittler; media archaeology; Charles Barbier's night writing; Gutenberg and print culture; Walter Benjamin; "The Storyteller"; mechanical reproducibility; Alcatraz; the 1969 Alcatraz occupation; Lessing's ring parable; *ahl al-kitāb*; post-secularism; profanation and museification; Bunyan's *The Pilgrim's Progress*; *A Canticle for Leibowitz*; *Fahrenheit 451*; *The Road*; *The Name of the Rose*; *Children of Men*; *Stalker*; *Dune*; the Western and the samurai film; Zatoichi; frontier thesis; Manifest Destiny; Psalm 23; hexaemeron; Bonaventure; St. Francis and the Canticle of the Sun; the eighth day; mytheme of scriptural restitution; New King James Version; Book of Mormon; scriptural supplement; Böckenförde dilemma; weapons of the weak; Jorge of Burgos; the Sabbath; Hagar and womanist theology; Black liberation theology; Homestead strike; Franciscan missions of California; Hopi prisoners of 1895; destruction of libraries; anarchival covenant.



into life